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Attitudes Towards Social Risks and Social Protection in the United Kingdom

Insights from the OECD Risks that Matter Survey

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Foreword

The OECD Risks that Matter programme (https://oe.cd/rtm) is a key output from the 2018 OECD Social Policy Ministerial in Montréal, Canada. OECD Ministers called on the OECD to provide evidence that helps them better understand the social risks that people face, both real and perceived, and what people expect from their governments and social protection. In line with these goals, the OECD launched the Risks that Matter (RTM) programme, under the supervision of the Employment, Labour and Social Affairs Committee (ELSAC) and the Working Party on Social Policy (WPSP).

The OECD Risks that Matter Survey is the only regular cross-national survey focused on tracking people's perceptions of the social and economic risks they face, how well they think their government addresses those risks, and what preferences they have for social protection going forward. Conducted every two years, the latest rounds of the survey cover 27 OECD countries spread across Europe, East Asia, and North and South America.

This report is the latest output from the Risks that Matter programme. In addition to dedicated main findings reports, key outputs from the programme include thematic Risks that Matter reports on issues including gender, youth and the costs of living, as well as country and region Risks That Matter studies, including on France and on Latin America. Data from OECD Risks that Matter have also been used as background in other OECD reports, and as indicators in OECD databases. As with all these outputs, the overarching goal of this report is to help governments better understand and respond to the lives lived by their citizens, to help ensure economic security, opportunities and growth.

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Executive summary

Public expenditure on social supports in the United Kingdom declined considerably in the years leading up to 2020, reflecting efforts to limit public spending following the global financial crisis and through the 2010s. Although social spending rose briefly during the COVID-19 pandemic, it remained lower than in the early-2010s, both in absolute terms and as a percentage of gross domestic product.

Where do people in the United Kingdom want social protection to go from here? This report examines public perceptions of social protection and attitudes towards the future of social policy in the United Kingdom. Using data from the late-2022 round of the OECD Risks That Matter (RTM) survey, it explores perceptions of economic risks, satisfaction with public services and benefits, and whether and where people want government to spend more going forward.

People in the United Kingdom express strong concerns about economic risks

Many people in the United Kingdom feel relatively vulnerable to social and economic risks and want more government support, especially in comparison to people in other G7 countries and northern Europe. Results indicate that people in the United Kingdom are often more concerned about a range of short- and longer-term risks – such as job loss, the possibility of falling ill, and access to healthcare, housing, education, and long-term care – than people elsewhere, especially after adjusting for cross-country differences in population composition. As in other countries, young people, women, and lower-income groups report the highest levels of concern.

These risk perceptions are mirrored in concerns about social protection. In the United Kingdom, as in most other OECD countries, respondents have mixed feelings about public services and benefits. Only a minority believe they could easily access benefits if needed, and confidence in government-provided income support in the event of financial emergencies is low. Overall, satisfaction with social programmes is lower in the United Kingdom than in some of the UK's G7 peers, like Canada and the United States, though the UK's satisfaction is higher than in countries like Italy and France. Perceptions of injustice and abuse within the benefits system are also comparatively mild in the United Kingdom. This is consistent with evidence elsewhere suggesting that attitudes towards benefit recipients have softened in the United Kingdom in recent years.

There is strong support in the United Kingdom for an expansion of social protection

Looking ahead, results from RTM suggest demand for greater social protections. Over three-quarters of UK respondents call for the government to do more to secure their social and economic well-being – a rate higher than in most other G7 countries. Health care is the highest priority for increased spending. Concerns about the availability of quality healthcare services are widespread, with 71% of UK respondents feeling at least somewhat concerned about their ability to access good care in the next year or two. These demands are accompanied by a willingness to pay: despite already representing the largest area of public social

spending, over three-quarters of UK respondents say they would like the government to spend more on healthcare. Over half indicate they would be willing to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes for better healthcare services.

Pensions and long-term care are also important issues, although a lower priority than healthcare. Unemployment supports come bottom of the priority list for people in the United Kingdom, even as the United Kingdom spends comparatively little on unemployment benefits relative to other countries.

There is appetite in the United Kingdom for more progressive taxes and transfers. Two-thirds of UK respondents call for increased taxes on the rich to better support the poor, one of the highest levels of support among OECD countries. Notably, and unlike in most other OECD countries, demands for progressive taxation and spending are just as strong among high earners and the highly educated as for people with lower incomes and less education. Results from RTM are consistent with evidence from UK sources showing that attitudes have been shifting recently in favour of progressive taxation and spending.

Economic and policy factors likely influence demand for greater support in the United Kingdom

Why are people in the United Kingdom currently more likely to call for support than peers elsewhere? The RTM survey cannot provide causal evidence on country differences in attitudes and preferences for social programmes, but country comparisons point to a few factors that may help explain why attitudes differ cross-nationally.

The size and shape of current social protection is one factor likely influencing public attitudes. Links between current policy and attitudes towards future policy are complex, but results from RTM suggest that countries with more expansive social protection systems see lower levels of concern about social risks, less dissatisfaction with social programmes, and lower calls for increased support and spending from government. In some (but not all) cases, attitudes and preferences in specific policy areas are also linked to policy structure and design. Confidence in income support following job loss tends to be higher in countries where unemployment benefits are more generous, for instance, as does confidence in old-age income support in countries with more generous pensions.

For the United Kingdom, there is evidence to suggest that demand for spending and redistribution may have grown as a response to cuts to social programmes over the past decade and a half. However, even in the absence of cuts, respondents in a country with a mid-sized, tightly targeted social protection system like the UK's might be expected to express a relatively strong preference for expanded government support.

Economic factors and social preferences likely play a role, too. Economic development is one potential driver, with respondents in wealthier countries often expressing fewer concerns about risks and greater satisfaction with social programmes than respondents in poorer countries. (Perceived) economic inequality is another: calls for increased spending on social policies and increased taxes on the rich tend to be stronger in countries where people express stronger concerns about income inequality. Income inequality is comparatively high in the United Kingdom, although public concern about inequality is moderate.

Economic security and economic shocks matter, as well. As well as shaping preferences at the individual level, countries with larger numbers of respondents who report a deterioration in their household finances in the past year also have larger numbers calling for increased taxes on the rich to support the poor. The United Kingdom notably has a large share of RTM respondents who report that their household finances have weakened in the past year, suggesting another factor behind its comparatively strong calls for more social protection.

1 Introduction and overview

This chapter provides an introduction and overview of the report, offering policy background to the report, an overview of the United Kingdom's approach to social protection and a sketch of recent trends in social spending. The remainder highlights key findings from the report's three main chapters. Overall, results point to a population in the United Kingdom that have comparatively strong concerns about social risks and would like the government to spend more on social policies.

By 2022, the United Kingdom was feeling the effects of a decade of falling social spending. Never one of the OECD's largest spenders on social programmes, UK social expenditure had fallen over the previous decade as successive governments looked to rebalance public budgets in the wake of the financial crisis. In real terms, on the eve of the pandemic in 2019, per head spending on social issues was close to USD 1 000 lower than at its peak in 2012. Even at the height of the pandemic it remained lower than in the early 2010s both in Dollar terms and as a share of GDP (OECD, 2024[1]).

Going forward, some level of change to the UK welfare state is inevitable. Estimates by the Office for Budget Responsibility (OBR), the UK's independent fiscal institution, indicate that spending on social benefits is set to rise as a share of GDP even in the absence of major policy change, largely due to demographics and an expected increase in incapacity benefit claimants (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2024[2]). Other planned or in-progress reforms, such as the expansion of government-funded childcare, rolling out from Spring 2024, could also raise social spending. Still, the exact shape and size of UK social protection remains at least partially up for discussion.

Where do people in the United Kingdom want social protection to go from here? Are they happy with what they currently receive from government? Would they like social supports to be scaled back further, or might they prefer an expansion of support, even if it means increased taxes or cuts to government spending elsewhere? And how do these preferences vary across groups?

This report examines public perceptions of social protection and attitudes towards the future of social policy in the United Kingdom. Drawing on data from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 (Box 1.1), a multi-country survey on perceptions of social protection systems and social policy preferences, it examines the strength of concerns in the United Kingdom about social and economic risks, and which risks worry them the most (Chapter 2). It also asks how satisfied people are with their access to public services and benefits, as well as their confidence in government income support should they lose their income (Chapter 3), and whether and where they would like more government spending in future (Chapter 4). Details on the data and methods used throughout the report are given in Annex A.

Results suggest that people in the United Kingdom share relatively strong concerns about social and economic risks, especially in comparison to their peers in several G7 countries (e.g. Canada, Germany, the United States) and other wealthy OECD economies (e.g. Denmark, Norway, the Netherlands), and are largely dissatisfied with social protection. In the United Kingdom, as also in many other OECD countries, many people feel that public benefits are both insufficient and hard to access, and few believe the government would provide adequate income support should they lose their income. Looking to the future, there is strong support for an expansion of social protection. Many say they would like the government to increase spending on social policies, with healthcare (including long-term care) the highest priority. Two-thirds think that the rich should be taxed more to help support the poor.

Box 1.1. The OECD Risks that Matter survey

The OECD Risks that Matter (RTM) survey is a cross-national survey examining people's perceptions of the social and economic risks they face, how well they think their government addresses those risks, and what preferences they have for social protection going forward. This is the most extensive global survey of perceptions of, and preferences for, social protection.

The RTM survey builds and expands on standard data sources like administrative records and labour force surveys, which provide more traditional data on issues such as people's labour force participation and earnings, their health status, and their level of education. The RTM microdata cover a majority of OECD countries and are updated every two years. Existing cross-national surveys in the area of perceptions of risk, including certain rounds of the International Social Survey Programme or the

European Commission's Eurobarometer survey, are conducted less frequently and/or only in specific regions.

The first RTM survey was conducted in spring and autumn of 2018, covering 18-70 year-olds in 21 countries. The second wave ran in September-October 2020, covering 18-64 year-olds in 25 OECD countries, and the third wave – presented here – was fielded in October-December 2022, covering 18-64 year-olds from 27 countries. The countries participating in the 2022 wave are Austria, Belgium, Canada, Chile, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Korea, Latvia, Lithuania, Mexico, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Slovenia, Spain, Switzerland, Türkiye, the United Kingdom and the United States. Member countries opt in to participate.

The questionnaire was developed by the OECD Secretariat in collaboration with OECD member country Delegates and stakeholders participating in an advisory group workshop in April 2022, and subsequently translated into national languages.

RTM uses non-probability samples recruited via the Internet and over the phone, and respondents take part in the survey online. The sampling criteria is based on quotas for gender, age group, education level, income level, and employment status. Survey weights are used to correct for under- or over-representation based on these five criteria. The target and weighted sample is 1 000 respondents per country. Respondents are paid a nominal sum of around one to two euros. The survey contractor is Bilendi Ltd (formerly Respondi Ltd).

RTM is overseen by the OECD Employment, Labour and Social Affairs Committee (ELSAC) and managed in the OECD Directorate for Employment, Labour and Social Affairs. Financial support for the 2022 survey was provided through voluntary contributions by participating OECD member countries, and specific modules were funded by the OECD Centre for Well-Being, Inclusion, Sustainability and Equal Opportunity (WISE), Kings College London, and the University of Stavanger.

The UK approach to social protection

The scope and design of social protection differs considerably across OECD countries (Esping-Andersen, 1990[3]; Castles and Mitchell, 1992[4]; Danforth, 2014[5]). Some countries, such as the Nordic countries, provide expansive protection, often in the form of universal benefit and service provision, and usually in tandem with strong active employment supports that encourage labour participation. Others (e.g. Germany) operate social insurance-based systems with entitlements more tightly linked to previous employment and earnings, or market-based systems (e.g. the United States) that emphasise self-sufficiency through employment and provide benefits only on a comparatively targeted basis.

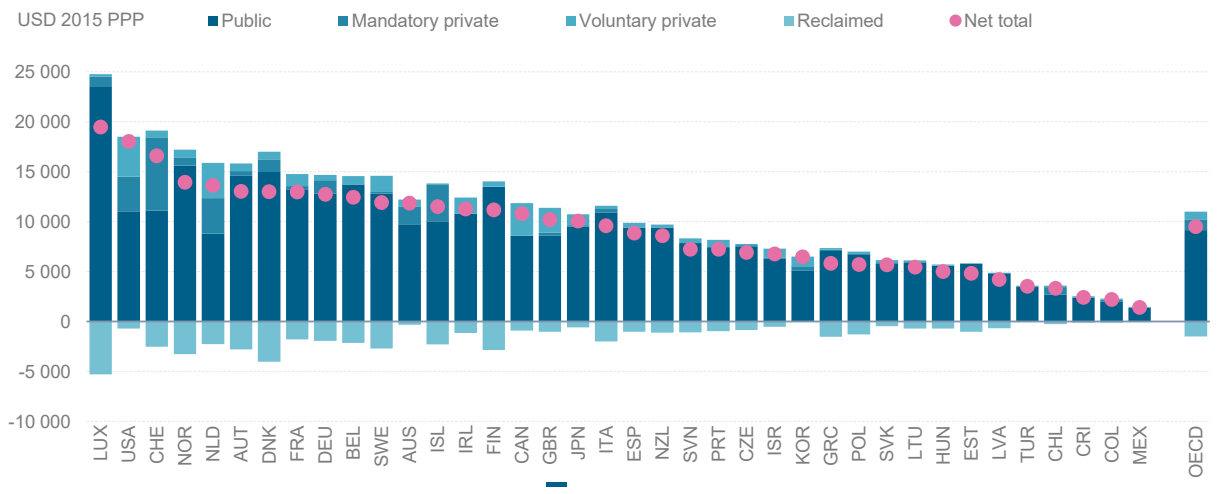
The United Kingdom, like other Anglophone OECD countries, runs a largely market-based social protection system. Individual responsibility is encouraged, with public support provided mostly through targeted (often means-tested) social assistance programmes. The main exception is the UK's universal public healthcare service (the National Health Service, or NHS), which in both eligibility and financing resembles a Nordic-style public service (Bambra, 2007[6]). Contribution-based entitlements make up a small and declining share of the working-age benefit mix (Brewer and Murphy, 2023[7]), and unlike many other OECD countries, especially in Europe, benefit payment rates are rarely linked to past earnings (Timmins, 2023[8]; OECD, 2024[9]). Many working-age benefits come with strong activation requirements in the form of job-search and earnings-increase commitments.

Compared to other OECD countries, the United Kingdom spends moderate amounts on social protection (Figure 1.1). At USD (2015) 8 600 per person (or 19.5% of GDP) in 2019, public social expenditure is close to the OECD average (USD 9 100 per person), though this average includes less wealthy OECD countries like Chile, Mexico and Türkiye. The UK's spending is well below the levels seen in countries with the most

expansive public systems, like Denmark (USD 15 000 per person) and Norway (USD 15 600 per person), as well as France (USD 13 200 per person) and Germany (USD 12 800 per person). Mandatory private social expenditure, a major source of social spending in countries such as Switzerland and the United States (OECD, 2023[10]), plays only a minor role in the United Kingdom (USD 270 per person). Voluntary private social expenditure is more important (USD 2 500 per person), with occupational pension schemes a major component of the old-age pension system (see below). Total net social expenditure, which accounts for both public and private social expenditure plus any amounts reclaimed through taxes paid by benefit recipients, comes to USD 10 200, slightly above the OECD-wide average (USD 9 500). Among the G7 group of major economies, only Japan (USD 10 100) and Italy (USD 9 600) spend less.

Figure 1.1. Total net social expenditure in the United Kingdom is slightly above the OECD-wide average but lower than in most other G7 countries

Social expenditure per capita (public, mandatory private, and voluntary private), expenditure reclaimed through the tax system, and net total social expenditure per capita, USD 2015 PPP, 2019

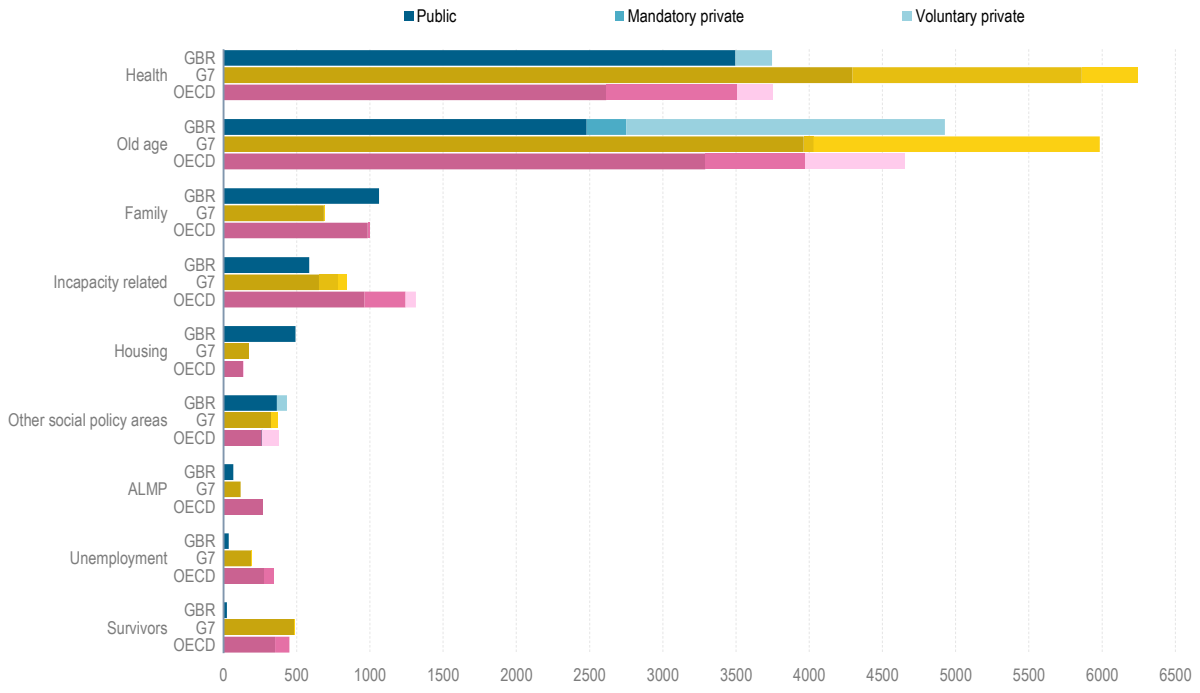


Note: Private social expenditure refers to social benefits delivered through the private sector which involve an element of compulsion, inter-personal redistribution or fiscal support for participation. It can be mandatory (stipulated by law) or voluntary. Examples of mandatory private social expenditure include compulsory private health insurance, pension benefits based on compulsory contributions, and sickness payments to employees by employers. Examples of voluntary private social expenditure includes pension benefits based on past voluntary contributions, employer-provided childcare support, and benefits provided by charitable non-government organisations (NGOs). "Reclaimed" expenditure refers to the direct and indirect taxes paid by recipients of public/private benefits.
Source: OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

As in many other OECD countries, healthcare and pensions dominate UK social spending (Figure 1.2). At just under USD (2015) 3 500 per person in 2019, health is by far the largest public social spending item. The vast majority of this spending runs through the NHS, with small amounts directed to related bodies such as the UK Health Security Agency, the UK's public health body (Harker, 2019[11]). Public spending on old-age support is lower at USD 2 500 per person, but this is complemented by substantial voluntary private spending (USD 2 200 per person). The latter is made up in almost equal amounts by public- and private sector occupational pension spending (both USD 1 100 per person) and represents the fourth highest level of voluntary private social spending on pensions in the OECD, after only Canada, the Netherlands, and the United States (OECD, 2024[1]). Overall, on both health and old age support, total UK social spending (including public, mandatory private and voluntary private spending) is similar to the OECD average but well below the average across the G7.

Figure 1.2. As in many other OECD countries, healthcare and pensions dominate UK social spending

Social expenditure per capita by branch, public, mandatory private and voluntary private, the United Kingdom, G7 total and OECD total, USD 2015 PPP, 2019



Note: Branches are sorted by the level of public and mandatory private expenditure per capita in the United Kingdom. "ALMP" refers to Active Labour Market Programmes. See Adema and Fron (2019[12]) for details on the scope and coverage of each branch. G7 refers to the weighted average across the seven members of the G7 group of major economies.
Source: OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

One area in which the United Kingdom stands out is in the comparatively small amounts spent on unemployment support (Figure 1.2). At USD (2015 PPP) 35 per person in 2019, public spending on unemployment in the United Kingdom is the fourth lowest in the OECD, less than a fifth of the G7 average, and not much more than a tenth of the OECD average. UK unemployment benefits are low by international standards and replace a comparatively small share of earnings for most workers (OECD, 2024[13]), in large part because payments are flat-rate rather than earnings-related (Brewer and Murphy, 2023[7]). One of the two major unemployment benefits, income-based Jobseeker's Allowance, is also being phased out, with qualifying new claimants now instead entitled to a more general means-tested income-support benefit through the Universal Credit programme.

Like many (but not all) OECD countries, the UK's public benefit system is aimed mostly towards lower income groups. In some OECD countries (e.g. Greece, Italy, Spain), high income groups are the main beneficiaries of public support. In these systems, benefits are closely linked to past earnings and there are large gaps in protection for low-income groups (OECD, 2022[14]). In others, benefit receipt is more evenly spread across the income distribution (e.g. France, Japan, the United States), or concentrated strictly on the poorest (e.g. Australia, Finland, New Zealand). In the United Kingdom, sharp means tests and the widespread use of flat-rate payments mean that lower-income groups are the main recipients of public benefits: the poorest fifth of the UK population receives about one-third (32.7%) of cash transfers to working-age households, well above the OECD average of just under one-quarter (23.4%), while the richest fifth receive just 6% (OECD, 2019[15]).

Overall, the UK's social protection system does a moderate amount to reduce poverty and hardship and produces comparatively moderate final poverty rates. Income poverty reflects both the distribution of market income and the effectiveness of policy efforts to redistribute that income. In the United Kingdom, relative income poverty rates fall by 16.9 percentage points (from 28.6% to 11.7%) after accounting for the taxes paid and benefits received by households (OECD, 2024[16]). This is similar to the OECD average (16.2 percentage points, from 27.6% to 11.4%). As in many countries, the elderly population (65+ year-olds) faces the highest poverty risk (14.5%), but only just, and poverty rates are generally similar across age groups. The child (0- to 17-year-old) poverty rate (12.7%) sits slightly above the OECD average (12.2%).

UK social spending has fallen over the past decade and a half

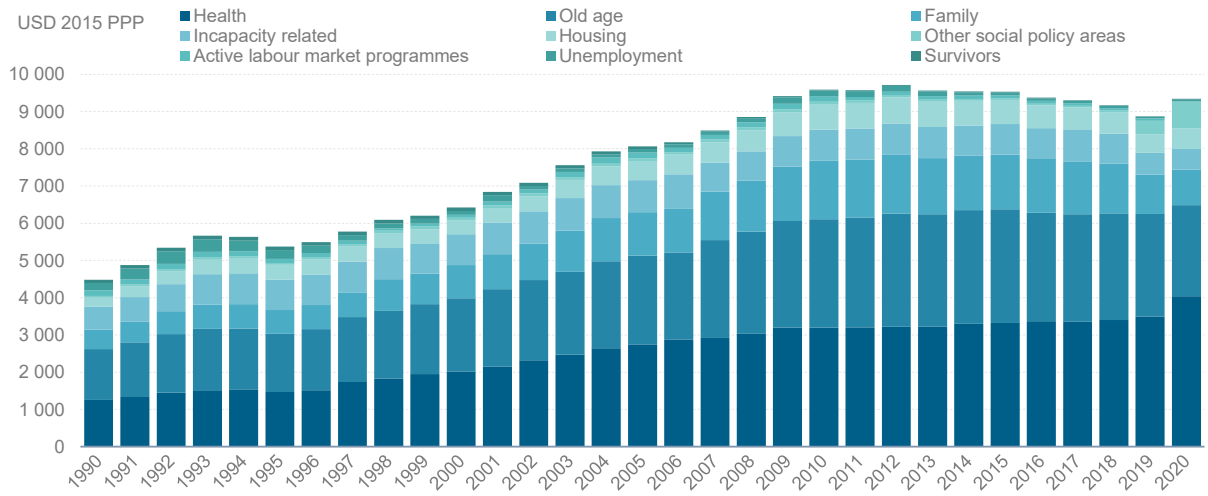
Social protection systems are not fixed, and governments can and do make real changes to the way their systems operate. In the United Kingdom, cuts to many social programmes and rising conditionality in the benefit system mean that social spending has fallen over the past decade and a half (Figure 1.3). Having more than doubled between the early 1990s and late 2000s, total public and mandatory private spending plateaued in real terms in the years following of the financial crisis and fell for seven years straight through the 2010s. By 2019, spending per head was about 8.5% (or USD 840) lower than at its peak in 2012. Spending jumped in 2020 but this was due almost entirely to COVID-19-related increases in health spending. UK-only figures show that per household spending on social benefits ("welfare"), which excludes healthcare and some other public social services, remained lower in 2022-23 than a decade earlier than in 2013-14 (DWP, 2024[17]).

The United Kingdom is one of only a few OECD countries that saw real terms decreases to social spending over the 2010s. In Dollar terms, only three OECD countries (Greece, Ireland and the United Kingdom) spent less per head on social issues in 2019 than they did in 2010; as a percentage of GDP, only Hungary and Ireland saw social spending fall by more (OECD, 2024[1]). Moreover, by historical standards, the decline in social spending coincided with a period of sustained high taxation in the UK, even if the tax burden remained below the OECD average throughout (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2023[18]). Tax as a share of GDP has and is forecast to continue rise through the 2020s, due in large part to freezes to income tax thresholds (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2024[2]).

Except for healthcare, few areas of UK social spending have escaped real-terms cuts since the early 2010s (Figure 1.3). Spending on families has fallen the most, following the introduction of the High Income Child Benefit Charge (HICBC), a tax charge that applies to Child Benefit recipients, or their partners, who have an adjusted net income of GBP 60 000 or more.[1] Spending on old-age support has notably fallen too. Drivers include a decline in spending on housing benefits for people over state pension age due to increasing home ownership, and a decline in means-tested income support for pensioners (pension credit) due to growth in pensioner income (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2024[19]). From an accounting perspective, there has also been a reallocation of funds towards "other social policy areas" as Universal Credit, a general means-tested income-support programme, has taken on an increasingly important role in benefit provision.

Figure 1.3. UK social spending fell between the early 2010s and the start of the pandemic

Social expenditure per capita (public and mandatory private) by branch, the United Kingdom, USD 2015 PPP, 1990-2020



Note: Private social expenditure refers to social benefits delivered through the private sector which involve an element of compulsion, inter-personal redistribution or fiscal support for participation. It can be mandatory (stipulated by law) or voluntary. Examples of mandatory private social expenditure include compulsory private health insurance, pension benefits based on compulsory contributions, and sickness payments to employees by employers.
Source: OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

Looking to the future, 2019 is likely to represent a recent low-water mark for UK social spending. Forecasts by the OBR suggest that even without major changes to policy, spending on social benefits will rise by about 1 percentage point as a share of GDP before the end of the decade (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2024[2]). The main reasons are increased pension spending due to an ageing population and expected increases in incapacity benefit claimants. Spending on families is likely to increase from 2024, partly because of the expansion of the government-funded childcare scheme, but also because of increases in the earnings threshold above which the tax charge is applied to Child Benefit recipients or their partners. While not yet set, health spending can also be expected to increase in real terms, as it has been the case historically (Harker, 2019[11]; The Health Foundation, 2023[20]).

People in the United Kingdom express comparatively strong concerns about social risks and want the government to spend more on social policies

Against this background, results from OECD Risks That Matter suggest that many people in the United Kingdom feel relatively vulnerable to social risks and often want more government support, especially compared to people in comparable peers in the G7 group of major economies.

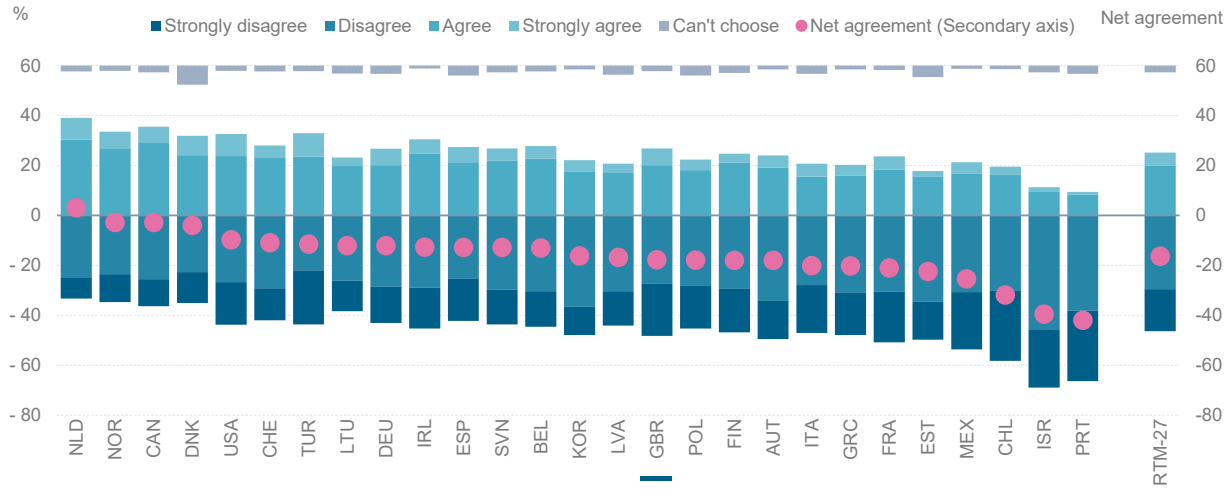
OECD Risks That Matter asks people how worried they are about a range of short- and longer-term social and economic risks, such as job loss and the possibility of falling ill, as well as their access to healthcare, housing, education, and long-term care. Results suggest that people in the United Kingdom are often more concerned about these things than people in many other OECD countries (Chapter 2). UK respondents to Risks That Matter express stronger average concerns than their counterparts in several other G7 countries, including France, Germany, and the United States, as well as some of the OECD's wealthiest economies, like Denmark, Norway and Switzerland. Concerns in the United Kingdom are

especially strong after adjusting for differences between countries in the composition of the population: on a like-for-like basis, people in the United Kingdom express stronger concerns about social risks over the next year or two than people in all countries covered other than Chile, Greece and Spain. As elsewhere in the OECD, concerns about social risks in the United Kingdom are stronger among women, parents, and those on lower incomes. Unlike most other OECD countries, concerns fall rather than grow with age: in the United Kingdom, as in a few other English-speaking countries, it is young people who are most concerned about their futures.

The concerns expressed by UK respondents about social and economic risks are mirrored in their (lack of) confidence in current social protection (Chapter 3). Similar to many elsewhere, UK respondents have mixed feelings about public service access but little confidence in public benefits and income support. Only a minority believe they could "easily" receive public benefits if they needed them (Figure 1.4). Overall, dissatisfaction with public benefits and services is stronger in the United Kingdom than in some of the UK's G7 peers, especially Canada and the United States, as well as several OECD countries with more extensive social protection systems, such as the Netherlands, Norway, and Switzerland. However, dissatisfaction is lower in the United Kingdom than in Italy and, most notably, France – a major spender on social protection, albeit one with a population that tends to be strongly critical of the state and the future direction of their country (Senik, 2014[21]). As in other OECD countries, dissatisfaction with public benefits and services tends to be stronger among women and older respondents, and especially among people who report that their household finances have worsened over the past year. This echoes research elsewhere suggesting that economic shocks can play an important role in shaping attitudes towards the state and social policy (Blekesaune, 2013[22]; Margalit, 2013[23]; Hacker, Rehm and Schlesinger, 2013[24]).

Figure 1.4. Only a minority of people in the United Kingdom believe they could easily receive public benefits if they needed them

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement?… I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



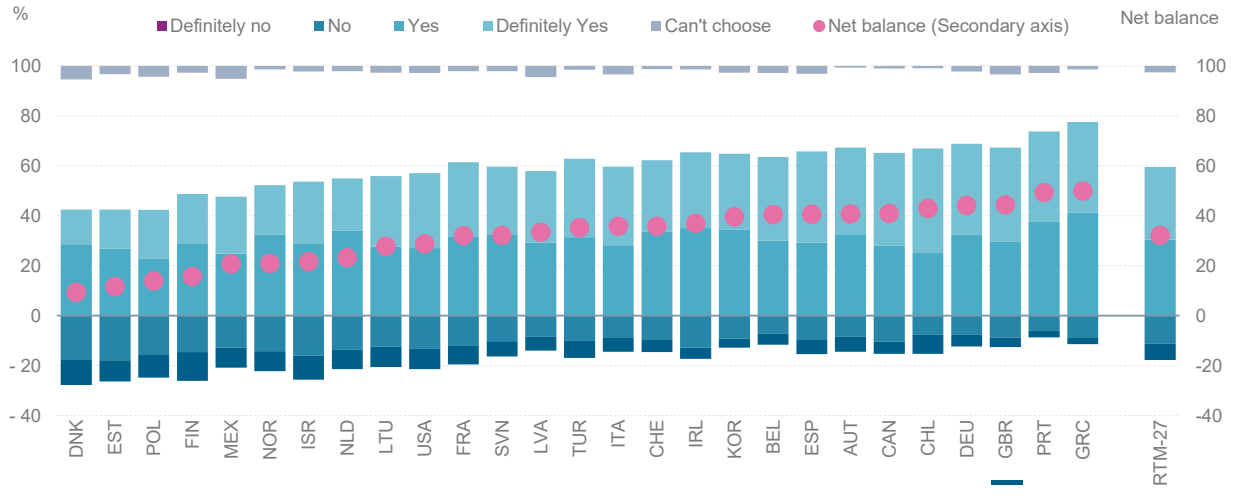
Note: Net agreement is calculated as the weighted sum of the shares responding "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Chapter 3 for more details.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Feelings of injustice and abuse in benefit receipt are comparatively mild in the United Kingdom (Chapter 3). Like people in many other OECD countries, many in the United Kingdom believe that they do not receive their fair share of public benefits and that others receive benefits they do not deserve. However, these feelings are less common in the United Kingdom than in several other OECD countries, most notably again, Italy and France. This is consistent with evidence from UK sources, which shows that attitudes towards benefit recipients, previously very hard, have softened markedly in the past decade or so (Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[25]).

Looking forward, many people in the United Kingdom want more from government (Chapter 4). Just over three-quarters of UK respondents to Risks That Matter say that the government should be doing more to secure their economic and social well-being – higher than in most other G7 countries. Large numbers say that the government should increase spending on social policies, even when reminded about the taxes they might have to pay. Even larger numbers favour increased redistribution, with the United Kingdom having the third strongest level of support for increasing taxes on the rich in order to support the poor (Figure 1.5). Calls for additional support are understandably larger among people exposed to economic insecurity, measured as those reporting that their household finances have worsened over the past year. However, in the United Kingdom unlike in most other OECD countries, demands for spending and redistribution are just as strong, if not stronger, among people with high education or high incomes than for people with less education or lower incomes. Overall, results from OECD Risks That Matter are consistent with evidence from UK sources, which show that attitudes have been shifting in favour of taxation, spending, and redistribution for about a decade or so (Curtice, 2021[26]; Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[27]; Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[25]).

Figure 1.5. A comparatively large share of people in the United Kingdom would like the government to tax the rich more to support the poor

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Net balance is calculated as the weighted sum of the shares responding "Definitely no" (-100), "No" (-50), "Neutral" (0), "Yes" (50) and "Definitely yes" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Chapter 4 for more details.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Health care is the priority area for many in the United Kingdom

Drilling down to specific policy areas, healthcare is the priority for many in the United Kingdom. A recent report based on the British Social Attitudes survey found that satisfaction with the UK National Health Service is at its lowest level in 40 years (Jefferies et al., 2024[28]). Results from OECD Risks That Matter suggest that while people in the United Kingdom are no less satisfied with their access to healthcare than with other public services (Chapter 3), many are concerned about the availability of "good quality" healthcare services going forward (Chapter 2). Indeed, 71% of UK respondents to OECD Risks That Matter report feeling at least somewhat concerned about their ability to access good-quality healthcare over the next year or two – the eighth highest share among covered OECD countries. These concerns are mirrored in their preferences for future spending, even at the risk of higher taxes and social contributions (Chapter 4). Despite already representing the largest area of public social spending (see above), just over three-quarters of UK respondents say they would like the government to spend more on healthcare, even after being reminded about the taxes they pay. As many as half say they'd be prepared to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes for better healthcare services.

Pensions are also an important issue, although not to the same extent as healthcare. Finances in old age are the most cited concern for UK respondents when they are asked to think about risks that stretch beyond the next ten years (Chapter 2) and, as in many other OECD countries, only a minority believe that the government will provide adequate income support on their retirement (Chapter 3). However, support for increased government spending on pensions is markedly lower than support for spending on healthcare, and is also lower than in many other OECD countries: about two-thirds of UK respondents say they'd like the government to spend more on pensions, and just under one-third would be prepared to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes to get it (Chapter 4). This possibly reflects the comparatively moderate role played by the public pension system in the United Kingdom (see above), as well as the relatively widespread view that government is not solely responsible for pensioners' standards of living (Hadler, Eder and Mayer, 2019[29]).

Notably, unemployment supports come bottom of the priority list for people in the United Kingdom. As discussed earlier in this chapter, the United Kingdom spends comparatively little on unemployment benefits, and as in other areas, relatively few respondents to RTM have confidence in government income support in case of job loss (Chapter 3). However, only a minority of UK respondents support increased spending on unemployment benefits. Although having softened in recent years (Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[25]), many in the United Kingdom hold comparatively hard attitudes towards the unemployed with large numbers believing the government has comparatively little responsibility for ensuring the unemployed have access to a "reasonable" income (Applica sprl et al., 2020[30]; van Oorschot et al., 2022[31]).

The shape and size of UK social protection may be one factor feeding into current attitudes and preferences

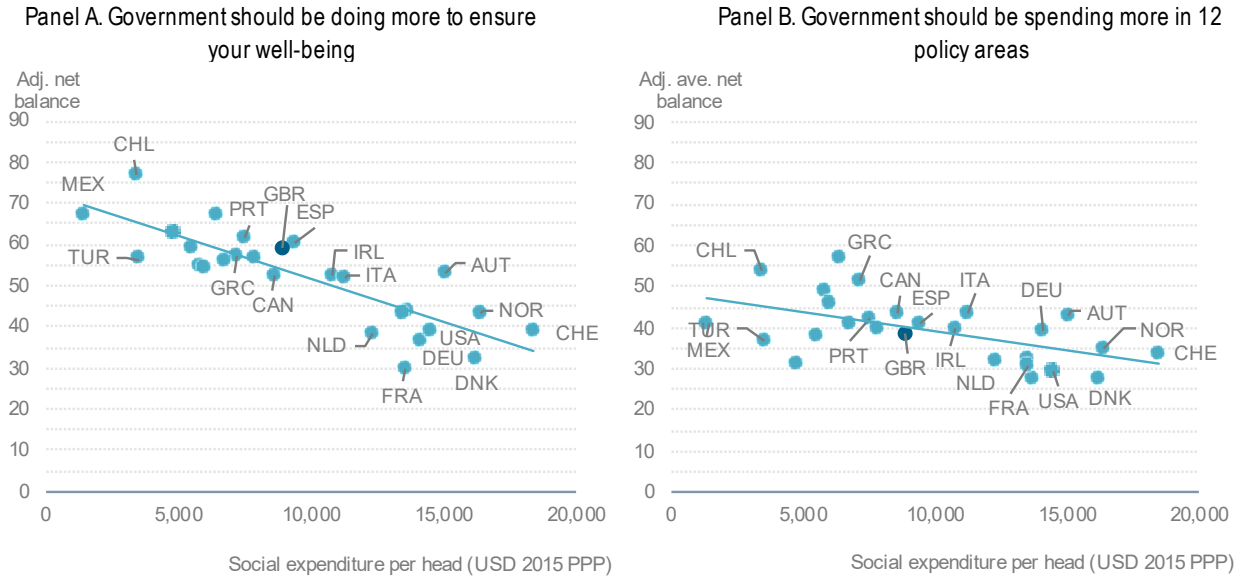
What shapes country differences in attitudes and preferences toward social policies? And why are people in the United Kingdom (currently) more likely to call for support than people in several of its peer countries? OECD Risks That Matter cannot provide causal evidence on the drivers of attitudes and preferences, and the number of countries covered by the survey (27) means it can be difficult to separate different possible influences. Nonetheless, country comparison points to a few factors that help explain why attitudes differ from one country to another.

Unsurprisingly, the size and shape of current social protection is one factor that might contribute to perceptions and attitudes. Links between current policy and attitudes towards future policy are known to be complex (Pierson, 1993[32]; Wlezien, 1995[33]; Busemeyer, Abrassart and Nezi, 2021[34]; van Oorschot et al., 2022[31]) but results from Risks That Matter suggest that to varying degrees, respondents in countries

with more expansive social protection systems are also less likely to express concern about social risks (Chapter 2), are less likely to report dissatisfaction with public benefits and services (Chapter 3), and are less likely to call for increased support and spending from government (Chapter 4). For example, even after controlling for population composition and GDP per capita, respondents in countries with higher social expenditure per head tend to call less strongly for additional government support (Figure 1.6, Panel A; r = -0.84) and, to a lesser extent, for increased spending on social policies (Figure 1.6, Panel B, r = -0.56). In some cases, attitudes and preferences in specific policy areas can also be linked to policy structure and design. Confidence in income support following job loss tends to be higher in countries where unemployment benefits are more generous, for instance, as does confidence in old-age income support in countries with more generous pensions (Chapter 3). However, attitudes do not always correspond to policy design. There are few clear links between policy indicators and satisfaction with public service access (Chapter 3), for example, while limited spending in a given policy area does not always lead to strong demands for more spending in that same area (Chapter 4).

Figure 1.6. People are less likely to call for additional spending when they live in countries that spend more on social issues

Social expenditure (public and mandatory private) per head (USD 2015 PPP), (adjusted) net balance of responses to the question "Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?", and (adjusted) average net balance of responses when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas



Note: Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. Social expenditure (public and mandatory private) per head is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. See Chapter 4 for more details.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

One complication is that it is sometimes difficult to separate the potential effects of social spending from other factors, especially economic development. The two are strongly correlated, with wealthier OECD countries often spending more on social issues than less wealthy countries, and one or both sometimes falls out of statistical significance when the two are put in the same statistical model (see Chapter 2, for example). However, social spending usually remains at least moderately correlated with

perceptions and attitudes even after controlling for economic development, and in several cases (e.g. confidence in government income support, calls for additional government support, calls for increased spending on social policies) links remain statistically significant.

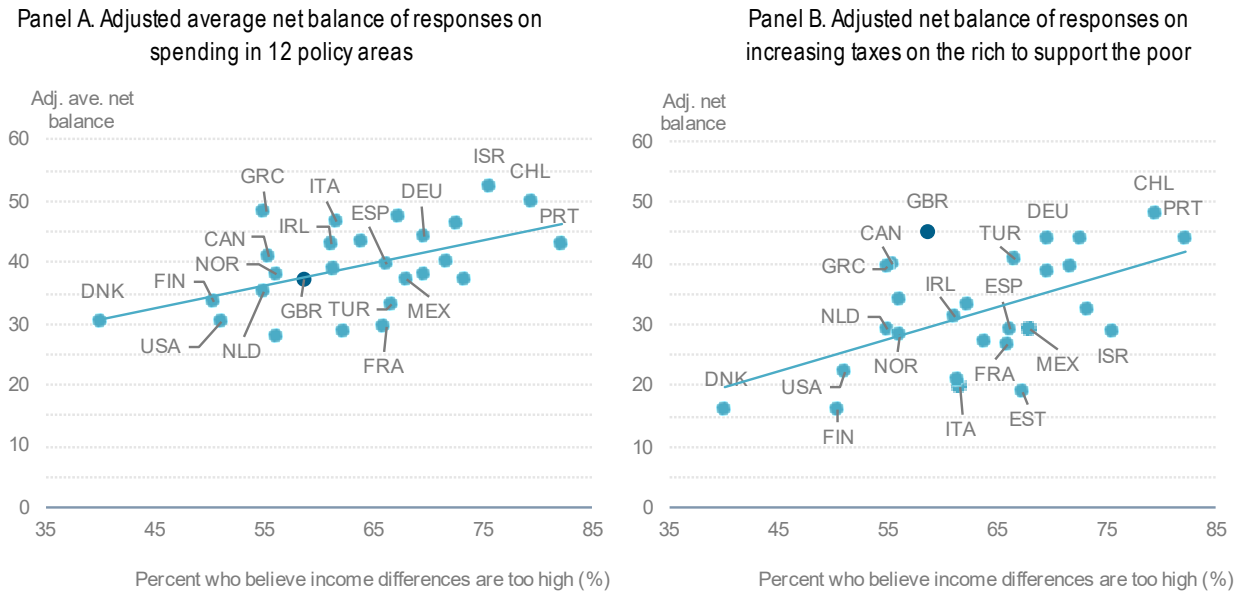
Current policy structures are likely to be one factor feeding into preferences and attitudes in the United Kingdom. As discussed in Chapter 4, evidence from the British Social Attitudes survey in particular suggests that demand for spending and redistribution has grown as a likely response to cuts to social programmes over the past decade and a half (Curtice, 2021[26]; Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[27]). More generally, even in the absence of recent cuts, respondents in a country with a mid-sized, tightly targeted system like the UK's (see earlier in this chapter) might be expected to express a relatively strong preference for expanded government support.

Economic development, economic inequality, and economic security may all also play a role in shaping attitudes and preferences

Away from policy, a range of additional economic and political factors are thought to play at least some role in attitudes and preferences for social protection (van Oorschot et al., 2022[31]; Mengel and Weidenholzer, 2023[35]). Related to the discussion above, economic development is one potential factor, with respondents in wealthier countries often expressing fewer concerns about social risks (Chapter 2) and greater satisfaction with benefits and services (Chapter 3) than respondents in less wealthy countries. Economic inequality (or rather, perceptions of economic inequality) is another: in line with recent OECD work on links between inequality and demand for redistribution (OECD, 2021[36]), calls for increased spending on social policies and increased taxes on the rich tend to be stronger in countries where people express stronger concerns about income inequality (Figure 1.7; r = 0.52 and 0.54; Chapter 4). Income inequality is comparatively high in the United Kingdom (OECD, 2024[16]) but concern about inequality (as measured by the share that believe differences in income are "too high") is only moderate. Economic security and the experience of economic shocks potentially matters too, at least for attitudes towards redistribution (Alesina and Giuliano, 2011[37]; Margalit, 2019[38]). As well as shaping preferences at the individual level, countries with larger numbers of respondents who report a deterioration in their household finances in the past year also have larger numbers calling for increased taxes on the rich to support the poor. The United Kingdom notably has a large share of respondents who report that their household finances have weakened in the past year, suggesting this could be one factor behind its comparatively strong calls for increased redistribution.

Figure 1.7. Calls for spending and redistribution are stronger in countries where people are more concerned about inequality

Percent who believe that differences in income are too high or far too high, (adjusted) average net balance of responses when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas, and (adjusted) net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?"



Note: Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). Concern about inequality is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. See Chapter 4 for more details.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD (2023[39]), "Working hand in hand? Exploring people's views of the role of different actors in fighting inequality", https://doi.org/10.1787/dbd54315-en.

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Notes

[1] HICBC increases gradually for those with adjusted net income between GBP 60 000 and GBP 80 000 and is equal to percentage of a family's Child Benefit for every GBP 200 of ANI that is over GBP 60 000 each year. Where adjusted net income exceeds GBP 80 000, the tax charge is equal to that individual's total Child Benefit.

2 What worries the United Kingdom?

This chapter examines perceptions of social and economic risks in the United Kingdom in comparison to other OECD countries. Drawing primarily on questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 about short- and long-term social risks, it explores the comparative level of concern in the United Kingdom and examines which risks most worry people in the United Kingdom. Results point to comparatively strong concerns in the United Kingdom, especially after adjusting for country differences in population composition. Health care and making ends meet top the worry list for people in the United Kingdom, as they do for people in most other OECD countries.

This chapter looks at perceptions of social and economic risk among people in the United Kingdom and how these perceptions compare to other OECD countries. The chapter draws primarily on two questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 on concerns about short- and long-term social risks, including job loss and the possibility of falling ill, as well as access to healthcare, housing, education, and long-term care (Box 2.1). It explores the level and degree of concern about social and economic risk in the United Kingdom, and examines which risks worry Brits the most.

Results point to a level of concern in the United Kingdom that is stronger than in many of its peer countries. Brits express stronger concerns about social and economic risks than people in most other G7 countries, including France, Germany, and the United States, and far stronger concerns than respondents in the OECD's best performers, like Denmark, Norway and Switzerland. Economic development might be one factor (the best-performing countries tend to be among the OECD's wealthiest), as might the breadth and depth of social protection (they tend also to run some of its most expansive social protection systems). UK concerns are particularly strong after adjusting for country differences in population composition: on a like-for-like basis, people in the United Kingdom express stronger concerns about short-term social risks than people in all covered OECD countries other than Chile, Greece and Spain.

Drilling down into specific issue areas, accessing healthcare and making ends meet top the worry list for people in the United Kingdom, as they also do for people in most other OECD countries. Just under three-quarters (72%) of UK respondents report feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about their ability to access good-quality healthcare over the next year or two – the eighth highest share among covered OECD countries, and a higher share than in most other G7 members – with 69% feeling similarly about paying expenses and making ends meet. However, concerns can differ across population groups. For example, housing is an important concern for young adults – much more so than for older age groups, with the age gap larger in the United Kingdom than in most other OECD countries.

Box 2.1. Questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 used in this chapter

This chapter is built around two main questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022. Both centre on respondents' risk perceptions and the extent to which they are concerned about a series of social risks. The first concentrates on "short-term" risks, defined as the next year or two:

- Thinking about the next year or two, how concerned are you about each of the following?
  - Becoming ill or disabled.
  - Losing a job or self-employment income.
  - Not being able to find/maintain adequate housing.
  - Not being able to pay all expenses and make ends meet.
  - Not being able to access good-quality childcare or education for your children (or young members of your family).
  - Not being able to access good-quality long-term care for elderly family members.
  - Not being able to access good-quality long-term care for young.
  - Being the victim of crime or violence.
  - Having to give up my job to care for children, elderly relatives, or relatives with illness or disability.
  - Accessing good-quality healthcare.

The second asks respondents to look further into the future and to think about risks stretching beyond the next ten years:

- Looking beyond the next ten years, how concerned are you about the following?
  - Not being as well-off and financially secure as your parents and/or that you had hoped to be.
  - Your children (or young members of your family) not being as well-off and financially secure as you are.
  - Becoming ill or disabled.
  - Not having the right skills and knowledge to work in a secure and well-paid job.
  - Not being financially secure in old age.
  - Not being able to find/maintain adequate housing.
  - Not being able to access good-quality long-term care for yourself.
  - Not being able to access good-quality long-term care for elderly family members.
  - Not being able to access good-quality long-term care for young or working-age family members with an illness or disability.
  - Accessing good-quality healthcare.

In both cases, respondents are provided with a set of closed response options. These are: 1. Not at all concerned; 2. Not so concerned; 3. Somewhat concerned; 4. Very concerned; 5. Can't choose/Not applicable.

Source: OECD (2023) OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022: Core Questionnaire, https://webfs.oecd.org/Els-com/RtM/OECD-Risks-That-Matter-2022-Core-Questionnaire.pdf.

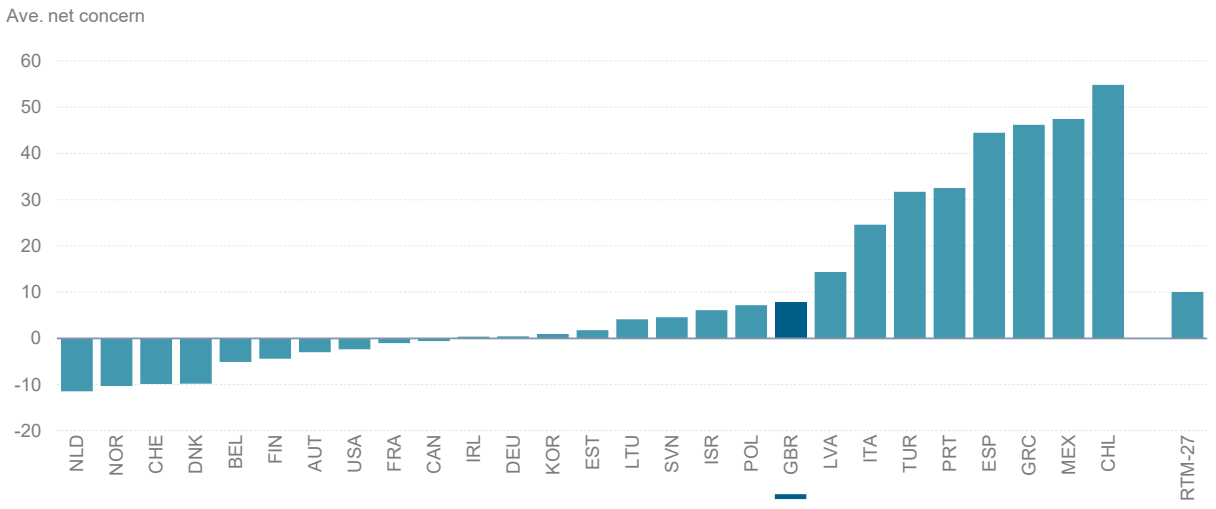
Respondents in the United Kingdom express stronger concerns about social and economic risks than respondents in many of its peer countries

Concerns about short-term risks are slightly below the OECD RTM average but stronger than in most other G7 countries

Worries about social and economic risks have spread widely in recent years. OECD Risks That Matter asks people how concerned they feel about a series of social and economic issues over the next year or two, including job loss and the possibility of falling ill, as well as their access to healthcare, housing, education, and long-term care (Box 2.1). Results point to strong concerns across many countries (Figure 2.1). Worries tend to be strongest in the OECD's less wealthy economies, such as Chile and Mexico, reflecting the day-to-day challenges faced by many in these countries. Concerns are less frequent, but still common, in members of the G7 group of advanced economies (Canada, France, Italy, Germany, the United States) and other wealthy OECD economies (e.g. Denmark, Norway, the Netherlands). Accessing healthcare and making ends meet are particularly frequent concerns in many countries, with an average of about two-thirds of respondents to Risks That Matter being at least "somewhat" concerned about both (OECD, 2023[1]).

Figure 2.1. UK concerns about short-term social risks are similar to the OECD average but stronger than in other covered members of the G7 except Italy

Average net concern across ten short-term social and economic risks, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net concern is based on a scale measuring average concern across a series of ten specified short-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Not at all concerned" for all ten items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Very concerned". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Respondents in the United Kingdom express concerns about social and economic risks that are stronger than in many similarly wealthy countries. Figure 2.1 shows average net concern across the ten short-term social and economic risks (see Box 2.1), with "net" referring to the balance of respondents expressing positive and negative concern. UK respondents feel overall more concerned than not about these short-term risks. At 8 points, average net concern in the United Kingdom is slightly lower than the OECD RTM average (10 points) and well below the levels seen in the most concerned countries like Mexico (47 points) and Chile (55 points), but higher than all other members of the G7 except Italy (25 points) and far higher than the best-performing countries like Switzerland (-10 points), Norway (-10 points), and the Netherlands (-11 points).

Health care and finances top the worry list for people in the United Kingdom

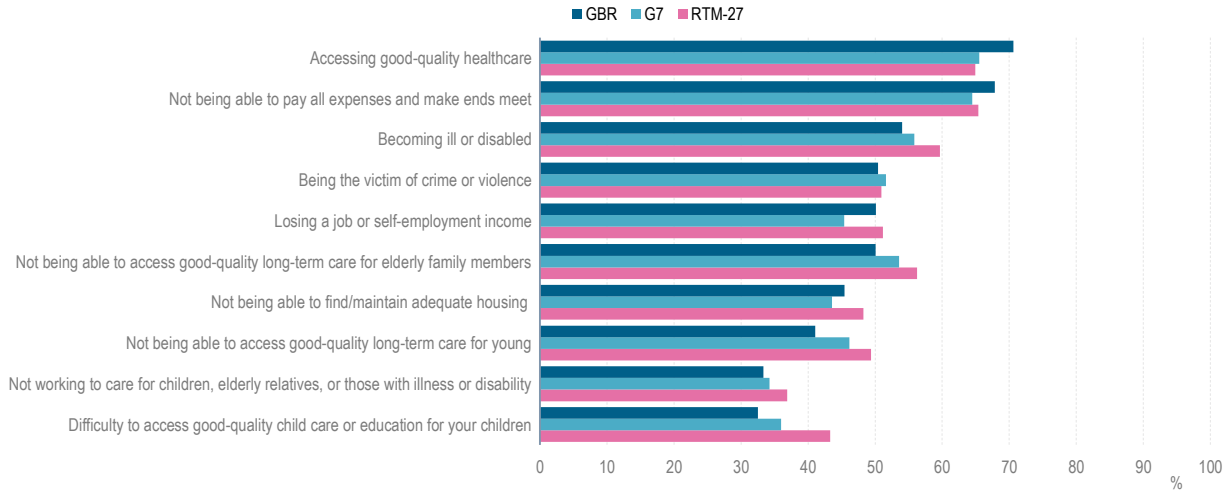
Drilling down to specific issue areas, healthcare and finances are the priority concerns for people in the United Kingdom, just as they are for people in many other OECD countries. Comparing across the ten short-term social and economic risks, accessing good-quality healthcare is the most frequent concern for respondents in the United Kingdom (Figure 2.2): 71% report feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about their ability to access good-quality healthcare over the next year or two, well above average average for both covered G7 and covered OECD countries (66% and 65%, respectively). Concerns about healthcare are followed closely by concerns about paying expenses and making ends meet (68%).

These top concerns – healthcare and finances – echo those highlighted by UK respondents in other data collections. For example, the UK ONS' Opinions and Lifestyle Survey regularly finds that the National Health Service (NHS) and the cost of living are the most frequently cited "important issues facing the UK today" (ONS, 2024[2]). Polling data from both Ipsos and YouGov point similarly to healthcare and the

economy as priority concerns for many in the United Kingdom (Ipsos, 2022[3]; YouGov, 2024[4]), as also does the OECD Survey on Drivers of Trust in Public Institutions (Trust Survey) (OECD, 2024[5]). Evidence from both Risks That Matter and elsewhere suggests that concerns around the economy may have peaked around the time of the RTM fieldwork and have likely eased since (Box 2.2).

Figure 2.2. Health care is the most common short-term concern for UK respondents, followed closely by making ends meet

Percentage of respondents who report being somewhat or very concerned by each risk over the next year or two, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies. See Box 2.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Except for issues relating to healthcare and finances, UK respondents tend to be less concerned about short-term risks than the average across OECD RTM countries (Figure 2.2). In comparative terms, concerns around accessing long-term care services and childcare and education services for young family members are particularly infrequent – the latter perhaps surprising, given that childcare is more expensive in the United Kingdom than anywhere else in the OECD (OECD, 2023[6]). Some issue areas remain important for certain subgroups, such as housing for young people (Box 2.3). However, for the general population, issues relating to healthcare and financial and economic security dominate short-term concerns.

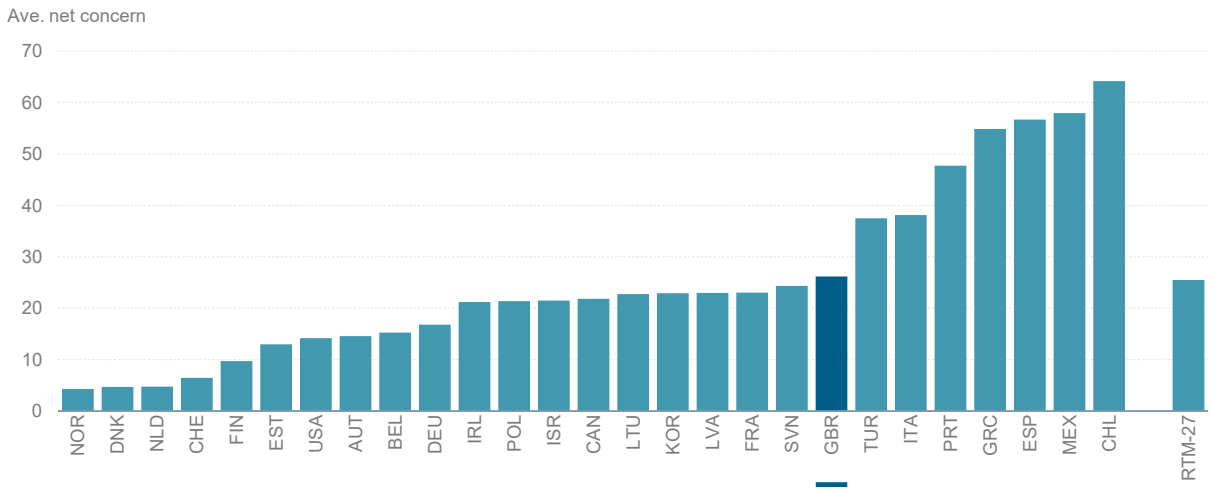
Concerns about long-term risks are strong in the United Kingdom, with healthcare and finances again top of the list

As well as short-term concerns, OECD Risks That Matter asks respondents how worried they feel about a series of ten longer-term social and economic risks – risks that might stretch further into the future, beyond the next ten years or so. Concerns are again relatively widespread across countries, and on balance are generally stronger than concerns about short-term risks (Figure 2.3). UK concerns are again stronger than in many of its peer countries. At 26 points, average net concern in the United Kingdom is similar to the OECD RTM average (26 points) and below the most concerned countries (e.g. Mexico, Chile), but stronger

than in other G7 countries with the exception of Italy (38 points) and well above the best performers, like the Netherlands (5 points), Denmark (5 points) and Norway (4 points).

Figure 2.3. Average concerns about long-term risks are stronger in the United Kingdom than in countries like Germany and the United States

Average net concern across ten long-term social and economic risks, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

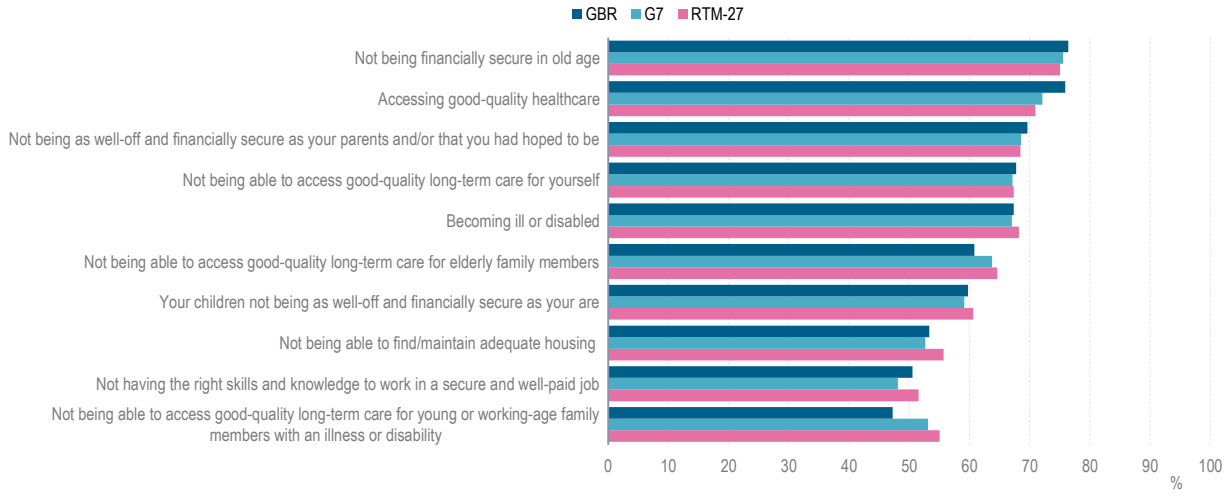


Note: Average net concern is based on a scale measuring average concern across a series of ten specified long-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Not at all concerned" for all ten items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Very concerned". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

As with the short term, issues relating to health and finances dominate UK long-term concerns. Financial security in old-age and accessing good-quality healthcare are the most frequently identified long-term concerns for UK respondents (Figure 2.4): just over three-quarters (76%) of UK respondents report feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about not being financially secure in old-age, and an almost identical number feel similarly about accessing good-quality healthcare. The next most commonly-cited long-term concern – "Not being as well-off and financially secure as your parents and/or that you had hoped to be" (70%) – also touches on issues relating to financial health and economic security.

Figure 2.4. Finances and healthcare dominate longer-term concerns

Percentage of respondents who report being somewhat or very concerned by each risk over the next ten years, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies. See Box 2.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

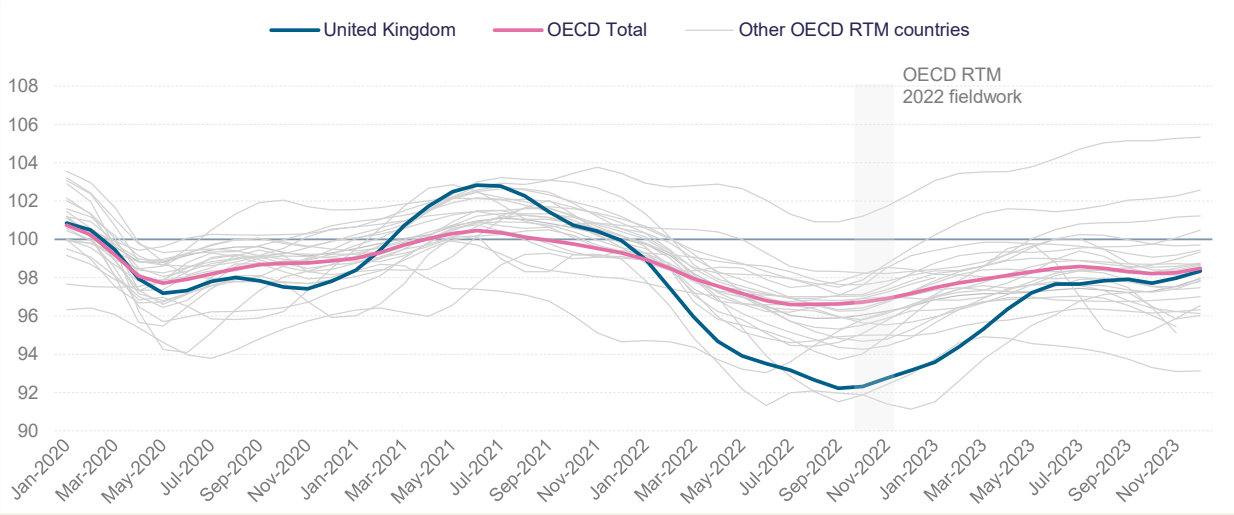
Box 2.2. Confidence in the UK economy fell sharply through late 2021 and 2022

The fallout from the COVID-19 crisis, Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine, and rising prices more generally meant that worries about economic security stretched wide when Risks That Matter went into the field in 2022 (OECD, 2023[1]), and few places more so than the United Kingdom. Results from Risks That Matter suggest that UK RTM respondents were more likely than respondents in most other countries to report that their household finances had deteriorated over the past year: as many as 50% of UK respondents reported that their finances were either "worse" or "much worse" than 12 months previous, compared to an average of just over 40% (OECD, 2023[1]). Similarly, when asked to think about prospects for their household finances and social and economic well-being over the next year or two, UK respondents reported stronger concerns than respondents in most other covered OECD countries: 82% of UK respondents reported feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about their prospects over the next couple of years, above the OECD RTM average of 75% (OECD, 2023[1]).

These strong economic security concerns are mirrored in other measures of UK economy- and finance-related sentiment from around the same time. For example, the UK's Consumer Confidence Index (CCI) collapsed through the second half of 2021 and first three-quarters of 2022, falling to its lowest level ever recorded in September 2022 (Figure 2.5). The forward-looking components of the index fell particularly sharply: echoing results from OECD Risks That Matter, UK residents were especially pessimistic about how both their own finances and the general economic situation would develop over the following 12 months (GfK, 2022[7]). Many other OECD countries also saw consumer confidence fall around the same time, but UK confidence fell faster and further than almost anywhere else. Indeed, relative to their own long-term averages, only three OECD countries (Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania) have ever seen consumer confidence fall lower than the United Kingdom in September 2022 (OECD, 2023[8]).

Figure 2.5. UK consumer confidence collapsed between July 2021 and September 2022

Consumer Confidence Index, normalised (= 100) and seasonally adjusted, the United Kingdom, OECD total and other OECD RTM countries, January 2020 – December 2023



Note: The Consumer Confidence Index is based on data from national consumer opinion surveys and is built on responses to four questions: assessment of financial situation over the last 12 months; expected financial position over the next 12 months; expected general economic situation over the next 12 months; and expected major purchases over the next 12 months. The index is seasonally adjusted and normalised around the long-term average (100). Values above 100 represent a more-optimistic-than-average attitude towards the economy, and less than 100 a more-pessimistic-than-average attitude. "Other OECD RTM countries" refers to the 26 other OECD countries covered by OECD Risks That Matter 2022.
Source: OECD (2023), *Main Economic Indicators*, *Volume 2023 Issue 12*, https://doi.org/10.1787/ded67b87-en.

Domestic analysis has pointed to heavy inflation and the associated decline in real household income as central to this collapse in confidence (NIESR, 2022[9]; IFS, 2022[10]; Bank of England, 2023[11]). Rapidly rising prices erode confidence and optimism and, like many OECD countries, the United Kingdom experienced strong inflation through late-2021 and 2022. Rising energy prices are likely to have been particularly important (Bank of England, 2023[11]). UK energy structures mean that the United Kingdom is comparatively exposed to energy price shocks, especially gas price shocks (Bank of England, 2023[11]; Ari and Mulas-Granados, 2023[12]), and UK prices surged in the months following Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine. However, inflation is unlikely to have been the only factor contributing to the UK's strong concerns. From a comparative perspective, the United Kingdom was not the only OECD country to experience heavy inflation through 2022 (OECD, 2024[13]), but few others saw concern rise as high.

The good news for the United Kingdom is that pessimism about finances and the economy has eased somewhat in more recent months. Slowing inflation and government efforts to tackle the rising cost of living, such as the Energy Price Guarantee, a mandated limit on the consumer price of gas, helped the UK CCI recover from its record low in September 2022, and by the end of 2023 UK confidence returned to a level similar to the OECD total (Figure 2.5). Data from YouGov point to a similar recovery in optimism (YouGov, 2024[14]; YouGov, 2024[15]). Still, some caution is needed: the UK CCI continues to sit below its long-term average, and several commentators have warned that confidence remains fragile (Bloomberg, 2024[16]; British Chambers of Commerce, 2024[17]).

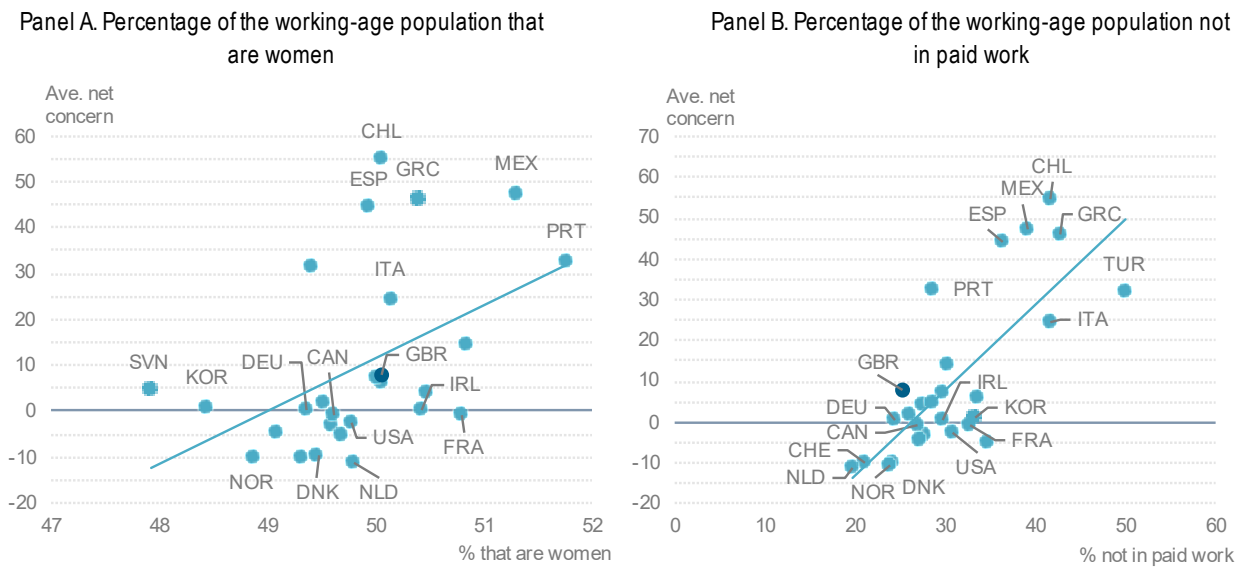
UK concerns strengthen after adjusting for country differences in population composition

Cross-country comparisons are not always made on a like-for-like basis. OECD Risks That Matter is built on samples designed to represent country populations as a whole, but the composition of these populations can differ substantially. Some OECD countries have populations that are older than others, for instance. Some have populations with greater shares of parents, or greater shares of highly educated people. As shown later on in this chapter, these kinds of individual characteristics are often important in shaping people's perceptions of risk. When aggregated, differences in their distribution can help explain why some OECD countries are, on average, less positive or more concerned about social and economic risks than others.

Results from this report's multilevel models point towards two population factors as being particularly important for explaining levels of perceived risk. One is women's share of the population, which is consistently associated with concern about social risk.[1] Net concern tends to be higher in countries where women make up a larger share of the population, and lower in countries with greater shares of men (Figure 2.6, Panel A; r = 0.47; A2.2.1, and A2.3.1). As touched on later on, this echoes a wider literature that finds women are generally less optimistic than men (Dawson, 2023[18]). The second is the share of the population out of work: in line with intuition, countries that have a larger share of the population outside paid work also report stronger average concerns around both short-term (Figure 2.6, Panel B; r = 0.76; Online Annex Table A2.2.1) and long-term social risks (Online Annex Table A2.3.1).

Figure 2.6. Women's share of the population and the share not in paid work are both associated with concerns about short-term social risks

Average net concern across ten short-term social and economic risks, percentage of the working-age population that are women, and percentage of the working-age population not in paid work



Note: Average net concern is based on a scale measuring average concern across a series of ten specified short-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). "Percentage of the working-age population not in paid work" is derived from answers to the question "Did you do any paid work in the last week?". See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only.

Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Adjusting estimates for differences in population composition can provide a more even basis for comparison. By “correcting” for the known effects of, for instance, differences in the age distribution or in women’s share of the population, adjusted estimates can help isolate differences between countries in “core” concern and perceived risk.

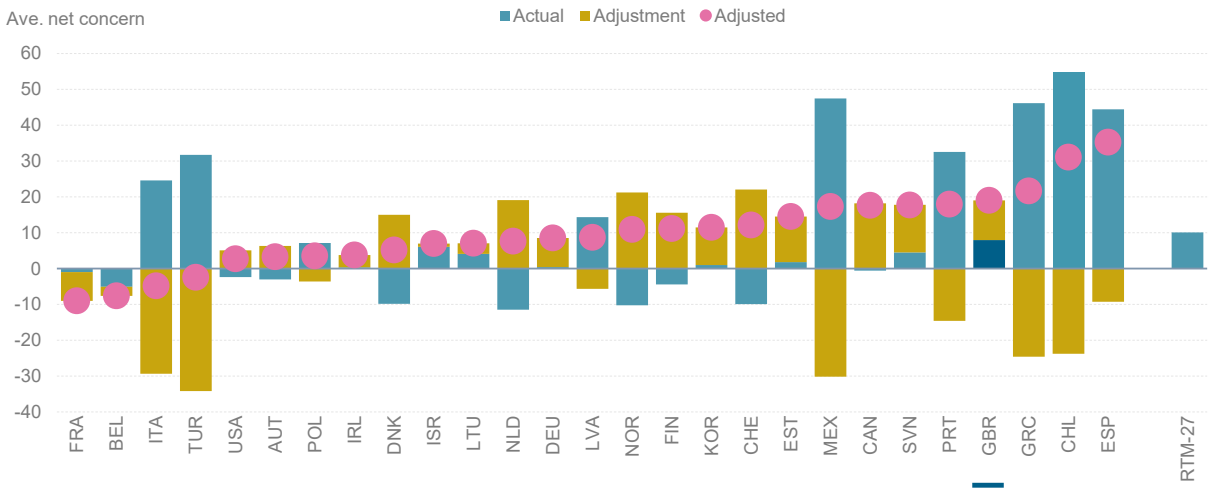
Figure 2.7 shows average net concern about short-term social risks before and after adjusting for between-country differences in demographic (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). The adjusted estimates in this instance are the level of net concern predicted for each country by this report’s multilevel models in the hypothetical scenario that population composition is identical (at the cross-country average) for all countries. For some countries, such as Italy, Mexico, and Türkiye, adjusting for population composition substantially reduces estimated net concern. These countries have population characteristics, including a higher-than-average share of the population out of work, that “inflate” expressed concern about social and economic risks. For others, like the Netherlands, Norway and Switzerland, population composition lends itself to a lower level of net concern; concern in these countries would be much higher if their populations looked more like the cross-country average.

For the United Kingdom, adjusting for population composition increases the comparative strength of expressed concern and moves the country further from many of its peers (Figure 2.7). Aspects of the UK population, especially its lower-than-average share of the population out of work, help keep average concerns down, and adjusting for this increases estimated net concern in the United Kingdom to levels slightly higher than the raw estimates (Figure 2.7, Panels A and B). Coupled with downward adjustments to estimates for countries with comparatively high levels of net concern (e.g. Italy, Türkiye), this moves the United Kingdom “up” the rankings towards the OECD’s most concerned countries. Overall, when the effects of population composition are taken out, UK respondents report the seventh highest level of concern about long-term social and economic risks (Figure 2.7, Panel A) and the fourth highest about short-term risks, behind only Greece, Chile, and Spain (Figure 2.7, Panel B).

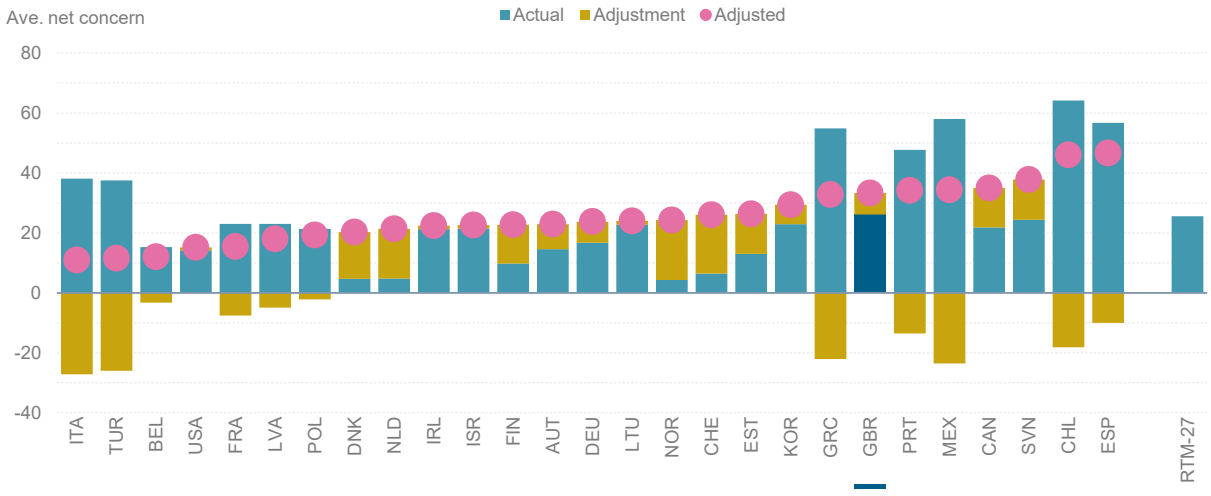
Figure 2.7. On a like-for-like basis, UK respondents report the seventh highest level of concern about long-term risks, and the fourth highest about short-term risks

Average net concern across ten short-term and ten long-term social and economic risks, before and after adjusting for population composition, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

Panel A. Short-term social and economic risks



Panel B. Long-term social and economic risks



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 4). Average net concern based on a scale measuring average concern across a series of ten specified short-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). GDP per capita is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses.

Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

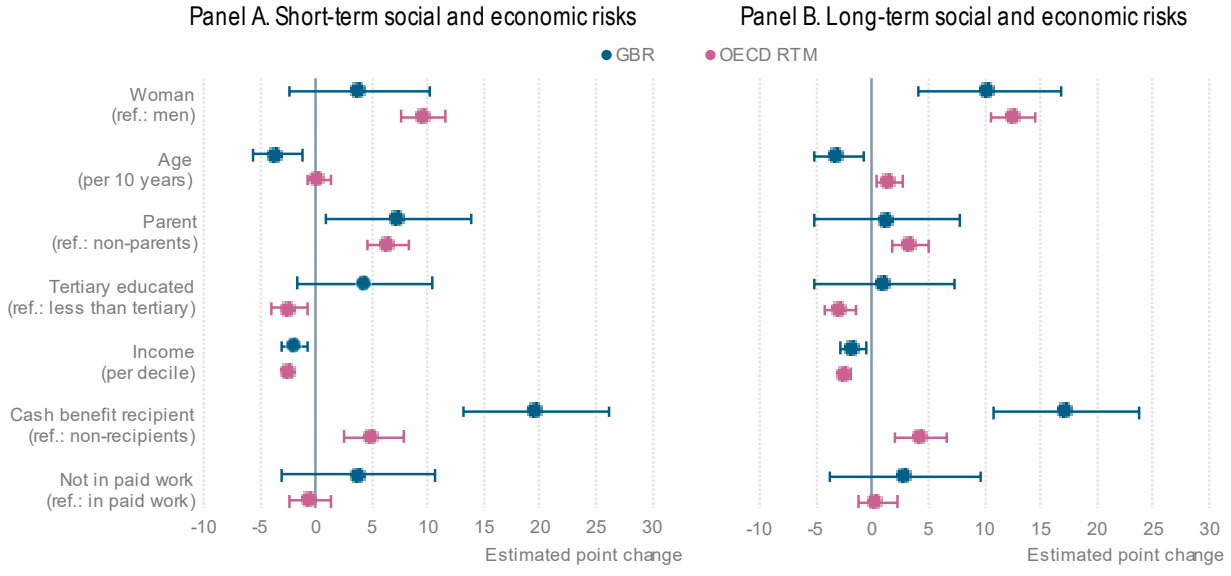
Women, parents, and those on lower incomes are more worried than others about social and economic risks, but in the United Kingdom concerns decrease (rather than increase) with age

Individual characteristics shape risk perceptions. As documented in past OECD Risks That Matter reports (OECD, 2019[19]; OECD, 2021[20]; OECD, 2023[1]), different social groups have different worries and concerns, with perceived risks varying in both type and intensity. Younger respondents are often more concerned about their financial security, for instance, and older respondents about access to healthcare (OECD, 2023[1]). Women often report stronger concerns than men, especially around finances and making ends meet. Lower-income respondents worry more about affordable housing, and higher-income respondents about access to quality child- and elder care services (OECD, 2019[19]).

Group differences in the United Kingdom are largely (but not always) similar to those seen in other OECD countries. Figure 2.8 summarises results from OECD RTM-wide and UK-specific linear models predicting within-country average concern about short-term (Panel A) and long-term (Panel B) social and economic risks. Full results are available in Online Annex Tables A2.2.2 and A2.3.2. In the United Kingdom, as elsewhere, being a woman is associated with stronger concerns about social risks, especially long-term concerns. This echoes findings from psychology that show women are consistently less optimistic and more risk averse than men (Dawson, 2023[18]), as well as reflecting women's disadvantaged position in society generally (OECD, 2023[1]). Parent status shares a similar (if usually smaller) positive association with expressed (short-term) concern. Unsurprisingly, income is negatively associated with perceived risk, with concern falling as income rises.

Figure 2.8. Perceived risk differs across social groups

Estimated point change in average net concern about short- and long-term social and economic risks per unit change in each independent variable, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom and OECD RTM-wide average, 2022

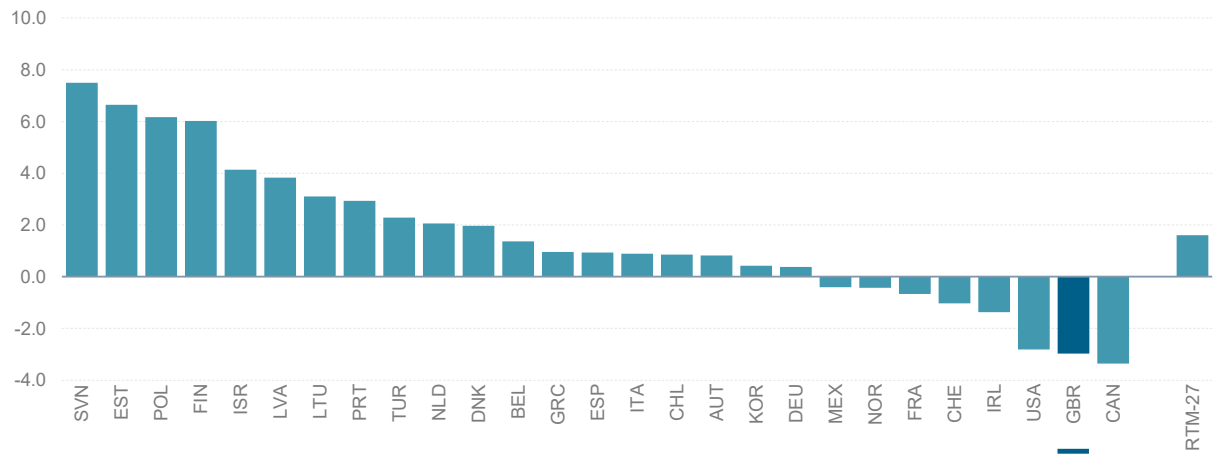


Note: Summary of results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (OECD RTM: Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 4) and country-specific linear regression models (GBR: Online Annex Tables A2.2.2 and A2.3.2, Model 4). Error bars set at the 95% confidence interval. The dependent variable in Panel A is average net concern across ten short-term social and economic risks, and in Panel B average net concern across ten long-term social and economic risks. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

However, there are areas where the United Kingdom differs from the OECD RTM sample as a whole. Two stand out. The first is that in the United Kingdom, as well as in some other (English-speaking) countries, both short and long-term concerns seem to decrease (rather than increase) with age (Figure 2.9). For example, focusing on long-term risks, in the United Kingdom, as also in Canada and the United States, each ten-year increase in age is associated with about a 2-point decrease in average net concern about long-term social risks, all else equal, compared to 1.6-point increase across the OECD RTM sample as a whole. In these English-speaking countries, it is younger rather than older respondents who are most concerned about their futures.

Figure 2.9. In the United Kingdom, as also in Canada and the United States, concerns about social risks fall (rather than grow) with age

Estimated point change in average net concern about long-term social and economic risks per ten-year increase in age, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Summary of results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (RTM-27: Online Annex Table A2.3.1, Model 4) and country-specific linear regression models (Online Annex Table A2.3.2, Model 4). The dependent variable is a scale measuring average concern about a series of ten specified long-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are weighted as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). Estimates are not adjusted for respondents with fully missing data. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

The second is that concerns about social risks seem to increase more strongly with benefit receipt in the United Kingdom than in most other countries. Perhaps unsurprisingly given that benefits are often targeted at more vulnerable sections of society, results from this report's regression models suggest that current benefit recipients (those who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months) express stronger short- and long-term concerns than non-recipients, even after controlling for income and other demographic and socio-economic factors (Figure 2.8). In the United Kingdom, receipt of a public cash benefit is associated with a 20-point increase in concern about short-term social risks, all else equal, compared to a 5-point increase on average across OECD RTM countries (Figure 2.8; Online Annex Tables A2.2.2 and A23.2, Model 4). Only in the United States (23 points) does benefit receipt share a stronger association with perceived risk. This likely reflects the targeted nature of public benefits in these two countries.

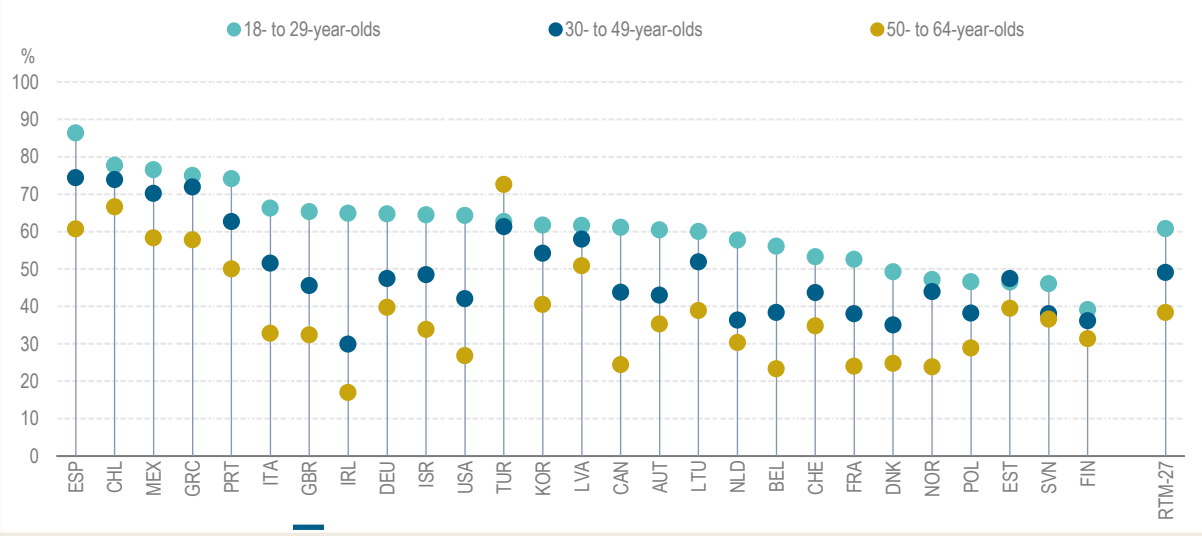
Box 2.3. Housing is a key concern for young adults in the United Kingdom, and much less so for older respondents

Housing is high on the agenda in the United Kingdom. By several measures, the United Kingdom has a comparatively expensive housing market, especially for renters. Almost a quarter (23%) of UK private renters are "overburdened" on their housing costs, meaning they are spending more than 40% of disposable income on their housing costs, compared to an OECD average of 14% (OECD, 2022[21]). Among low-income private renters, the overburden rate rises to more than half (53%). Like many OECD countries, house prices have risen faster than household income in recent decades, and housing's share of overall consumption expenditure (22%) is well above the OECD average (18%) (OECD, 2023[22]). Domestically, it has become common to talk of a housing "crisis".

In this context, it is not surprising that accessing affordable housing is a key concern for many UK respondents, particularly younger respondents. In 2022, 65% of 18- to 29-year-old UK respondents reported feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about their ability to find or maintain adequate housing over the following year or two, compared to an OECD RTM average of 61% (OECD, 2023[1]). Only Chile, Greece, Italy, Mexico, Portugal, and Spain reported higher levels of concern about housing among young respondents. Notably, as in several other OECD countries, worries around housing were much lower among older UK respondents: 32% of 50- to 64-year-old respondents reported feeling at least "somewhat" concerned about housing, 33 percentage points lower than among 18- to 29-year-olds. Only Canada, Italy, Ireland and the United States reported larger gaps in concern across age groups.

Figure 2.10. The United Kingdom has one of the largest age gaps in concern about accessing housing

Percentage of respondents reporting that they are somewhat concerned or very concerned about not being able to find/maintain adequate housing, by age group, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: See Box 2.1 for question wording.
Source: (OECD, 2023[1]), *Main Findings from the 2022 OECD Risks that Matter Survey*, https://doi.org/10.1787/70aea928-en.

This age gap in concern about housing mirrors a growing generational divide in housing tenure in the United Kingdom. Young UK adults today are far less likely to be homeowners than older generations were at the same age, and are much more likely to be found renting or living with parents (Broome et al., 2023[23]). Data from the Resolution Foundation show that the share of 19- to 29-year-old-headed households who are homeowners more than halved between 1989 and 2013, from 23% to 8% (Broome et al., 2023[23]). At the same time, homeownership is high and rising among older age groups. The 2021 UK Population and Housing Census shows that well over half (59%) of 60- to 69-year-olds now own their own properties outright, rising to three-quarters (75%) among 70- to 79-year-olds (ONS, 2023[24]).

Economic development and the shape of the social protection system may both contribute to how the United Kingdom ranks on concerns about social risks

What factors drive cross-national differences in perceived risk and concern, and what could the United Kingdom do, if anything, to bring its concerns closer to those expressed by respondents in the OECD's best performers? There are limits on the extent to which Risks That Matter can isolate country-level drivers of perceived risk, in part because the number of countries covered (27) restricts analysts' ability to separate the effects of different possible influences (see Annex A). Nonetheless, country comparison points to several factors that may help explain why concerns might be different in the United Kingdom than in some other OECD countries. This chapter has already noted that aspects of population composition can influence levels of concern, including women's share of the population and the share of the population of work (Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1). Economic development and the breadth and depth of social protection are two further potential factors.

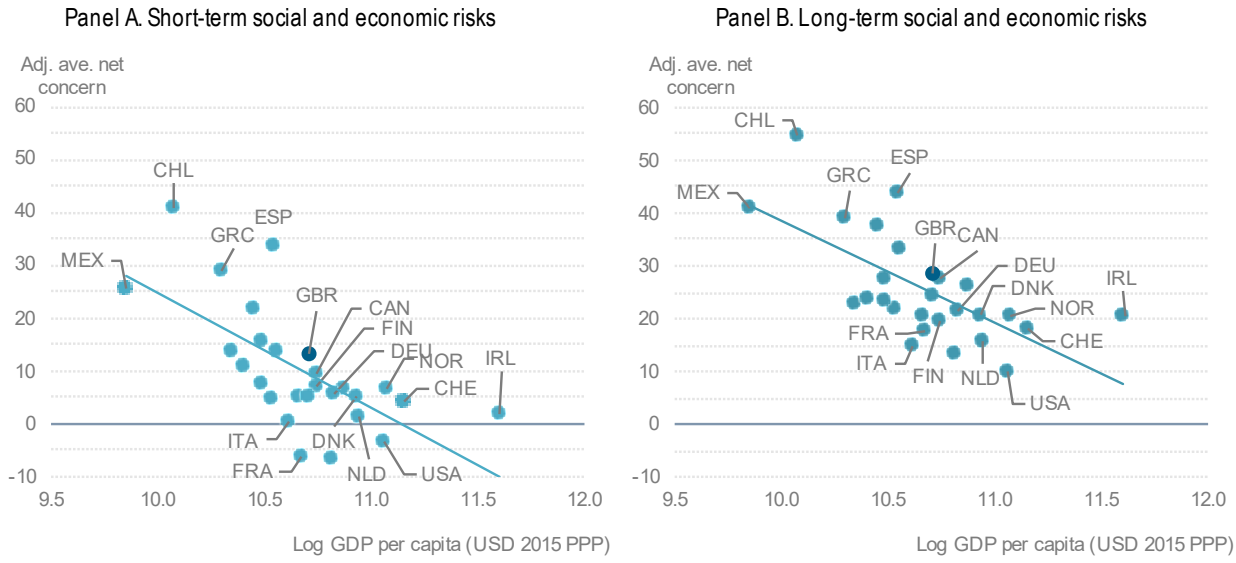
Economic development is one factor potentially contributing to the UK's comparatively moderate concerns

Echoing well-known links between average income and outcomes such as happiness and well-being (Helliwell, Layard and Sachs, 2012[25]; Clark, 2018[26]), results from Risks That Matter suggest that higher (average) incomes may help at least some people feel more secure and less vulnerable to social risks. As noted earlier in this chapter, respondents in some of the OECD's wealthier economies like Norway and Switzerland tend to express fewer concerns about social and economic risks than respondents in many of the OECD's less wealthy economies (Figure 2.1 and Figure 2.3). More generally, even after controlling for population composition, respondents in countries with higher GDP per capita tend to express weaker concerns about both short-term (Figure 2.11, Panel A; r = -0.67; Online Annex Table A2.2.1, Model 4) and long-term social and economic risks (Figure 2.11, Panel B; r = -0.66, or r = -0.72; Online Annex Table A2.3.1, Model 4), although it should be noted that associations weaken once social expenditure (another potential driver) is taken into account (Box 2.4). Associations are similar for concerns about most specific risks, like becoming ill or disabled, losing a job, accessing adequate housing, accessing education and childcare, and accessing long-term care (Online Annex Tables A2.2a.1. A2.2b.1, A2.2c.1, A2.2e.1, and A2.2f.1).

The United Kingdom, for its part, is a mid-range performer on GDP per capita. Sluggish growth over the decade and a half since the financial crisis means that UK GDP per capita (USD (2015) 45 000 in 2022) is now 10% lower than in Germany (USD (2015) 50 000), and more than 30% lower than in leading countries like Norway (USD (2015) 65 000), Switzerland (USD (2015) 70 000), and the United States (USD (2015) 64 000). In this light, it is not surprising that expressed concern is higher in the United Kingdom than in several other (wealthier) OECD countries.

Figure 2.11. Respondents tend to be less concerned about short- and long-term social risks when they live in countries with higher (average) incomes

Log GDP per capita (USD 2015 PPP), (adjusted) average net concern about short-term social and economic risks, and (adjusted) average net concern about long-term social and economic risks



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 4). Average net concern is derived from scales measuring average concern about a series of ten specified short-term and ten long-term social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic composition (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). GDP per capita is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. Data on GDP per capita refer to 2022. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD National Accounts, www.oecd.org/sdd/na/.

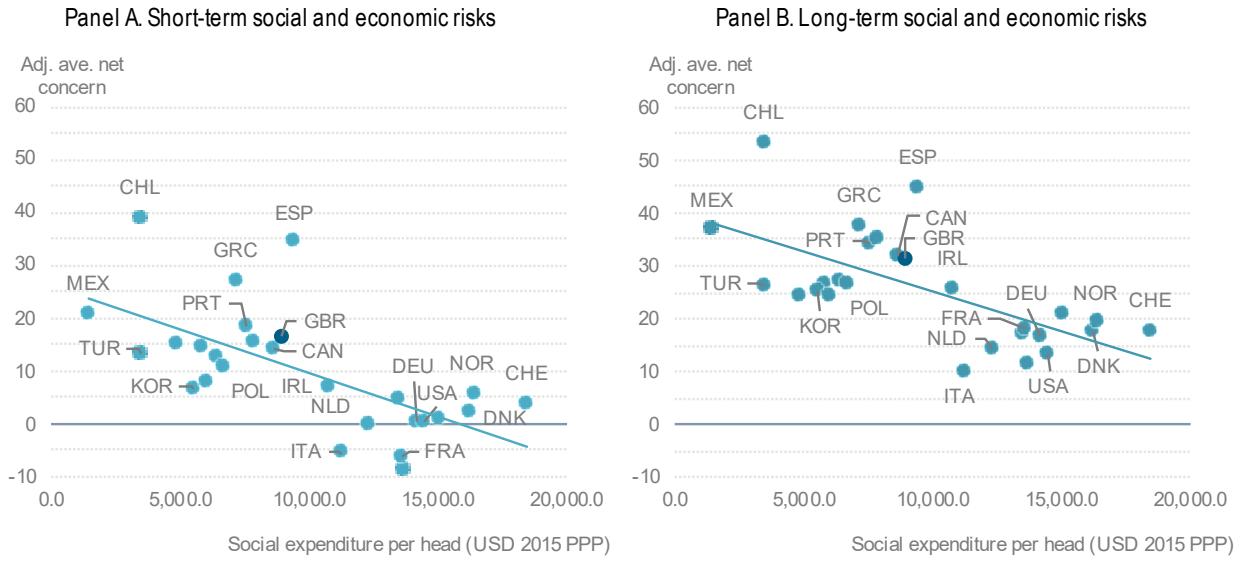
People in countries with expansive social protection systems express fewer concerns about social and economic risks

An important goal of social protection is to help people feel secure about their futures and as with GDP per capita, evidence from Risks That Matter suggests that people report fewer concerns when they live in countries that operate more expansive social protection systems. For example, Denmark and Norway are countries with extensive public social protection (Chapter 1) and have respondents who express some of the fewest concerns about both short- and long-term social risks (see Figure 2.1 and Figure 2.3). The Netherlands and Switzerland, countries with extensive mandatory private social spending (OECD, 2023[27]), are also consistently strong performers. More generally, even after adjusting for population composition, respondents express fewer concerns about short- and long-term risks when they live in countries that spend more on social issues (Figure 2.12; r = -0.65 and r = -0.66; Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 12), although associations again weaken after controlling for GDP per capita (see Box 2.4). Concerns about some specific risks can also be linked to social policies. For example, respondents tend to be less concerned about job loss when they live in countries that spend more on social policies generally and unemployment supports specifically (Online Annex Tables A2.2b.1 and A2.3d.1, Models 11 and 20). Worries about finding and maintaining housing are negatively associated with policy efforts to reduce poverty and inequality, as well as with the targeting of cash benefits towards low-income groups (Online Annex Tables A2.2c.1 and A2.3f.1, Models 15 and 17).

As discussed in Chapter 1, the United Kingdom operates a mid-sized market-based social protection system. UK social spending (USD (2015) 8 900 per person in 2019) is close to the OECD average (USD 9 900 per person) but well below the amounts spent in countries like Denmark (USD 16 200 per person), Norway (USD 16 400 per person) and Switzerland (USD 18 400 per person). All else equal, respondents in the United Kingdom might be expected to report stronger concerns than respondents in countries with more expansive social protection systems.

Figure 2.12. Concerns about short- and long-term risks are less frequent in countries that spend more on social issues

Public and mandatory private social expenditure per head (USD 2015 PPP), (adjusted) average net concern about short-term social and economic risks, and (adjusted) average net concern about long-term social and economic risks



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 12). Average net concern is derived from scales measuring average concern about a series of ten specified short-term (long-term) social and economic risks. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic composition (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). Social expenditure is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. Data on social expenditure refer to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and the OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

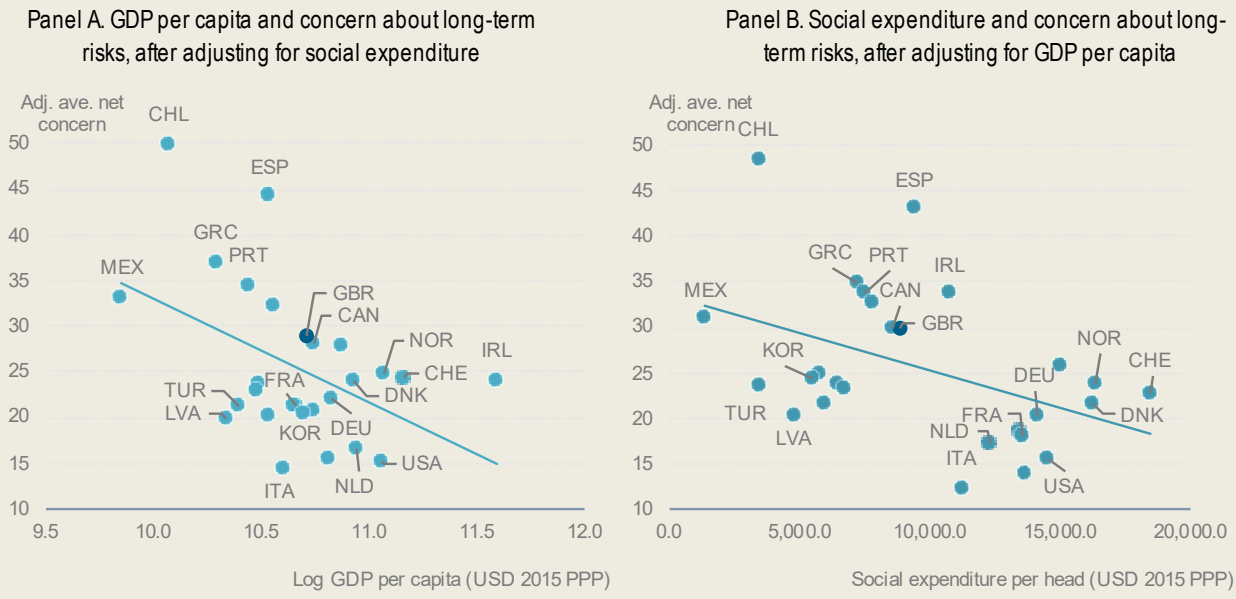
Box 2.4. A caveat on links between GDP per capita, social spending, and perceived risk and concern

This section has highlighted GDP per capita and social spending as factors that potentially influence concern about social risks, but separating and isolating the effects of the two is not as straightforward as might be hoped. (Log) GDP per capita and (public and mandatory private) social expenditure are themselves strongly correlated (r = 0.77), with wealthier OECD countries often operating more extensive social protection systems. While short of what is typically considered multicollinear, the strength of this correlation increases the difficulty of disentangling the individual effects of each, especially with a limited sample size (27). Indeed, when GDP per capita and social expenditure are entered into the same regression model, associations on *both* soften somewhat and move out of statistical significance (Online Annex Tables A2.2.1 and A2.3.1, Model 12).

Further work is needed to establish the independence of these two associations. It is possible that this is a case of confounding, with the apparent link between GDP per capita and perceived risk actually driven by social spending, or vice versa. However, both factors remain at least moderately correlated with concern about social risks even after controlling for the other (Figure 2.13; r = -0.46 and -0.45, respectively), and there are theoretical reasons to believe that both can help people feel more secure in the face of social risks. Higher (average) incomes can provide many (if not always all) people with private means for mitigating and insuring against risk, for instance, while more expansive social protection provides a strong social safety net.

Figure 2.13. Both GDP per capita and social expenditure remain negatively correlated with concerns about long-term risks after controlling for one another

GDP per capita (USD 2015 PPP), public and mandatory private social expenditure per head (USD 2015 PPP), and (adjusted) average net concern about long-term social and economic risks, after adjusting for population composition and social expenditure (GDP per capita)



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Table A2.3.1, Model 11). Average net concern is derived from scales measuring average concern about a series of ten short-term and ten long-term social and economic risks.

The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Not at all concerned" (-100), "Not so concerned" (-33.333), "Somewhat concerned" (33.333) and "Very concerned" (100). Estimates in Panel A adjust for between-country differences in demographic composition (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt) plus public and mandatory private social expenditure per head. Estimates in Panel B adjust for between-country differences in demographic composition and basic socio-economic characteristics plus GDP per capita. GDP per capita (social expenditure) is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates in Panel A (B). Data on GDP per capita refer to 2022, and social expenditure to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 2.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html; OECD National Accounts, www.oecd.org/sdd/na/, and the OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

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Notes

[1] The data on women's share of the population used in Figure 2.6 are derived from the Risks That Matter microdata, which is itself determined by the statistics used for the survey's sampling quotas and weighting calculations. According to the latest numbers available from the United Kingdom's Office for National Statistics, women's share of the working-age (18- to 64-year-old) population stood at 50.8% in mid-2022. This is slightly higher than the share derived from the RTM microdata (50.0%), suggesting that RTM slightly underestimates women's share of the UK population and underrepresents women in its results.

3 How does the United Kingdom feel about social protection?

This chapter examines public satisfaction with social policy in United Kingdom and how it compares to other OECD countries. Built on data from OECD Risks That Matter 2022, it explores perceptions around access to public services and benefits, as well as beliefs about fairness in benefit receipt and the extent to which people feel listened to by those designing social protection. Results suggest that, like many elsewhere, respondents in the United Kingdom are often dissatisfied with public benefits and services, with dissatisfaction especially strong among women and older respondents. People in the also express a sense of injustice in benefit receipt, believing that many others receive more than they deserve, but not to the same extent as respondents in some other OECD countries.

This chapter examines public satisfaction with social policy in the United Kingdom and how it compares to other OECD countries. Constructed around three main questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 (Box 3.1), it looks at how happy people in the United Kingdom are with their access to public services and benefits, as well as their confidence in government income support in a range of income loss scenarios. Additional questions touch on feelings of fairness in benefit receipt and the extent to which people feel listened to by those designing social protection (Box 3.1).

Results suggest that respondents in the United Kingdom are often dissatisfied with public benefits and services. Like many elsewhere, UK respondents have mixed feelings about public service access but little confidence in public benefits and income support. Dissatisfaction is stronger in the United Kingdom than in some of the UK's G7 peers, like Canada, Germany, and the United States, but is generally lower than in France and Italy. Respondents in the United Kingdom also express a sense of injustice in benefit receipt, believing that many others receive more than they deserve, but not to the same extent as respondents in some other countries, again including France and Italy. This mirrors domestic evidence showing that attitudes towards benefit recipients, previously very hard in the United Kingdom, have softened markedly in the past decade or so.

Benefit and service satisfaction differs across groups, with women and older respondents expressing greater dissatisfaction. The age gap in satisfaction is particularly large in the United Kingdom. The role of income differs across countries, with satisfaction growing (rather than falling) with income in the United Kingdom. Associations with economic and financial security are more consistent: across countries, people who report that their household finances have deteriorated in the past year also report lower satisfaction with public benefits and services. The United Kingdom has one of the largest gaps in satisfaction between those with and without deteriorating finances.

The role of policy is mixed. Countries running more expansive social protection systems often (but not always) see greater overall satisfaction with public services and benefits, and there is also evidence to suggest that more generous unemployment benefits and pensions can boost confidence in income support following job loss or retirement. There is scope for the United Kingdom to increase generosity in both areas. However, links between policy structures and satisfaction with public service access are less clear, with service satisfaction seemingly mostly unrelated to country-level policy indicators.

Box 3.1. Questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 used in this chapter

This chapter is built around three main questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022. The first of these questions focuses on the extent to which respondents believe they have access to "good quality and affordable" public services in a range of policy areas:

- Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement:

  "I think that my household and I have/would have access to good quality and affordable public services in the area of [#ITEM#], if needed."

The policy areas (items) given were: Family support (e.g. childcare, parenting support services, etc.); Education (e.g. schools, universities, professional/vocational training, adult education, etc.); Employment (e.g. job search supports, skills training supports, self-employment supports, etc.); Housing (e.g. social housing, housing benefit, etc.); Health (e.g. public medical care, subsidised health insurance, mental health support, etc.); Disability/incapacity-related needs (e.g. disability benefits and services, long-term care services for persons with disability, community living resources, etc.); Long-term care for older people (e.g. home, community-based and/or institutional care); and Public safety (e.g. policing).

The second question focuses on perceptions of access to public benefits:

- To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement? If you currently are receiving services or benefits please answer these questions according to your experience. If you are not receiving them, please answer according to what you think your experience would be if you needed them.

  "I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them"

The third concentrates on perceived income support from government in case of income loss:

- Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement:

  "I think that the government does/would provide my household and me with adequate income support in the case of income loss due to [#ITEM#]"

The income loss reasons (items) given were: Unemployment; Illness/disability; Having a child/having more children; Leaving work to care for elderly family members or family members with disabilities; Retirement; Death of spouse or partner.

Additionally, three further questions are used to measure perceptions of fairness in benefit receipt and the extent to which respondents feel listened to in the policy-making process:

- Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement:

  "I feel that I receive a fair share of public benefits, given the taxes and social contributions I pay and/or have paid in the past."

- Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement:

  "Many people receive public benefits without deserving them."

- Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement:

  "I feel the government incorporates the views of people like me when designing or reforming public benefits and services."

In all six cases, possible response options were: 1. Strongly disagree; 2. Disagree; 3. Neither agree nor disagree; 4. Agree; 5. Strongly agree; 6. Can't choose.

Source: OECD (2023) OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022: Core Questionnaire, https://webfs.oecd.org/Els-com/RtM/OECD-Risks-That-Matter-2022-Core-Questionnaire.pdf.

People in the United Kingdom are generally dissatisfied with public benefits and services

Responses to OECD Risks That Matter show that across OECD countries, many people are dissatisfied with public benefits and services (OECD, 2023[1]). Many respondents report that it is difficult to access good quality and affordable public services, particularly in areas like disability and incapacity-related services and long-term care. Even larger numbers feel that public benefits are both insufficient and difficult to receive. Responses by UK respondents are not so different. Overall, the picture painted by UK respondents to OECD Risks That Matter is one of general dissatisfaction, especially with benefits, and at a level stronger than in several of the UK's peers in the G7 and other wealthy OECD economies (e.g. Denmark, Norway, the Netherlands).

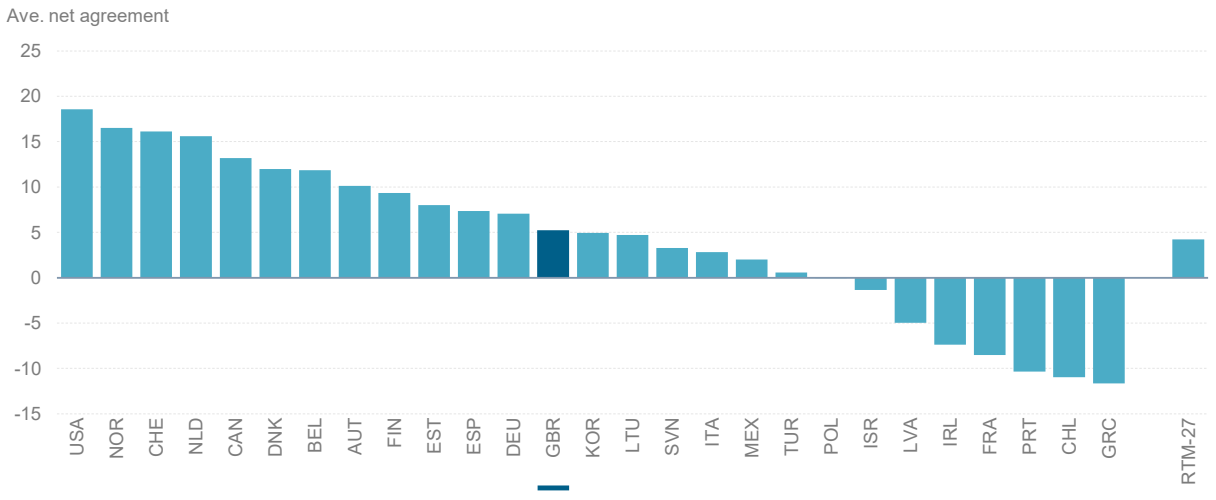
UK respondents are mixed on their access to public services

On public service access, respondents in Britain are overall ambivalent. When asked whether they agree that their household has access to quality, affordable services in eight policy areas, UK respondents were on average more likely to agree than to disagree, but only marginally so (Figure 3.1). In comparative terms, net average agreement in the United Kingdom (5 points) is slightly higher than the OECD RTM average (4 points). It is well below the most satisfied countries like Switzerland (16 points), Norway (17 points) and the United States (19 points), as well as some other G7 economies like Canada (13 points) and Germany (7 points), but slightly above Italy (3 points), France (-9 points) and neighbouring Ireland (-7 points).

Drilling down to specific policy areas, UK respondents match those in many other OECD countries in being most satisfied with public service access in education, public safety and health, and least satisfied with long-term care and disability and incapacity services (Figure 3.2). Comparing across policy areas, 49% of UK respondents to Risks That Matter agree that their household has access to "good quality and affordable" services in education, and 45% in public safety. Despite strong concerns around ongoing access (see Chapter 3), many (43%) also agree that they currently have access to good-quality public healthcare services. This is similar to the 50% of UK respondents to the OECD Survey on Drivers of Trust in Public Institutions (Trust Survey) who report satisfaction with the healthcare system (OECD, 2024[2]). As in many other countries, relatively few believe they would have access to good-quality disability/incapacity and long-term care services (both 30%) if they needed them. Whether this is due to a lack of awareness of the public services available in these areas, or to dissatisfaction with the (availability of) services actually offered, is not clear from the available data.

Figure 3.1. UK respondents have mixed feelings about public service access

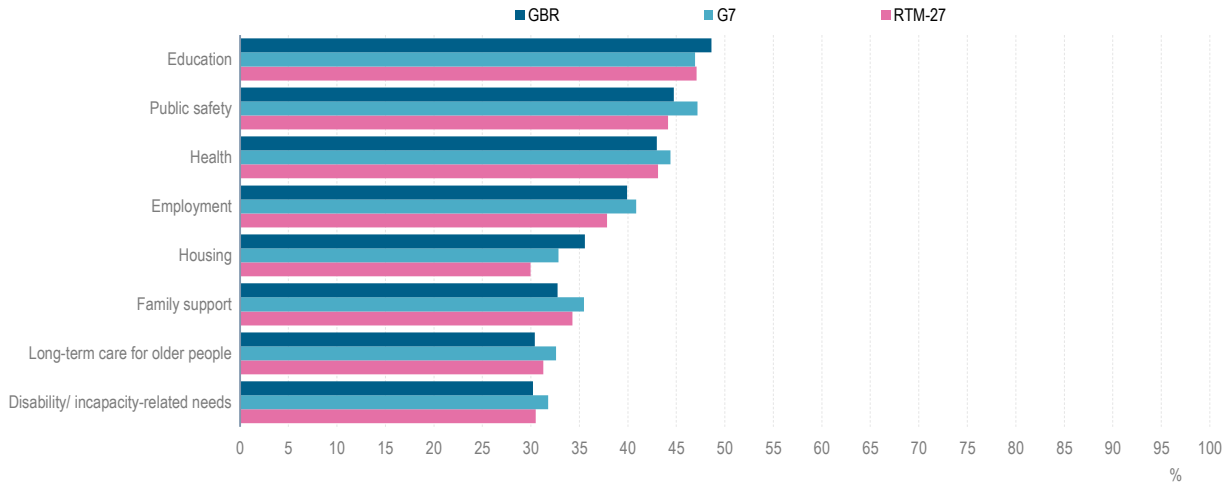
Average net agreement about household access to "good quality and affordable public services" in eight policy areas, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with household access to "good quality and affordable public services" in eight specified policy areas. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all eight items, to 100 in the case that they chose "Strongly agree" for all items. Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Figure 3.2. Like people elsewhere, UK respondents are most satisfied with their access to education, public safety and health services

Percentage of respondents who agree or strongly agree with the statement "I think that my household and I have/would have access to good quality and affordable public services in the area of..., if needed", 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

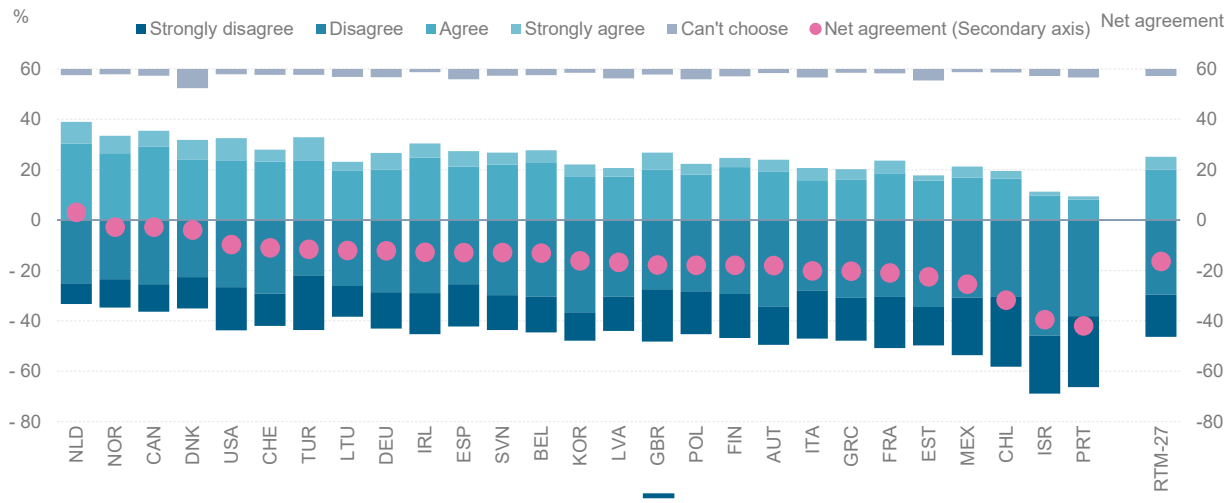
One area where the United Kingdom at least partly stands out is in satisfaction with access to public housing services. 36% of UK respondents agree that their household has access to "good quality and affordable" public housing services – above the OECD RTM average (30%), and the eighth highest agreement rate among covered countries. While the sector faces challenges, including in maintaining supply and updating an ageing housing stock (Cromarty and Barton, 2024[3]), the United Kingdom continues to hold one of the largest stocks of social housing in the OECD (OECD, 2022[4]) and UK respondents are more likely to have had at least some interaction with public housing services than respondents in many other OECD countries.

Like many elsewhere, people in the United Kingdom lack confidence in public benefits

Like people in many other OECD countries, UK respondents are more clearly dissatisfied when asked about public benefits and income support. Similar to respondents elsewhere, UK respondents are more likely to disagree than to agree that they could "easily receive public benefits if [they] needed them" (Figure 3.3) and express little confidence that the government would provide adequate income support in six different income loss scenarios (Figure 3.4). Relative to other countries, net (dis)agreement on benefit access in the United Kingdom (-18 points) is slightly below the OECD RTM average (-16 points), and well below Canada (-3 points), the United States (-10 points), and Germany (-12 points), but slightly higher than in Italy (-20 points) and France (-21 points). On income support adequacy, net agreement (-21 points) again sits slightly below the OECD RTM average (-20 points) and well below Canada (-13 points) and the United States (-13 points), but above Ireland (-25 points), France (-29 points), and several of the OECD's less wealthy economies in Southern and Central and Eastern Europe and Latin America.

Figure 3.3. Respondents in the United Kingdom are far more likely to disagree than agree that they can easily access public benefits

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement?… I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



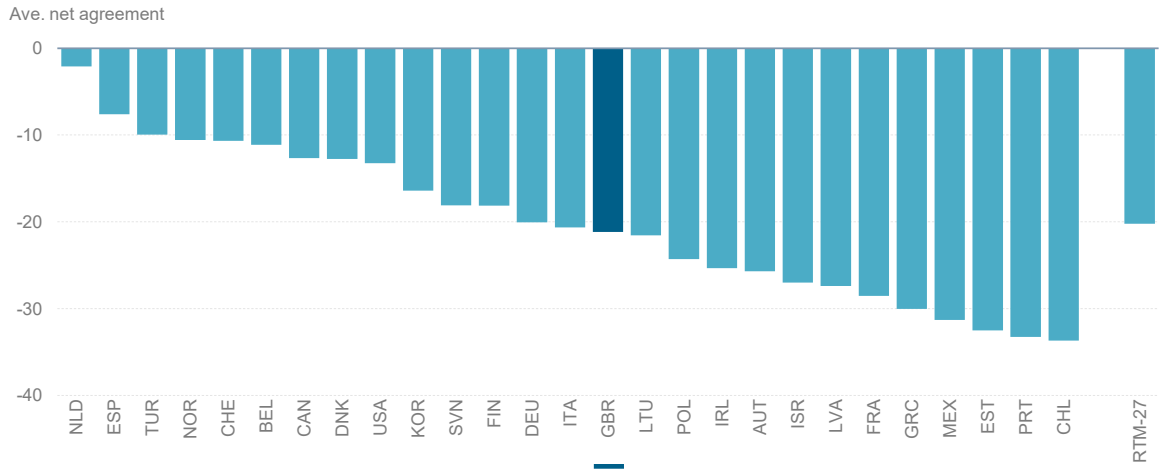
Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 3.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Satisfaction with income support is generally low regardless of the reason for income loss. As outlined in Box 3.1, Risks That Matter asked respondents whether the government would (or does) provide their household with adequate income support in case they lost income for six different reasons: "unemployment", "illness/disability", "having a child/having more children", "leaving work to care for others", "retirement", and "death of spouse or partner". When thinking about any of the six situations, around or less than a quarter of UK respondents believe that the government would provide them with adequate income support (Figure 3.5). In comparative terms, the United Kingdom lags its peers in the G7 when it comes to confidence in income support following job loss but otherwise levels of satisfaction are generally similar.

This lack of confidence in government income support echoes findings from domestic data collections. Results from the British Social Attitudes survey show that in 2019, 50% of people in Britain believed that "benefits for unemployed people are too low and cause hardship" (Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[5]). Similarly, polling data by YouGov show that people in Britain are consistently more likely to think that benefits are too low than too high (YouGov, 2024[6]), and that many believe the benefit system offers "too little support" to a range of groups, including people on low incomes with children, people in low-paid work, and people over 65 (YouGov, 2024[7]; YouGov, 2024[8]; YouGov, 2024[9]). However, some aspects of the benefit system receive public support. For example, polling by both Ipsos and YouGov suggests that many people support the UK's two-child limit on child benefit payments, with YouGov finding that as many as 60% believe the two-child limit should be retained (Ipsos, 2024[10]; YouGov, 2024[11]).

Figure 3.4. As in many other countries, UK respondents have little confidence in government income support

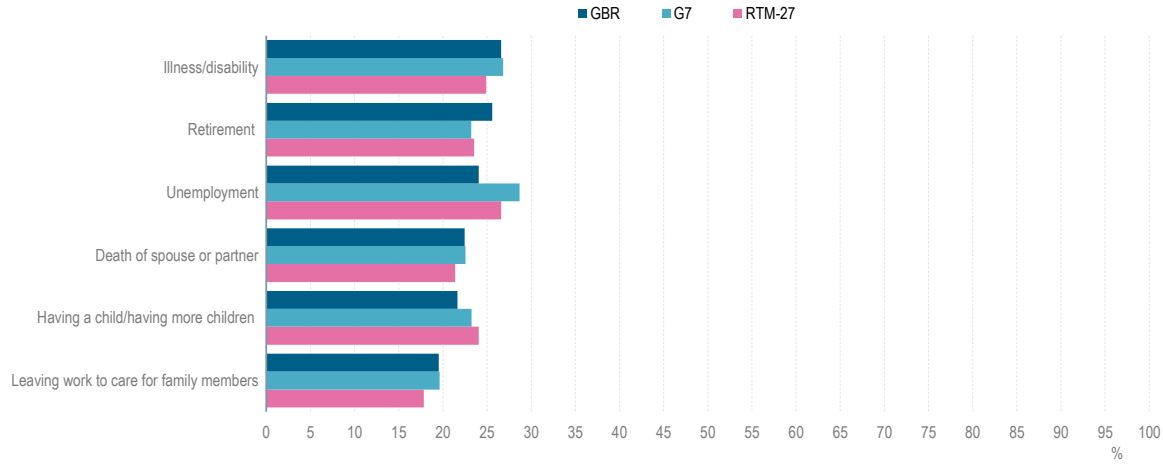
Average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six income-loss circumstances, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Figure 3.5. Satisfaction with government income support is low regardless of the reason for income loss

Percentage of respondents who agree or strongly agree with the statement "I think that the government does/would provide my household and me with adequate income support in the case of income loss due to...", 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies. See Box 3.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Box 3.2. Many people in the United Kingdom lack confidence in their eligibility for public benefits

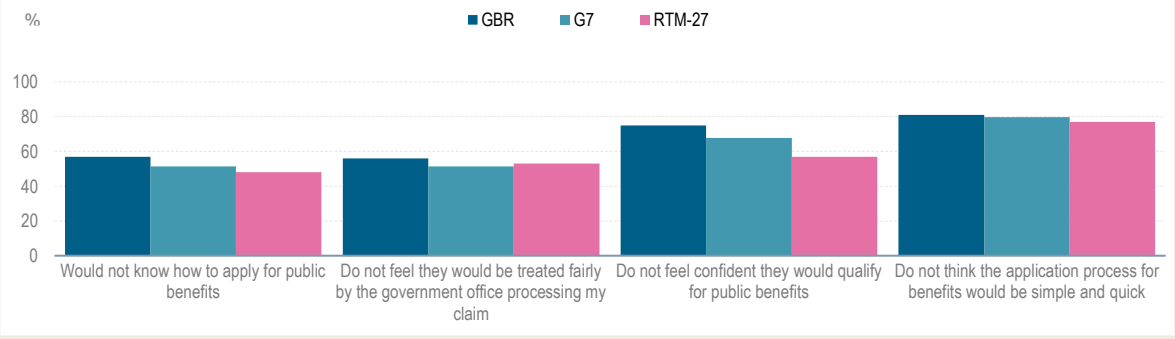
While many people in many OECD countries believe it is not easy to access benefits, the reasons behind this perceived lack of access can differ substantially. As part of a battery of questions on benefit access, Risks That Matter 2022 asked people for their thoughts on various aspects of the benefit application process and the extent to which each might act as a barrier to receipt. Examining responses to these questions by those who believe they could not easily access public benefits adds detail on the underlying reasons.

The ease and simplicity of the application process is the dominant reason given for a perceived lack of access to benefits in many OECD countries (Figure 3.6). On average across the 27 OECD countries covered by Risks That Matter 2022, more than three-quarters (77%) of those who doubt they could easily access benefits also doubt that the application process for benefits would be quick and easy. Around 50-60% also doubt that they would qualify for public benefits (57%), that they would be treated fairly by the government processing office (53%), and that they know how to apply for benefits (48%).

Responses in the United Kingdom mostly follow the OECD RTM average, with the exception of the share who doubt they would qualify for public benefits, which is much higher than in most other countries (Figure 3.6). Indeed, at 75%, the United Kingdom has the second highest share who doubt their eligibility, after only the United States (78%) (OECD, 2023[1]). Notably, the three countries with the highest shares lacking confidence in their eligibility for public benefits (the United Kingdom, the United States, and Ireland) all operate strongly targeted and heavily means-tested social protection systems.

Figure 3.6. A comparatively large share of UK respondents doubt they would qualify for benefits if they needed them

Percentage of respondents reporting each expected difficulty if they needed to access public benefits, among respondents who disagree or strongly disagree with the statement "I believe I could access public benefits if I needed them", 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Respondents were asked: "To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement? If you currently are receiving services or benefits please answer these questions according to your experience. If you are not receiving them, please answer according to what you think your experience would be if you needed them: I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them/I am confident I would qualify for public benefits/I know how to apply for public benefits/I think the application process for benefits would be simple and quick/I feel I would be treated fairly by the government office processing my claim. Respondents could choose between: "Strongly disagree"; "Disagree"; "Neither agree nor disagree"; "Agree"; "Strongly agree"; "Can't choose". Data refer to the percentage responding "strongly disagree" or "disagree", among those who disagree or strongly disagree that they could easily receive public benefits if they needed them. G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies.
Source: (OECD, 2023[1]), *Main Findings from the 2022 OECD Risks that Matter Survey*, https://doi.org/10.1787/70aea928-en.

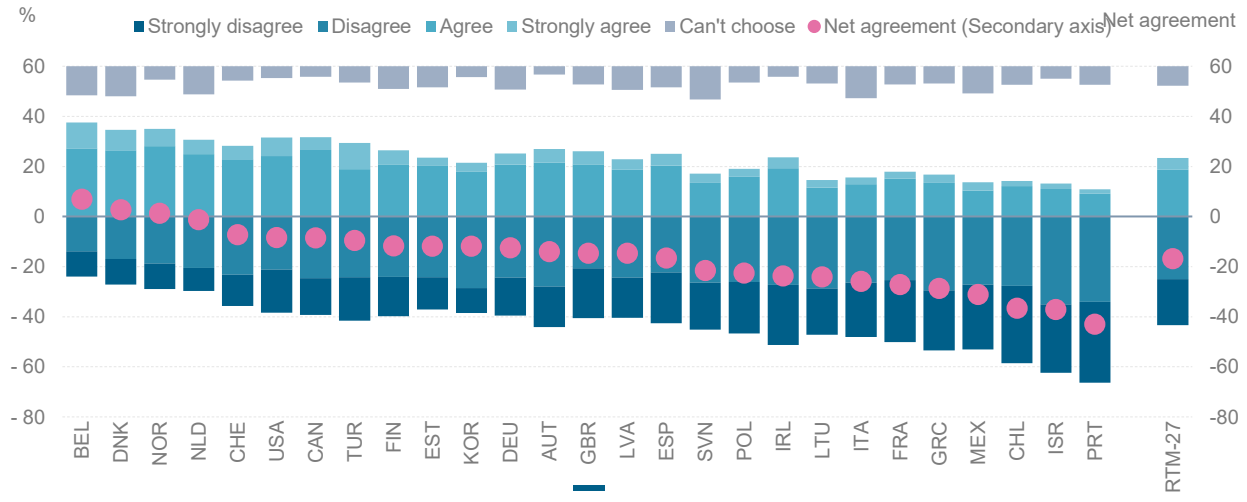
Feelings of injustice in benefit receipt are comparatively mild in the United Kingdom

Past rounds of OECD Risks That Matter have documented a widespread sense of injustice in public benefit receipt (OECD, 2019[12]; OECD, 2023[1]). Across countries, only a minority of people believe they are getting the benefits they deserve in return for the taxes they pay, with large numbers feeling that others are receiving more than they should. Underlying this sense of injustice is a commonly held belief that the benefit system is not designed with people like them in mind.

Compared to many other OECD countries, feelings of injustice in benefit receipt are relatively moderate among respondents in the United Kingdom. Like people in almost all other covered countries, UK respondents are more likely to disagree than to agree that they receive their fair share of public benefits given the taxes they pay (Figure 3.7), and are far more likely to agree that many others receive benefits without deserving them (Figure 3.8). However, in both cases, net agreement (-15 and 31 points, respectively) is similar to the OECD RTM average (-17 and 36 points) and relatively close to several other G7 countries, including Canada (-9 and 33 points), Germany (-13 and 32 points), and the United States (-8 and 30 points). Overall feelings of injustice are far milder in the United Kingdom than in France and Italy, as well as several other Southern and Central and Eastern European and Latin American OECD countries. This fits well with domestic evidence from the British Social Attitudes survey, which shows that attitudes towards benefit recipients, previously very hard, have softened markedly in the past decade or so (Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[5]).

Figure 3.7. Like respondents in other countries, Brits are more likely to disagree than to agree that they receive their fair share of public benefits

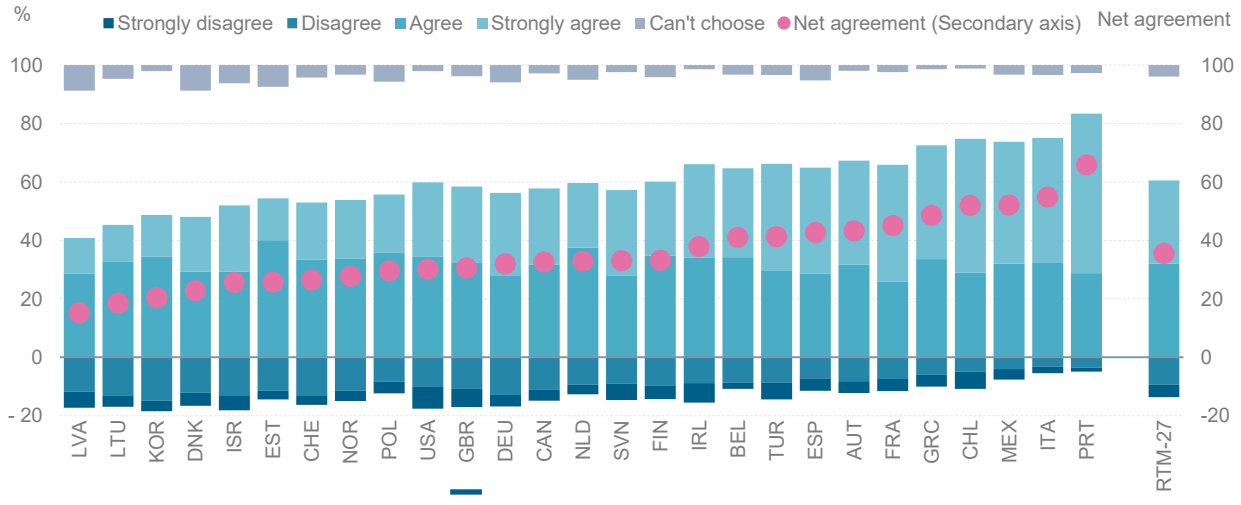
Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: I feel that I receive a fair share of public benefits, given the taxes and social contributions I pay and/or have paid in the past.", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 3.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Figure 3.8. Feelings of injustice in benefit receipt are mild compared to some other OECD countries

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: Many people receive public benefits without deserving them", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

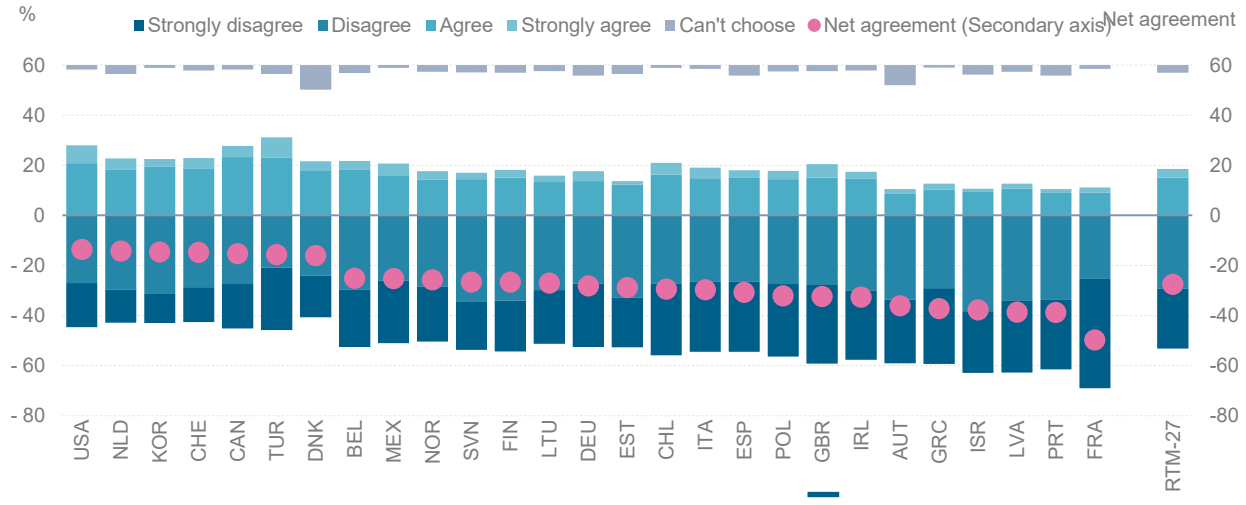


Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 3.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Regardless of their thoughts on fairness, many people in Britain continue to feel that the public benefit system is not designed for them (Figure 3.9). When asked to indicate the extent to which they agree or disagree with the statement "I feel the government incorporates the views of people like me when designing or reforming public benefits", 28% of UK respondents marked "disagree", with as many as 31% choosing "strongly disagree" – the second highest share among the covered countries, behind only France. Overall net agreement in the United Kingdom (-32 points) is lower than the OECD RTM average (-28 points). This feeling of exclusion in benefit design echoes a wider belief in the United Kingdom that the government is "out of touch" and has done little to understand, represent or promote the interests of ordinary people (Hughes, 2023[13]).

Figure 3.9. Many people feel that the benefit system is not designed with them in mind

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: I feel the government incorporates the views of people like me when designing or reforming public benefits and services", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 3.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Satisfaction with public benefits and services differs across groups

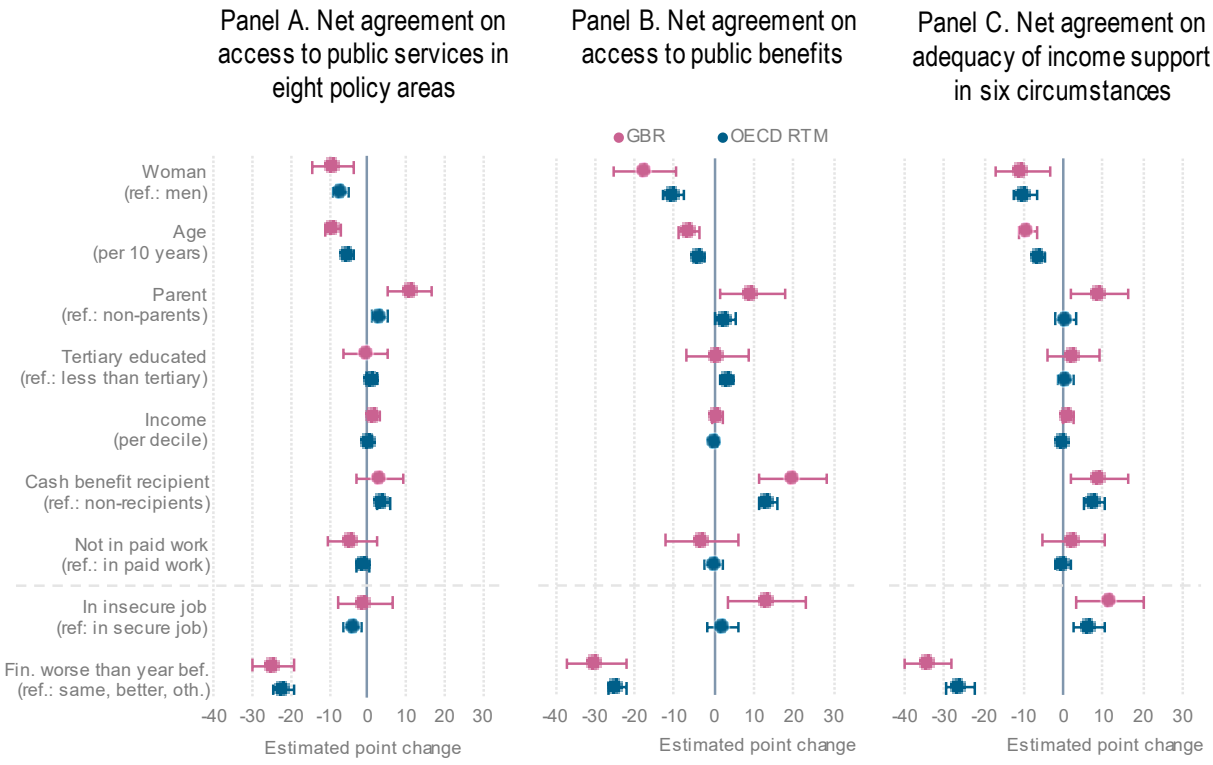
Women express greater dissatisfaction than men, and older people greater dissatisfaction than younger people

Experiences with public benefits and services can vary greatly from person to person. What people need from government (and, indeed, what people expect from government) differs with circumstances and can shift and evolve at different stages of life (OECD, 2017[14]).

With this in mind, it is not surprising that views on the adequacy of public benefits and services should differ across groups (OECD, 2019[12]). Women, for example, are consistently less satisfied than men with public benefits and services (Figure 3.10). In the United Kingdom, being a woman is associated with an estimated 9-point decrease in net agreement about access to quality, affordable public services (Figure 3.10, Panel A), a 17-point decrease in net agreement about access to public benefits (Figure 3.10, Panel B), and a 10-point decrease in net agreement on the adequacy of income support (Figure 3.10, Panel C). Parenthood is also associated with satisfaction: compared to respondents without children, parents are more likely to agree that their household can easily access both public benefits and public services (Figure 3.10, Panels A and B) as well as, in the United Kingdom at least, to agree that that the government would provide adequate income support in case of income loss (Figure 3.10, Panel C). One possibility is that parents are more regular users of many public services and some public benefits, and are therefore more familiar with the processes involved (see also Box 3.3).

Figure 3.10. Views on the adequacy of public benefits and services differ across social groups

Estimated point change in net satisfaction with access to public services in eight policy areas (Panel A), in net satisfaction with access to public benefits (Panel B), and in net confidence on income support in six income-loss circumstances (Panel C) per unit change in each independent variable, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Summary of estimates from multilevel mixed effect linear models (OECD RTM: Online Annex Tables A3.10.1, A3.11.1 and A3.13a.1, Models 4, 5 and 6) and linear regression models (GBR: Online Annex Tables A3.10.2, A3.11.2 and A3.13a.2, Models 4, 5 and 6). The dependent variables are average net agreement about household access to "good quality and affordable public services" in eight specified policy areas (Panel A), the net balance of responses to the question "To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement? I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them" (Panel B), and average net average about the adequacy of government income support in six specified circumstances (Panel C). Error bars set at the 95% confidence interval. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.

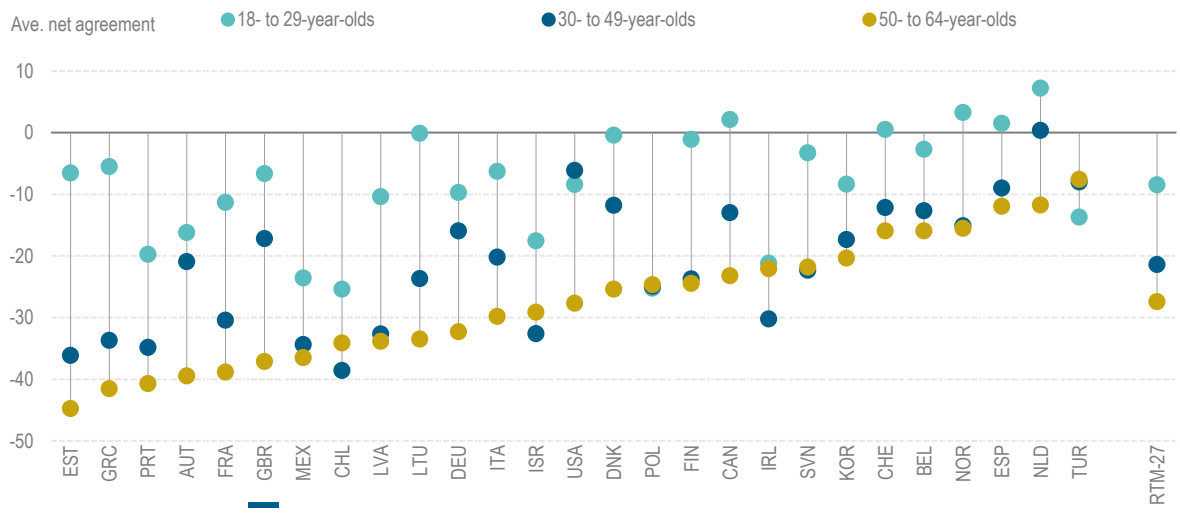
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Age is another factor feeding into satisfaction, especially in the United Kingdom. In general, older respondents are less likely than younger respondents to believe they could easily access public benefits and services if they needed them (Figure 3.10, Panels A and B), and that the government would provide them with adequate income support in case of income loss (Figure 3.10, Panel C). However, the strength of the age gradient varies across countries, and age plays a stronger role in the United Kingdom than in many of the other countries covered by Risks That Matter (Online Annex Tables A3.10.2, A3.11.2 and A3.13a.2). For example, in the United Kingdom, net average (dis)agreement on the adequacy of government income support sits at -37 points among 50- to 64-year-old respondents, compared to -7 points among 18- to 29-year-olds (Figure 3.11). Only five countries (Estonia, Greece, Portugal, Austria and France) see stronger dissatisfaction among 50- to 64-year-olds, and only three (Estonia, Greece and Lithuania) see larger gaps in satisfaction across age groups.

The age gap in satisfaction is perhaps best illustrated by age differences in perceived access to health-related benefits and services. As outlined in OECD (2023[1]), older respondents are consistently more likely than younger adults to doubt they could access good-quality and affordable public healthcare if needed, and express scepticism about the level of government income support provided in case of illness or disability. In both cases, age gaps in the United Kingdom are substantially larger than the OECD RTM average.

Figure 3.11. Age shapes satisfaction with benefits and services more strongly in the United Kingdom than in many other countries

Average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six income-loss circumstances, by age group, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Income shocks may matter as much as income levels for satisfaction

Income and economic insecurity also feed into public benefits and service satisfaction, albeit in ways that are not always straightforward (OECD, 2019[12]).

Links between satisfaction and income level itself are mixed. Overall associations with income are relatively small and sensitive to model specification (Figure 3.10; Online Annex Tables A3.10.1, A3.11.1 and A3.13a.1), in part because they differ in size and direction across countries (Online Annex Tables A3.10.2, A3.11.2 and A3.13a.2, Model 4). To take one example, results from this report's regression models suggest the effect of moving up an income decile on net confidence in government income support differs from a decrease of 2.1 points in Lithuania to an increase of 2.0 points in Belgium (Figure 3.13). The United Kingdom notably has one of the steepest positive income gradients, indicating that confidence in government income support may grow with income. This would be surprising as the tightly targeted nature

of many UK public benefits means that in proportional terms, income replacement often falls sharply as income rises.

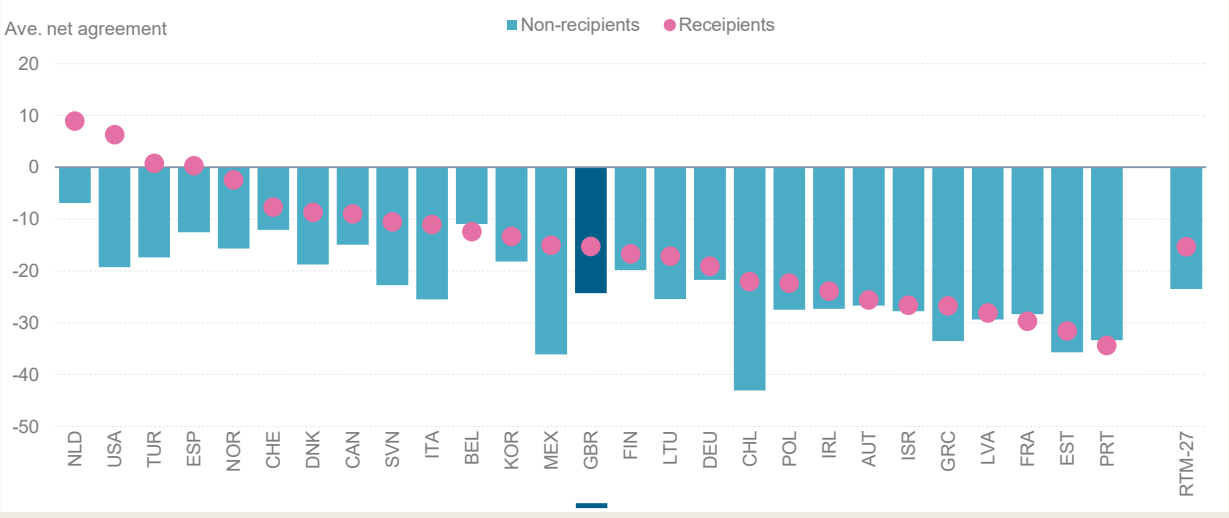
Box 3.3. Does recent experience with benefit receipt increase satisfaction?

Who better to comment on benefit adequacy than benefit recipients themselves? As part of its background questionnaire, OECD Risks That Matter 2022 asked respondents whether they or anyone in their household received a series of public cash benefits in the previous 12 months, including unemployment benefits, disability benefits, housing support, family benefits, and pensions. 30% of respondents in the United Kingdom reported that they had received at least one benefit over the year, compared to an average of 40% across all 27 OECD RTM countries. Using this information, it is possible to examine differences in public benefit satisfaction between benefit recipients and non-recipients.

Results suggest that on average, self-reported cash benefit recipients are more satisfied with public benefits than non-recipients. Respondents who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months are more likely to believe they could easily access benefits if needed, even after controlling for income and other individual characteristics (Figure 3.10 , Panel B), and are more likely to believe that the government would provide adequate income support in case of income loss (Figure 3.10, Panel C). However, the extent to which recipient status shapes satisfaction differs markedly across countries (Figure 3.12).

Figure 3.12. On average, cash benefit recipients are more satisfied with government income support than non-recipients

Average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six specified circumstances, by self-reported benefit receipt status, by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

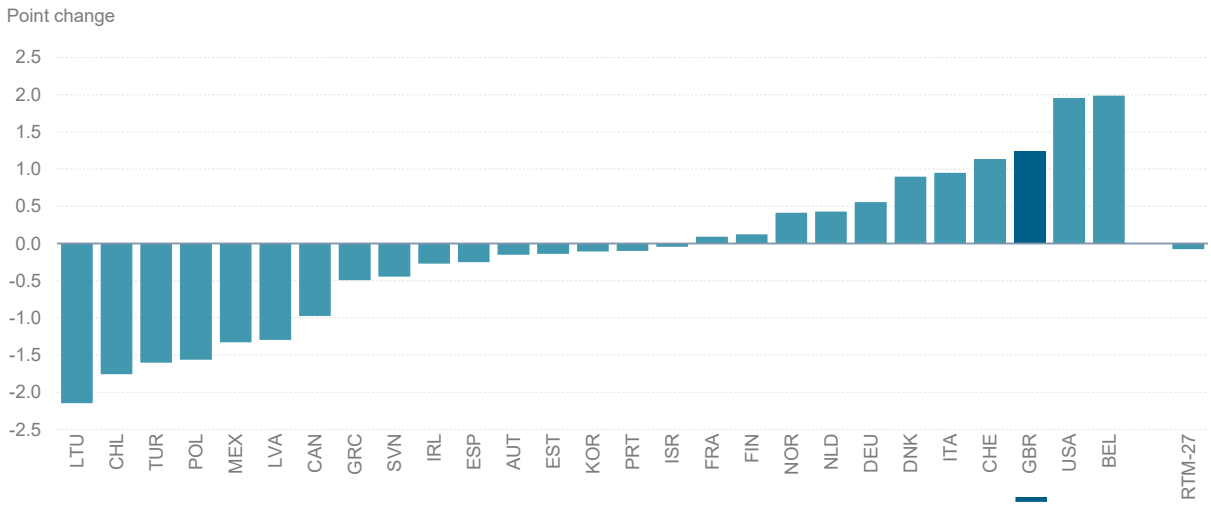


Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". "Recipients" are those who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

In the United Kingdom, average net agreement on the adequacy of government income support sits at -15 points among respondents who report having received at least one benefit, compared to -24 points among those who have not. This gap between the two is slightly larger than the average (8 points).

Figure 3.13. Confidence in government income support grows with income in the United Kingdom

Estimated point change in average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support per unit increase in income decile, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



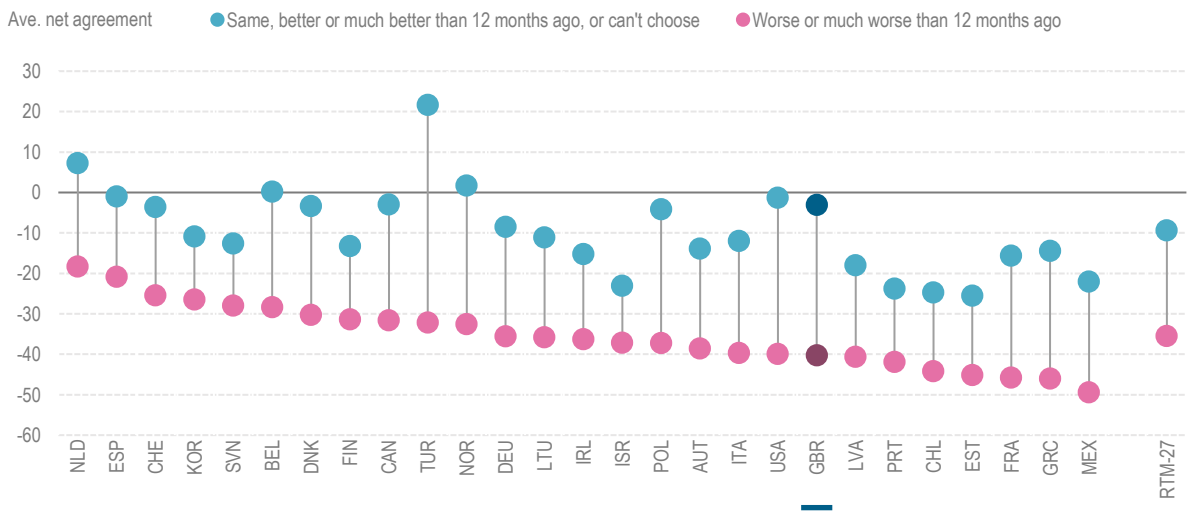
Note: Results from multilevel mixed-effects and country-specific linear regression models (Online Annex Table A3.11.2, Model 4). The dependent variable is a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Measures relating to economic security are more clearly associated with satisfaction. As discussed in OECD (2023[1]), respondents who are concerned about their ability to make ends meet over the next couple of years feel less well-supported by government than those with no such concerns. For example, across RTM countries, half (50%) of those who report being concerned about making ends meet also do not think that they could easily receive public benefits if they needed them, compared to 40% among those not concerned about making ends meet (OECD, 2023[1]).

In a similar vein, looking backwards, respondents who report that their household finances have deteriorated in the past year also report substantially lower satisfaction with public benefits and services, even after controlling for income (Figure 3.10). For example, net agreement on the adequacy of government income support is on average 26 points lower among respondents who report that their finances have worsened in the past year (-36 points) than among those who do not (-9 points) (Figure 3.14). The gap in the United Kingdom is as large as 37 points – the 3rd largest among covered countries. In line with several studies on the effects of economic shocks on attitudes towards redistribution and welfare policy (Blekesaune, 2013[15]; Margalit, 2013[16]; Hacker, Rehm and Schlesinger, 2013[17]), income shocks appear at least as important as income levels for shaping public benefit and service satisfaction.

Figure 3.14. Confidence in income support is lower among respondents who feel their finances have deteriorated in the last year, especially in the United Kingdom

Average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six income-loss circumstances, by response to the question "Do you think that your household's financial situation is better than, the same as, or worse than it was 12 months ago?", 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Younger people, university graduates, and current benefit recipients are among those who are less likely to report feelings of injustice in benefit receipt

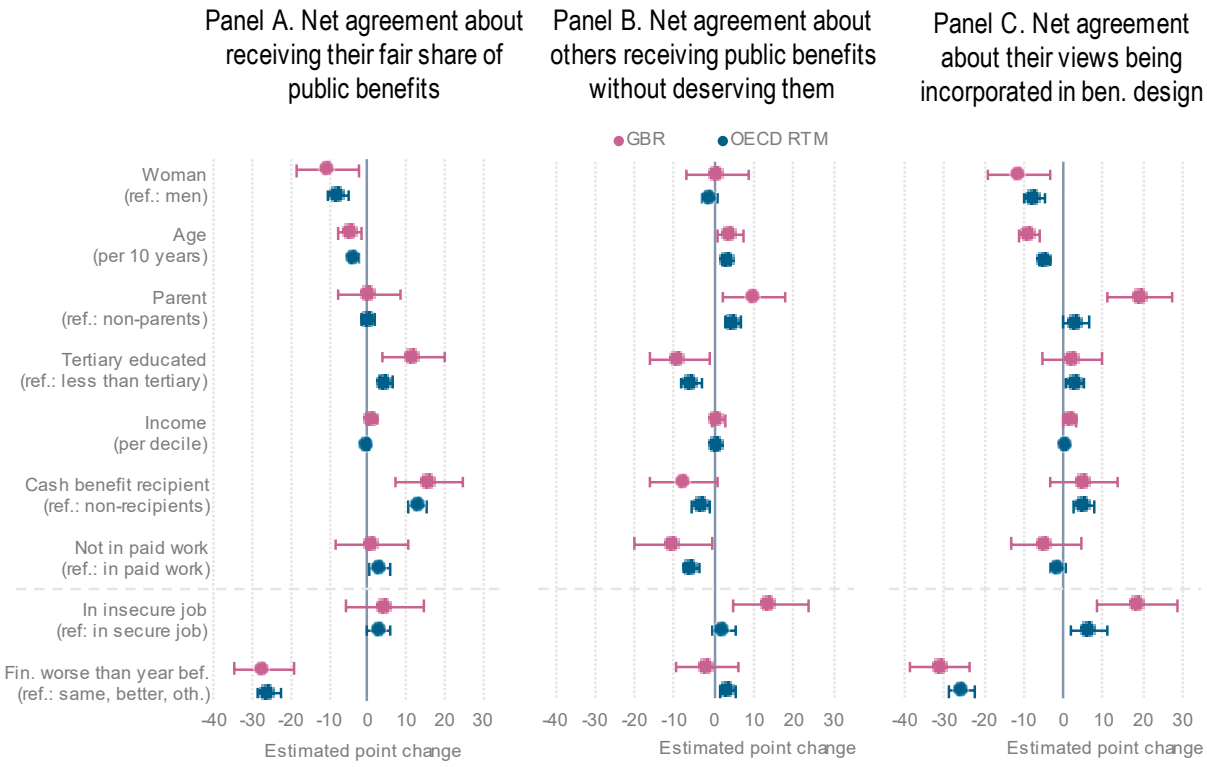
Perceptions of fairness in benefit receipt differ in mostly similar ways. Women and older respondents are less likely than men and younger people to believe that they receive their fair share of benefits, with older respondents also more likely to believe that many others receive public benefits without deserving them (Figure 3.15, Panels A and B). Respondents with tertiary education and who are out of work are more likely to feel they are receiving their fair share, and are less likely to believe others are receiving more than they should, especially in the United Kingdom. Those who report that their household finances have deteriorated in the past year are particularly unlikely to believe they are receiving what they deserve, further underlining the general disillusionment felt by this group.

One finding of note is that respondents who are self-reported public benefit recipients are less likely to report feelings of unfairness in benefit receipt. Work from the United Kingdom (Baumberg Geiger, 2016[18]) has suggested that benefit claimants can be at least as critical of others receiving benefits as non-claimants. Here, controlling for other factors, respondents who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months are more likely to feel they are receiving their fair share of public benefits and, more notably, are less likely to believe that others are receiving public benefits without deserving them (Figure 3.15, Panels A and B). In the United Kingdom, net agreement that others receive benefits without

deserving them is about 8 points lower among benefit recipients than non-recipients, all else equal (Figure 3.15).

Figure 3.15. Perceptions of fairness in benefit receipt differ across social groups

Estimated point change in respondent net agreement about receiving their fair share of public benefits (Panel A), about others receiving public benefits without deserving them (Panel B), and about the views of people like them being incorporated in the design of public benefits and services (Panel C) per unit change in each independent variable, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Summary of results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (OECD RTM: Online Annex Tables A3.12.1, A3.15.1 and A3.16.1, Models 4, 5 and 6) and country-specific linear regression models (GBR: Online Annex Tables A3.12.2, A3.15.2 and A3.16.2, Models 4, 5 and 6). The dependent variables are the net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: I feel that I receive a fair share of public benefits, given the taxes and social contributions I pay and/or have paid in the past." (Panel A), the net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: Many people receive public benefits without deserving them" (Panel B), and the net balance of responses to the question "Please indicate the degree to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: I feel the government incorporates the views of people like me when designing or reforming public benefits and services" (Panel C). Error bars set at the 95% confidence interval. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.

Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

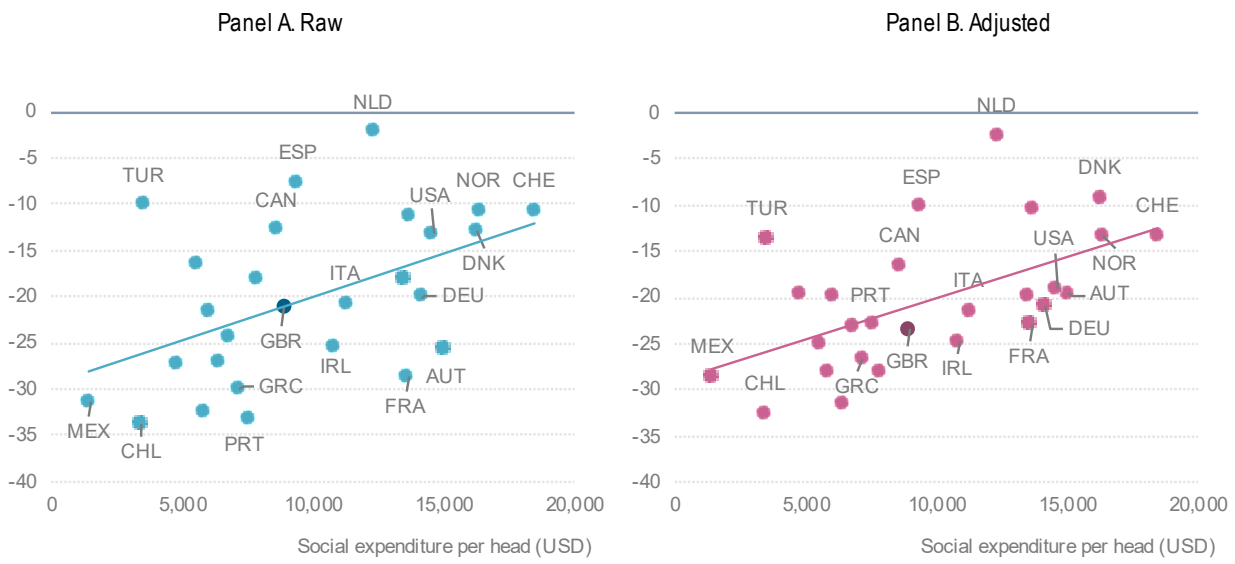
More expansive social protection is associated with greater satisfaction in some but not all social policy areas

General satisfaction is often (but not always) higher in countries that spend more on social issues

Running a more expansive social protection system may help contribute to greater overall satisfaction with public services and benefits. While there are important exceptions (e.g. France), satisfaction tends to be higher in countries with more extensive social protection systems (e.g. Denmark, Norway, Switzerland), and lower in countries with comparatively limited supports (e.g. Chile, Greece). Confidence in government income support, for example, is positively correlated with public and mandatory private social expenditure (Figure 3.16, Panel A; r = 0.49), especially after controlling other factors (Figure 3.16, Panel B; r = 0.56; Online Annex Table A3.11.1, Models 11 and 12). Patterns are largely similar for satisfaction with public service access, although the association is not statistically significant at the 10% level, in part because of the influence of France as an outlier (Online Annex Table A3.10.1, Models 11 and 12). However, once other factors are controlled for, satisfaction with benefit access is only very weakly associated with social expenditure (Online Annex Table A3.13a.1).

Figure 3.16. Confidence in income support is correlated with spending on social issues

Total public and mandatory private social expenditure per head (USD 2015 PPP) and average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six income-loss circumstances, before and after adjusting for population composition and GDP per capita



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A3.11.1, Model 11). Average net agreement based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in six specified income-loss circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in population composition (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. Social expenditure is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on social expenditure per head refer to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and the OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

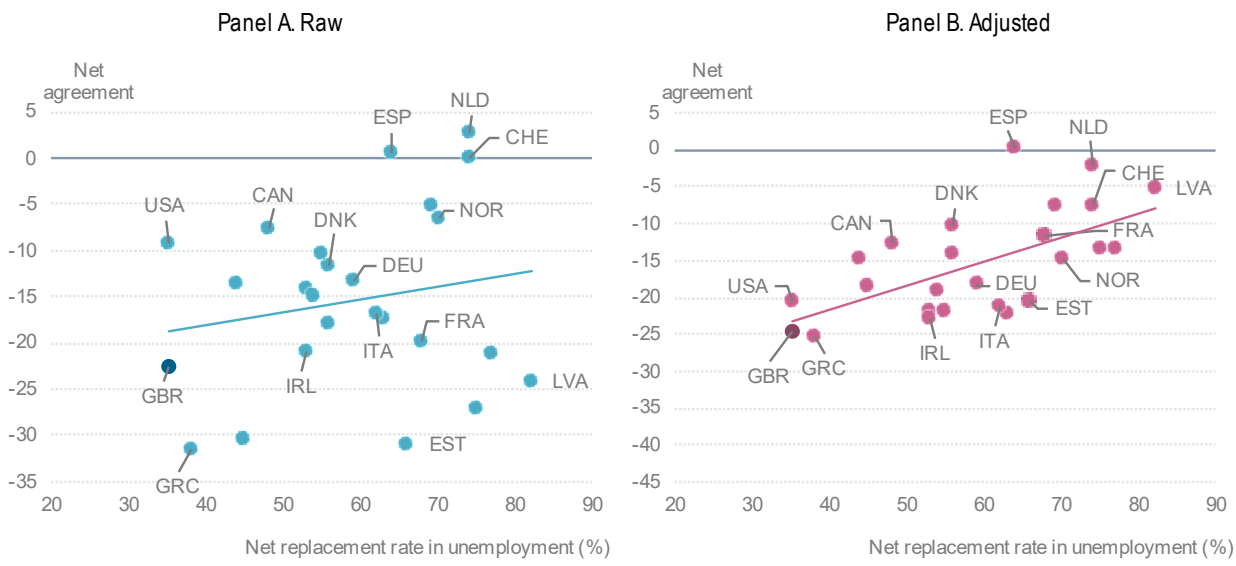
Confidence in unemployment and old-age income support is higher in countries with more generous unemployment benefits and pensions

Policy structure and design can be linked to satisfaction in at least some specific topic areas, especially in the case of satisfaction with benefits and income support.

Take confidence in government income support following unemployment, for instance. Unemployment support is a core component of social protection (ILO, 2012[19]) and almost all OECD countries have unemployment insurance programmes designed to provide income security in case of job loss (OECD, 2024[20]). The United Kingdom, for its part, has one of the OECD's least generous unemployment benefit schemes: in 2022, for a single average earner two months into unemployment, unemployment benefits replaced just 35% of previous income – the second lowest replacement rate in the OECD after Australia (28%), and not far off half the OECD average rate (59%) (OECD, 2024[20]). Country comparisons suggest these comparatively limited benefits could contribute to lower felt support: looking across countries, confidence in unemployment income support tends to be higher in countries where unemployment benefits are more generous, at least after adjusting for population factors and GDP per capita (Figure 3.17, Panel B; r = 0.62) (Online Annex Table A3.11a.1, Model 21), as well as in countries with higher public spending on unemployment (Online Annex Table A3.11a.1, Model 19 and 20). Employment regulation and stricter protection from dismissal may contribute too (Online Annex Table A3.11a.1, Model 23 and 24), perhaps because of the security and stability it provides to workers and their families.

Figure 3.17. Confidence in unemployment support is higher in countries where unemployment benefits are more generous, especially after adjusting for population composition and GDP

Net replacement rate in unemployment and net balance of responses to the question "I think that the government does/would provide my household and me with adequate income support in the case of income loss due to... Unemployment", before and after adjusting for population composition and GDP per capita

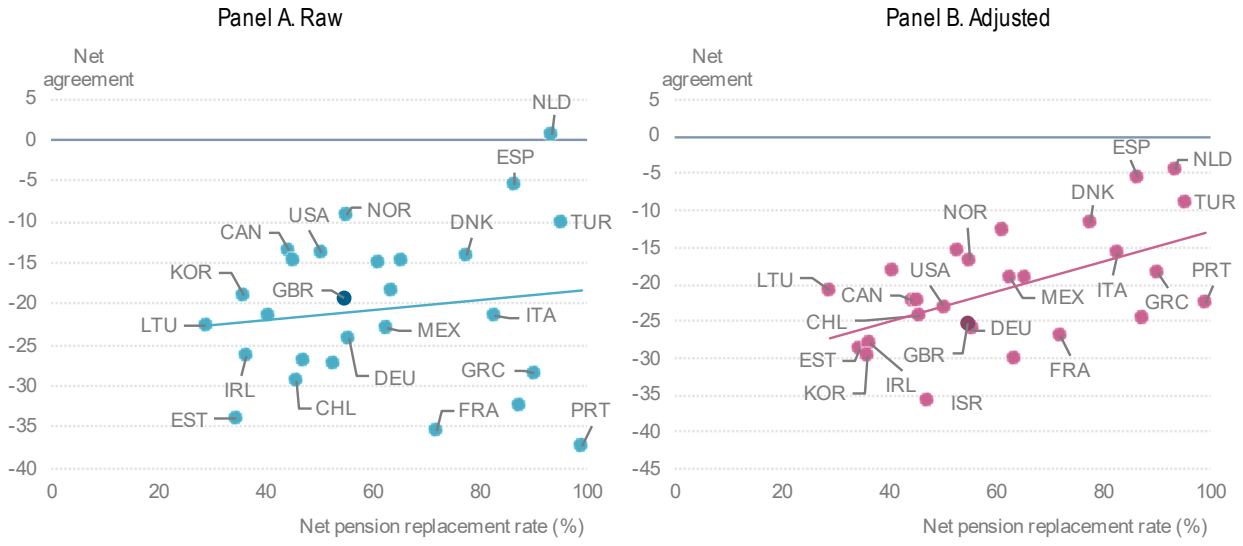


Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A3.11a.1, Model 21). Net agreement is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. The net replacement rate in unemployment is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on unemployment replacement rates refer to net household income in the second month of unemployment as a percentage of net household income before job loss. Estimates are based on a single person with no children previously earning 100% of average earnings. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and the OECD Tax-Benefit Data Portal, www.oecd.org/social/benefits-and-wages/data/.

The same is true in several other income support areas. For example, confidence in government old-age income support tends to be higher in countries with more generous pensions, at least after controlling for population composition and GDP per capita (Figure 3.18, Panel B; r = 0.55; Online Annex Table A3.11e.1, Model 21),[1] as well as in countries with lower pensioner poverty rates (Online Annex Table A3.11e.1, Model 23). Similarly, countries that spend more public money on incapacity-related benefits often have fewer respondents who lack confidence in government income support in case of illness or disability (Online Annex Table A3.11b.1, Model 20). In both cases, there is room for the United Kingdom to boost spending and benefit generosity: at 54% of pre-retirement earnings for a man previously on average earnings, UK pension net replacement rates are lower than the OECD average (61%), and well below the rates in the Netherlands (93%), Türkiye (95%) and Portugal (99%) (OECD, 2023[21]), while UK public spending on incapacity related benefits and services (USD (2015) 585 per person, or 1.3% of GDP) is likewise lower than OECD average (USD (2015) 963 per person, or 2.0% of GDP) (OECD, 2024[22]).

Figure 3.18. After controlling for other factors, confidence in government old-age income support tends to be higher in countries with more generous pensions

Net pension replacement rate and net balance of responses to the question "I think that the government does/would provide my household and me with adequate income support in the case of income loss due to... Retirement", before and after adjusting for population composition and GDP per capita



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A3.11e.1, Model 21). Net agreement is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. The pension replacement rate is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". The net pension replacement rate is defined as the individual net pension entitlement divided by net pre-retirement earnings, taking into account personal income taxes and social security contributions paid by workers and pensioners. Estimates refer to men previously earning 100% of average earnings. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and (OECD, 2023[21]), *OECD Pensions at a Glance 2023*, https://doi.org/10.1787/678055dd-en

Links between policy and satisfaction with public services are not clear

Links between policy indicators and satisfaction with public service access are less clear. Although there are a few minor exceptions – for example, satisfaction with education services is correlated with country performance on the OECD PISA reading and science (but not mathematics) tests (Online Annex Table A3.10b.1, Models 22-24) – clear associations between policy indicators and public service satisfaction are few and far between. Satisfaction with access to health services, for example, shares no clear association with social spending on health and few clear and logical links with a series of health policy indicators, including bed and physician density (Online Annex Table A3.10e.1).[2] Similarly, satisfaction with access in other public service areas, like employment, housing, disability/incapacity, and long-term care, seem mostly uncorrelated with macro policy indicators (Online Annex Tables A3.10c.1, A3.10d.1, A3.10f.1, A3.10g.1).

Population composition and the economic setting may both matter for satisfaction

Factors other than policy may also shape satisfaction with public services and benefits.

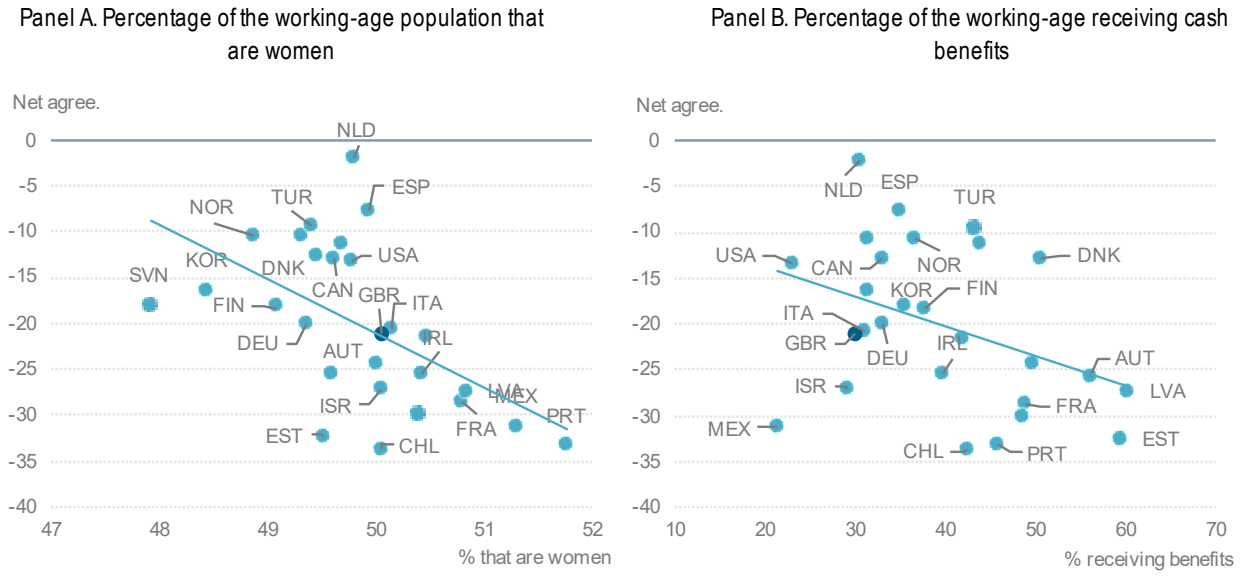
Chapter 2 highlighted between-country differences in population composition as one factor driving country differences in perceived risk, with women's share of the population and the share out of work particularly important. Results from this report's multilevel models suggest population composition may play a role in shaping country differences in satisfaction, too (Online Annex Tables A3.10.1, A3.11.1, and A3.13a.1). Women's share of the population is again important, with satisfaction with both public services and public benefits higher in countries where women's share of the population is lower.[3] This mirrors women's lower satisfaction with benefits and services more generally (see earlier in this chapter). The average age of the working-age population is negatively associated with satisfaction with public service access (Online Annex Table A3.10.1), again echoing older respondents' lower general satisfaction. There is also some suggestion that confidence in government income support is lower in countries where larger shares of the population receive cash benefits (Online Annex Table A3.11.1). This runs counter to the positive within-country association between benefit recipient status and confidence in income support highlighted earlier in this chapter.

Aspects of the economic environment may also play a role in shaping satisfaction with public benefits and services (OECD, 2019[12]). Comparing across countries, benefit and service satisfaction tends to be higher in countries with more developed economies, like the Netherlands, Norway, and the United States. Respondents in countries with higher GDP per capita are substantially more likely to believe they can easily access public benefits (Figure 3.20, Panel A; r= 0.52), for example, even after adjusting for population composition (Figure 3.20, Panel B; r= 0.39) (Online Annex Tables A4.13a.1, Model 4). Respondents in richer economies also tend to express greater satisfaction with public service access and greater confidence in government income support, at least when Ireland is excluded as an outlier (Online Annex Tables A4.10.1 and A4.11.1, Model 7). The United Kingdom, for its part, is a mid-range performer

on GDP per capita (see Chapter 2) and sits correspondingly close to the average on both service and benefit satisfaction, too.

Figure 3.19. Women's share of the population and the share receiving benefits are both correlated with confidence in government income support

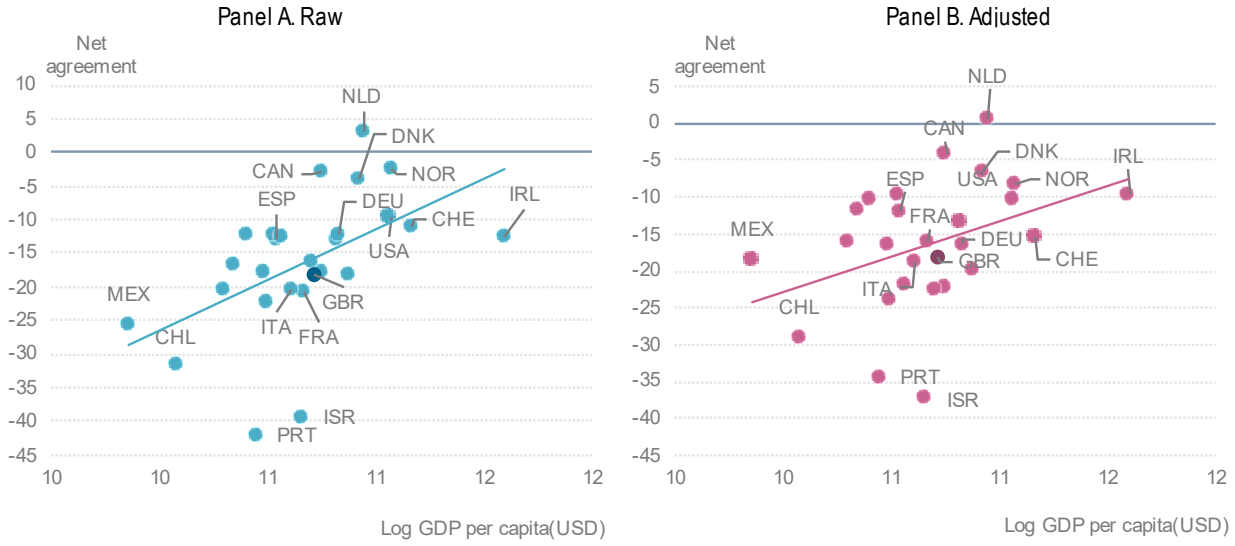
Average net agreement about the adequacy of government income support in six income-loss circumstances, percentage of the working-age population that are women, and percentage of the working-age population not in paid work



Note: Average net agreement is based on a scale measuring respondents' average agreement with the adequacy of government income support in case of income loss in six specified circumstances. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Strongly disagree" for all six items, to 100 in the case that they all chose "Strongly agree". Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. Benefit recipients are those who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Figure 3.20. Respondents in richer countries are more likely to believe they could receive benefits if they needed them

Log GDP per capita (USD 2015 PPP) and net balance of responses to the question "To what degree do you agree or disagree with the following statement?… I feel I could easily receive public benefits if I needed them", before and after adjusting for population composition



Note: Estimates based on predictions from multilevel mixed-effects linear regression models (Online Annex Tables A3.13a.1, Model 4). Net agreement is calculated as the average of the responses "Strongly disagree" (-100), "Disagree" (-50), "Neither agree nor disagree" (0), "Agree" (50) and "Strongly agree" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). GDP per capita is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on GDP per capita refer to 2022. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 3.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD National Accounts, www.oecd.org/sdd/na/.

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YouGov (2024), *Do people on low incomes bringing up children need more support from the benefits system?*, https://yougov.co.uk/topics/politics/trackers/do-people-on-low-incomes-bringing-up-children-need-more-support-from-the-benefits-system. [8]

YouGov (2024), *Do people over 65 need more support from the benefits system?*, https://yougov.co.uk/topics/politics/trackers/do-people-over-65-need-more-support-from-the-benefits-system. [9]

YouGov (2024), *Public support retaining the two-child benefit limit as Starmer gears up for first rebellion*, https://yougov.co.uk/politics/articles/50140-public-support-retaining-the-two-child-benefit-limit-as-starmer-gears-up-for-first-rebellion. [11]

Notes

[1] As noted in previous Risks That Matter reports (OECD, 2019[12]; OECD, 2021[23]; OECD, 2023[1]), raw confidence in government old-age income support is only weakly correlated with pension net replacement rates (Figure 3.18, Panel A; r = 0.13). This notably changes after controlling for population composition and GDP per capita.

[2] The exception is the density of generalist physicians, which is negatively associated with net agreement on access to "good quality and affordable" public health services (Online Annex Table A3.10e.1, Model 18). This association seems likely spurious.

[3] See endnote 1 in Chapter 2 for a note on women's share of the working-age population in the United Kingdom.

4 What does the United Kingdom want from social protection?

This chapter explores social policy preferences in the United Kingdom. Based on data from OECD Risks That Matter 2022, it examines whether people in the United Kingdom want more or less from social protection, and where their priorities lie. Results suggest that, similar to many other OECD countries, many people in the United Kingdom want more support from government, especially women, older respondents and those exposed to economic shocks. Health care services are the priority action area for people in the United Kingdom, followed by long-term care services and old-age pensions.

This chapter focuses on social policy preferences in the United Kingdom and how they compare to other OECD countries. Based on four questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 (Box 4.1), it asks what people in the United Kingdom want from social policy, and where their priorities lie. Questions look at whether respondents would be prepared to see taxes increase in order to receive better support, as well as whether they would like an increase in redistribution from the affluent to those on lower incomes.

Results suggest that as in other OECD countries, many people in the United Kingdom want more support from government. Just over three-quarters of UK respondents to Risks That Matter say the government should be doing more to secure their economic and social well-being – a rate just slightly above the average, and higher than in most other G7 countries. Even when they are reminded about the taxes they might have to pay, large numbers of UK respondents say that they would like the government to increase spending on social policies. Two-thirds think that the rich should be taxed more to help support the poor. This support for an expansion of social protection mirrors evidence from UK sources that show attitudes have been shifting in favour of taxation, spending, and redistribution for about a decade or so.

Health care services are the priority action area for people in the United Kingdom. Just over three-quarters of respondents in the United Kingdom say they would like the government to spend more on healthcare, even after being reminded about the taxes they pay. Long-term care services and old-age pensions are the next most popular policy areas, but in absolute terms receive far less support than health. Unemployment sits bottom of the UK policy priority list, reflecting the UK's comparatively hard (if softening) attitudes towards unemployment benefit recipients.

Policy preferences differ across groups, reflecting in part differences in perceptions and satisfaction with existing social protection arrangements. Women, older respondents, and those exposed to economic shocks are all more likely than others to want more spending and more support from government. In most countries, calls for spending and redistribution tend also to fall with education and income. This is notably not the case in the United Kingdom, where demands for spending and redistribution are just as strong, if not stronger, among people with high education or high incomes. Indeed, in the United Kingdom, support for redistribution is higher among high-income respondents than the cross-country average for low-income respondents.

While people in all countries want more from government, demands tend to be stronger where current social supports are limited. Links between current policy and preferences for future policy are known to be complex, but country comparison shows that people are more likely to call for support and spending when they live in countries with comparatively slim social protection systems. However, links between policy and preferences in specific policy areas are mixed, with respondents not always more likely to call for spending when their country spends comparatively little in a given area. In the United Kingdom, for instance, respondents are relatively unlikely to call for increased pension or unemployment spending despite the comparatively low amounts the country spends in these areas. Health care remains top of the list despite it already being the largest item in UK public social expenditure.

Box 4.1. Questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022 used in this chapter

This chapter is built around four main questions from OECD Risks That Matter 2022. The first of these questions focuses on respondents' felt needs for more support from government:

- Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?

Possible response options were: 1. Much less; 2. Less; 3. About the same as now; 4. More; 5. Much more; and 6. Can't choose.

The next two questions concentrate on preferences for increased government spending in a range of social policy areas. The first provides respondents with a soft reminder about the taxes they might have to pay in order to receive better benefits and services in each area; the second explicitly asks respondents whether they would be happy to pay an additional 2% of their income for it:

- Thinking about the taxes you and your family might have to pay and the benefits you and your family might receive, would you like to see the government spend less, spend the same, or spend more in each of the following areas?
- Would you be willing to pay an additional 2% of your income in taxes/social contributions to benefit from better provision of and access to:

In both cases, the policy areas (items) given were: Family supports; Education services and supports; Employment supports; Unemployment supports; Income supports; Housing supports; Health; Disability/incapacity-related supports; Old-age pensions; Long-term care services for elderly people; Public safety; and Public transport. The second of the two questions also provided respondents with the following two response options: I would not be willing to spend an extra 2% on any of these things; and Can't choose/don't know.

The last question focuses on income redistribution. It asks respondents whether the government should increase taxation on the "rich" with the explicit purpose of better supporting the poor:

- Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?

Possible response options were: 1. Definitely no; 2. No; 3. Neutral; 4. Yes; 5. Definitely yes; and 6. Can't choose.

Source: OECD (2023) OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022: Core Questionnaire, https://webfs.oecd.org/Els-com/RtM/OECD-Risks-That-Matter-2022-Core-Questionnaire.pdf.

People in the United Kingdom want more help from government, with healthcare the priority

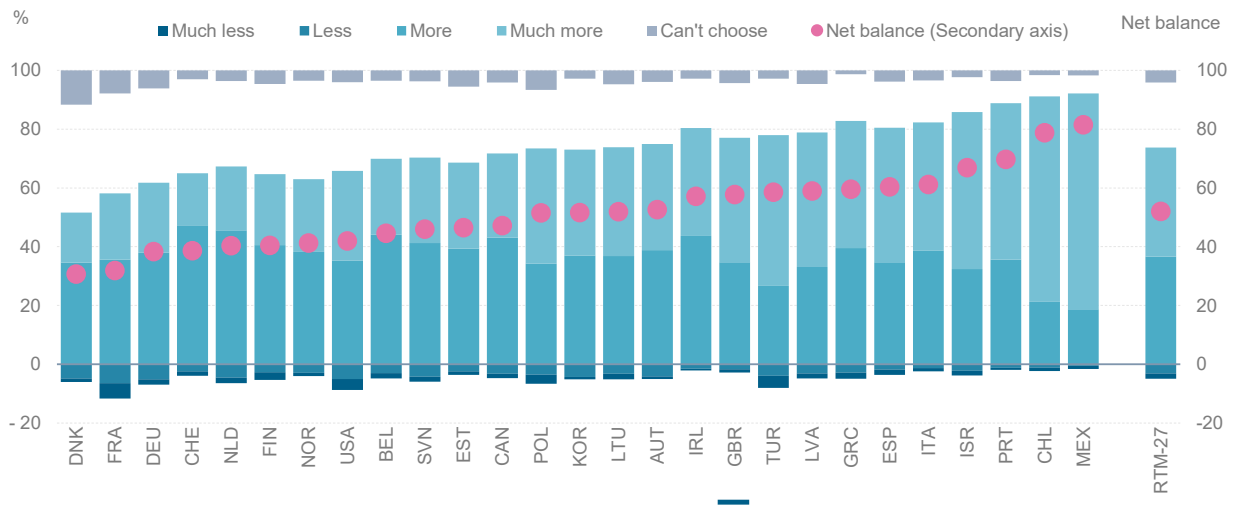
People in the United Kingdom want more support from government

Respondents from across the OECD overwhelmingly call for more support from government, even at the cost of higher taxes (OECD, 2023[1]). On average, just under three-quarters (74%) of respondents say that the government should be doing more or much more to protect their economic and social security, rising as high as more than 90% in Chile and Mexico (Figure 4.1). Support for more government spending on social policy remains high even when respondents are asked to consider the taxes they have to pay (Figure 4.2).

Respondents in the United Kingdom express stronger demands for government support than respondents in many of its peer countries. Just over three-quarters (77%) of UK respondents think that the government should be doing more to secure their economic and social security, with as many as 42% believing they should be doing "much more" (Figure 4.1). Only 3% of UK respondents say that the government should be doing less. The UK's overall net preference for more government support (58 points) is stronger than in other covered members of the G7 except Italy (61 points), and are far stronger than in Denmark (31 points) and France (32 points) in particular.

Figure 4.1. Three-quarters of people in the United Kingdom want more support from government

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

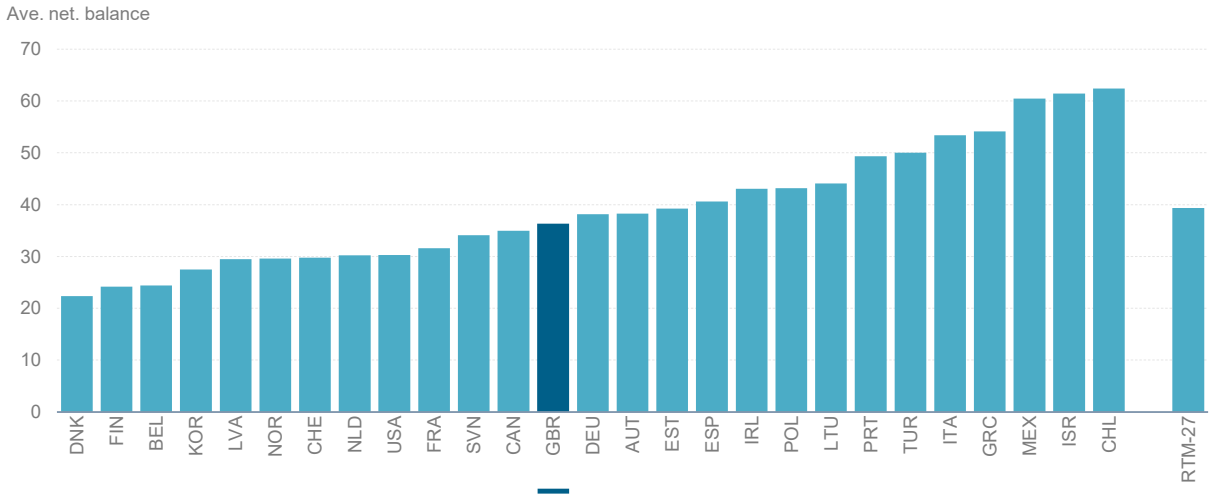


Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 4.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

As in many other countries, support for government action falls but remains high when respondents are asked to consider cost. After prompting respondents to think about "the taxes you and your family might have to pay and the benefits you and your family might receive", Risks That Matter asks whether the government should spend less, the same, or more in 12 policy areas (Figure 4.2). On average across the 12 areas, UK respondents are substantially more likely to want more, rather than less, spending, with the average net preference for more spending standing at 36 points. This is slightly lower than the OECD RTM average (39 points) and roughly similar to Canada (35 points) and Germany (38 points). This broad demand for increased intervention echoes findings from the UK's British Social Attitudes survey, which show that roughly half of the United Kingdom is in favour of increasing taxes to spend more on "health, education and social benefits" (Curtice, 2022[2]).

Figure 4.2. Many in the United Kingdom want more government spending even when they are reminded about the taxes they might have to pay

Average net balance of responses when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Average net balance is based on a scale measuring respondents' average response when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas. The underlying responses are scaled as follows: "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100). The final scale can range from -100 in the case that all respondents in the given country chose "Much less" for all 12 items, to 100 in the case that they chose "Much more" for all items. Estimates exclude respondents with three or fewer valid responses. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

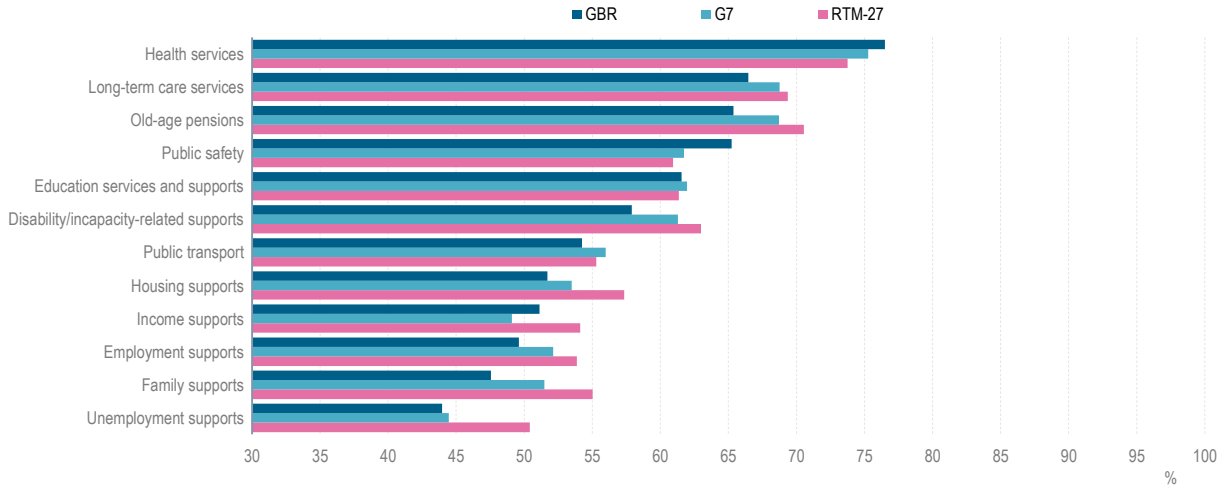
Health care services are the clear priority for people in the United Kingdom

Similar to many OECD countries (OECD, 2023[1]), healthcare services are the priority action area for people in the United Kingdom. Just over three-quarters (76%) of respondents in the United Kingdom say they would like the government to spend more on healthcare, even after being reminded about the taxes they might have to pay (Figure 4.3). This is 10 percentage points higher than in any other policy area. As many as half (50%) of UK respondents say that they'd be prepared to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes to access better healthcare services, a share well above the OECD RTM average (43%) and the average across members of the G7 (41%) (Figure 4.4). Domestic polling data similarly point to healthcare as the dominant policy priority for many in the United Kingdom (YouGov, 2024[3]).

Long-term care services and old-age pensions are the next most popular policy areas. About two-thirds (66% and 65%, respectively) of UK respondents say they would like the government to spend more in these areas (Figure 4.3), and just under one-third (30%) would be prepared to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes to get it (Figure 4.4). The share of UK respondents prepared to pay more in tax to access better pensions is notably lower than the OECD RTM average (37%), despite people in the United Kingdom being just as concerned about income in old-age as people elsewhere (see Chapter 2 and later in this chapter).

Figure 4.3. More than three-quarters of UK respondents would like more government spending on healthcare services…

Percentage of respondents who believe that the government should spend more or much more in each policy area, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Data are based on responses to the question "Thinking about the taxes you and your family might have to pay and the benefits you and your family might receive, would you like to see the government spend less, spend the same, or spend more in each of the following areas?". See Box 4.1 for question wording. G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Family and unemployment supports come bottom of the priority list for people in the United Kingdom. Less than half of UK respondents would like more spending in these two areas (Figure 4.3), with 20% or less willing to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes for it (Figure 4.4). These shares are similar to the respective averages across G7 members but well below the corresponding OECD RTM averages. This is notable because current UK policy is comparatively limited in both areas: unemployment benefits are among the least generous in the OECD (see Chapter 3), while childcare is more expensive in the United Kingdom than in any other OECD country (OECD, 2023[4]), at least until new entitlements kick in in 2024. However, their low ranking is not unexpected: Brits have historically held comparatively hostile attitudes to unemployment benefit recipients (Box 4.3) and are more likely than people in other (European) countries to see family services like childcare as being outside of government responsibility (Applica sprl et al., 2020[5]).

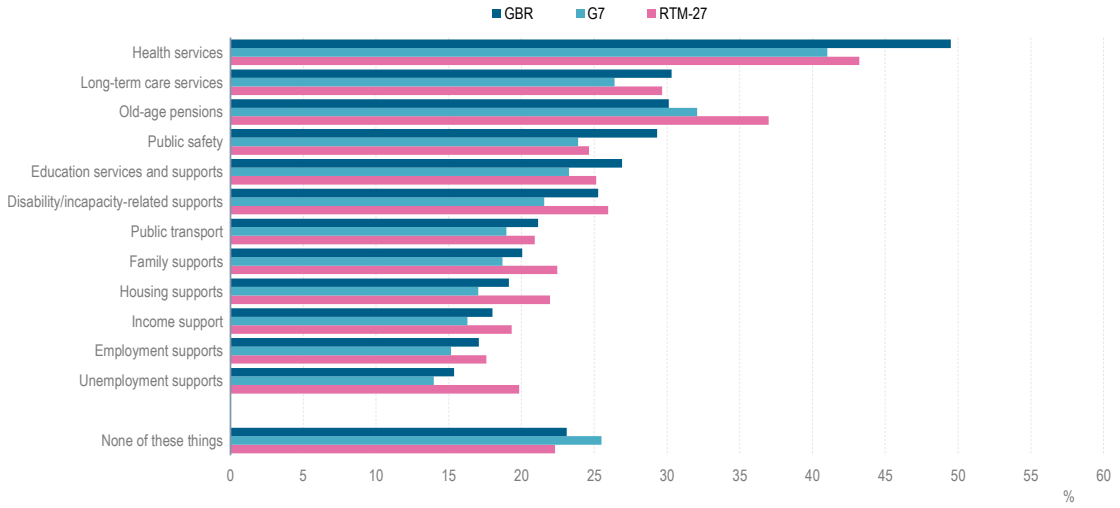
People in the United Kingdom are more likely than people in most other countries to support increasing taxes on the rich

Taxes on high earners are moderate in the United Kingdom relative to other OECD countries (OECD, 2024[6]) and evidence from OECD RTM and elsewhere (Box 4.2) suggests there is growing appetite among many in the United Kingdom for increasing taxes on the rich if it helps better support the poor. Two-thirds (67%) of UK respondents to Risks That Matter say that the government should tax the rich more to help support the poor, with only 13% stating that they should not (Figure 4.5). In comparative terms, only respondents in Greece and Portugal express stronger support for increasing taxes on the rich, although the United Kingdom is followed closely by respondents from several other major economies, including Canada and Germany. Domestic polling from YouGov points to a similar share of people in the United Kingdom (63% in October 2022) who believe that "the rich are not paying enough and their taxes should be increased" (YouGov, 2024[7]). More generally, attitudes in the United Kingdom have been shifting

in favour of tax, spend and redistribution for about a decade or so, perhaps as a reaction to declining real spending on many public benefits and services (Box 4.2).

Figure 4.4. …and almost half would be prepared to give an additional 2% of their income in taxes to pay for it

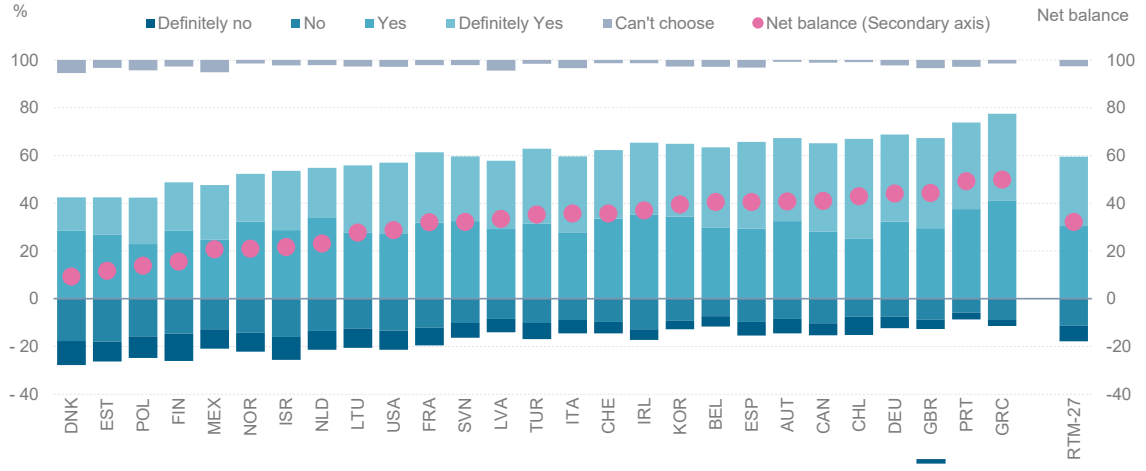
Percentage of respondents who report being willing to pay an additional 2% of their income in taxes/social contributions to benefit from better provision of and access to supports and services in each policy area, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom, G7 average and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Data are based on responses to the question "Would you be willing to pay an additional 2% of your income in taxes/social contributions to benefit from better provision of and access to...". G7 refers to the unweighted average across the six available members of the G7 group of major economies. See Box 4.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Figure 4.5. Two-thirds of Brits think that the rich should be taxed more to help support the poor

Distribution and net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?", by country, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022



Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Definitely no" (-100), "No" (-50), "Neutral" (0), "Yes" (50) and "Definitely yes" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. See Box 4.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Box 4.2. Support for redistribution has been growing in the United Kingdom over the last decade or so, possibly as a response to cuts to public benefits and services

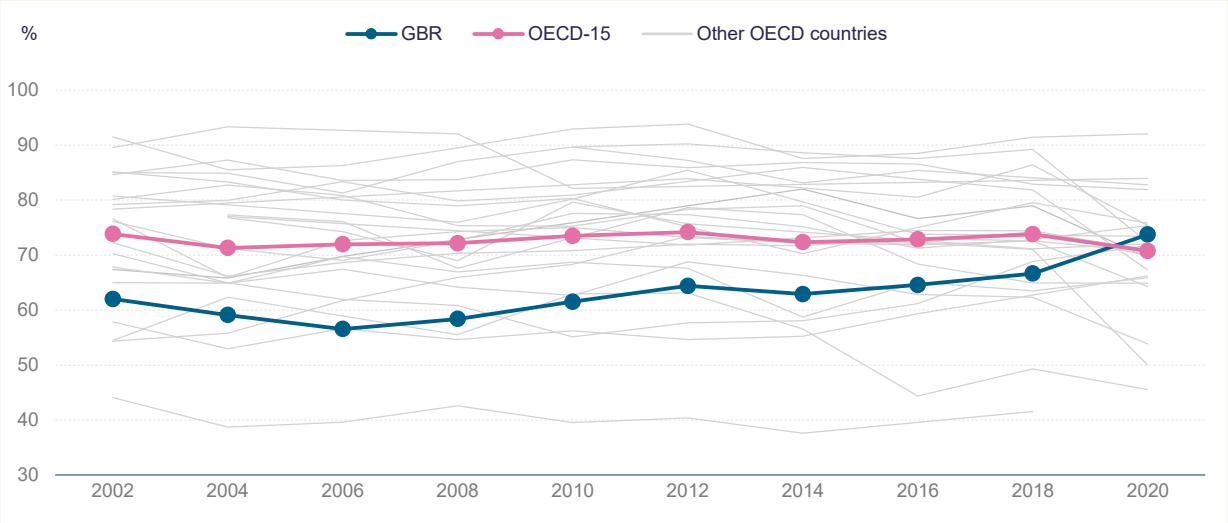
There is a long-standing debate in political science on the extent to which public opinion tends to favour established policy structures (the positive feedback model) or oppose them (the negative feedback or public thermostat model). Proponents of the positive feedback model argue that policies often shape public attitudes in self-reinforcing cycles, with existing policy structures influencing opinion in ways that favour preservation of the status quo (Pierson, 1993[8]; Pierson, 1994[9]; Pierson, 2000[10]). Established policies (especially highly inclusive ones) build coalitions of support, leading to policy structures becoming "locked in" (Jordan, 2013[11]). In contrast, those in favour of the public thermostat model suggest that the public has a fairly stable "ideal" level of policy activity and adjust their stated preferences as a counter-cyclical response to current policies: put simply, people are more likely to favour expansion when government support is cut, and to remove their support as it increases (Wlezien, 1995[12]; Curtice, 2010[13]; Soroka and Wlezien, 2010[14]). Busemeyer et al. (2021[15]) argue that the two processes can co-exist, with attitudes potentially adjusting in a "thermostatic" manner in the short-term but following a consistent (and potentially self-reinforcing) trajectory in the longer term.

In the United Kingdom, attitudes have been shifting in favour of taxation, spending, and redistribution over the past decade or so, in a manner that many interpret as a "thermostatic" response to declining real spending on many public benefits and services (Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[16]; Curtice, 2021[17]; Curtice and Scholes, 2023[18]; Defty, 2024[19]). Spending on benefits and services has fallen since the financial crisis, while targeting and conditionality have increased (see Chapter 1). At the same time, support for government intervention has increased markedly (Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[16]). Data from British Social Attitudes show that the share of the population in favour of increasing taxes to spend more on "health, education and social benefits" has almost doubled since the financial crisis, increasing from 31% in 2010 to 55% in 2023, while the share thinking the government should spend more supporting the poor has increased by just under 10 percentage points (Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[20]; Curtice and Scholes, 2023[18]). Data from the European Social Survey suggest that over a similar period, British attitudes towards redistribution have shifted from some of the least favourable in Europe to above average for European OECD countries (Figure 4.6). This likely represents the continuation of long-running series of thermostat-like swings in UK public opinion. Hudson et al. (2016[21]) examine British opinion towards public benefits and benefit recipients from the Second World War onwards, finding that attitudes have fluctuated back and forth over the period. Curtice and Scholes (2023[18]) demonstrate how attitudes have moved counter-cyclically in response to public spending since the early 1980s.

The latest swing in favour of tax, spend and redistribution presents UK policy makers with a puzzle. On the one hand, it offers a clear signal that the public would like the government to expand social protection. On the other, both public thermostat theory and the history of British public opinion suggest that expansion can only go so far until the public are likely to push back. Polling data is unfortunately not detailed enough to tell policy makers at exactly what level and for how long they'd like expanded social supports (Defty, 2024[19]). The challenge is to find the "middle ground" that fits best with the British public's longer-term aspirations for social protection.

Figure 4.6. UK attitudes to redistribution have shifted from some of the least favourable in Europe to above average for European OECD countries

Percentage that agree (or agree strongly) with the statement "The government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels", 15+ year-olds, OECD countries, 2002-20



Note: Respondents were asked "To what extent do you agree or disagree that… The government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels". Response options were "Agree strongly", "Agree", "Neither agree nor disagree", "Disagree", and "Disagree strongly". The OECD-15 average refers to the unweighted average across the 15 OECD countries with data available for all 10 waves of the ESS.
Source: OECD estimates based on the European Social Survey (ESS) Rounds 1-10 (2002-20), www.europeansocialsurvey.org.

Women, older respondents, and those exposed to economic insecurity all want more support, while in the United Kingdom calls for spending are just as strong, if not stronger, among advantaged as disadvantaged groups

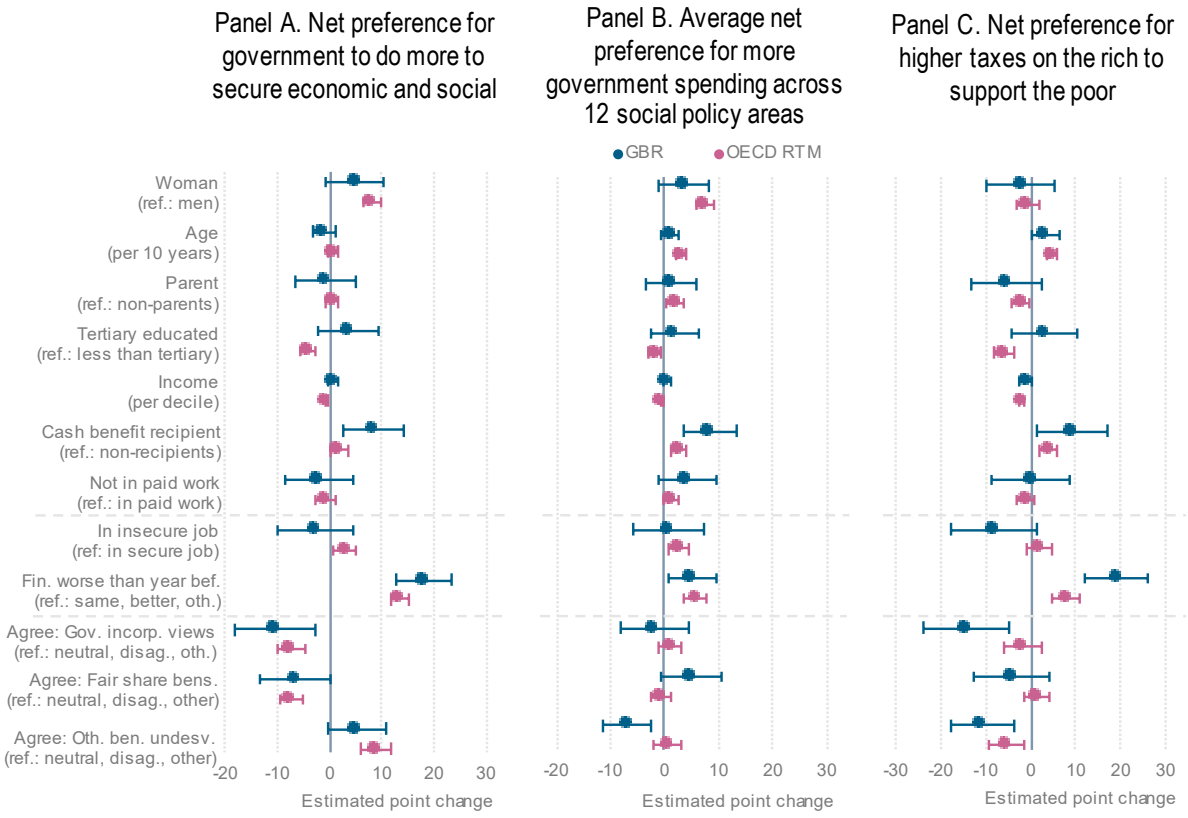
Women and older respondents want more from government

Across OECD countries, including the United Kingdom, calls for support frequently differ between social groups. In-line with both their risk perceptions and thoughts about existing policies, women are more likely than men to want more support from government (Figure 4.7, Panel A) and for the government to spend more on social policies (Figure 4.7, Panel B) (see also Buser et al., (2020[22])). In the United Kingdom, being a woman is associated with an estimated 5-point increase in the net preference for more government support, although the association falls just short of statistical significance at the 5% level (Figure 4.7, Panel A). Support for intervention also often increases with age: older respondents to Risks That Matter are more likely than younger respondents to want the government to spend more on social policies (Figure 4.7, Panel B) and to believe that the government should tax the rich more to support the poor (Figure 4.7, Panel C). Evidence from the United Kingdom confirms this age gap in redistributive preferences but suggests it has emerged only recently: in the 1980s and early 1990s, it was younger (rather than older) people who were more likely to support redistribution, with differences narrowing through the 1990s and 2000s, and reversing in the 2010s (Curtice et al., 2023[23]). Baumberg Geiger and colleagues (2023[20]) believe this reflects generational effects and the feeding through of cohorts with

persistently strong (those born in the 1950s and 1960s) and weak (those born in the 1970s and, more so, the 1980s) preferences for redistribution.

Figure 4.7. In the United Kingdom, as elsewhere, calls for support and spending often differ between social groups

Estimated point change in net preferences for government to do more to ensure economic and social security and well-being (Panel A), for more government spending across 12 social policy areas (Panel B), and for higher taxes on the rich to support the poor (Panel C) per unit change in each independent variable, 18- to 64-year-olds, the United Kingdom and OECD RTM-27 average, 2022



Note: Summary of results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (OECD RTM: Online Annex Tables A4.17.1, A4.18.1 and A4.20.1, Models 4, 5 and 6) and country-specific linear regression models (GBR: Online Annex Tables A4.17.2, A4.18.2 and A4.20.2, Models 4, 5 and 6). The dependent variables are the net balance of responses to the question "Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?" (Panel A), the average net balance when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas (Panel B), and the net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?" (Panel C). Error bars set at the 95% confidence interval. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

In the United Kingdom, people in advantaged socio-economic positions are just as likely, if not more likely, to call for more spending and more redistribution

While far from the only driver (Fong, 2001[24]; Cavaillé and Trump, 2015[25]), economic self-interest is known to be one factor affecting preferences for intervention and redistribution. All else equal, individuals with stronger skills, on higher incomes, and/or in more secure positions financially are expected to prefer lower

taxes and lower spending (Iversen and Soskice, 2001[26]; Rehm, Hacker and Schlesinger, 2012[27]; Durante, Putterman and van der Weele, 2014[28]; OECD, 2021[29]; Alesina and Giuliano, 2011[30]). This includes those with higher education who, despite often expressing a range of progressive social attitudes, tend in many countries to be less supportive of redistribution than their less-educated peers (Gelepithis and Giani, 2022[31]).

The United Kingdom might be different from other countries in this regard. Evidence from Risks That Matter and elsewhere (Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[16]; Baumberg Geiger et al., 2023[20]; YouGov, 2024[7]) suggests that in the United Kingdom, demands for more spending and more redistribution tend to be just as strong, if not stronger, among people in advantaged socio-economic positions as in disadvantaged positions. Results from Risks That Matter show that calls for support, spending and redistribution vary little with income or education in the United Kingdom, especially after controlling for other individual-level characteristics (Figure 4.7, Panels A, B and C). This stands in contrast to most other OECD countries, as well as the RTM sample as a whole, where respondents with higher education or higher incomes are less likely to call for support, spending and redistribution. The underlying difference lies in comparatively strong calls for support and redistribution among people in socio-economically advantaged positions. For example, high-income UK respondents express a level of support for increasing taxes on the rich (40 points) that is stronger not only than high-income respondents in most other countries, but also than the cross-country average for low-income respondents (38 points) (Figure 4.8).

Figure 4.8. Support for increasing taxes on the rich is stronger among high-income UK respondents than the cross-country average for low-income respondents

Net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?", by income level, 18- to 64-year-olds, 2022

Note: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Definitely no" (-100), "No" (-50), "Neutral" (0), "Yes" (50) and "Definitely yes" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Respondents from "low income" households are those in households with equivalised disposable incomes in the bottom three deciles of the national disposable income distribution, and respondents from "high income" households are those with incomes in the top three deciles of the national disposable income distribution. See Box 4.1 for question wording.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html.

Those who report recent receipt of public benefits are more likely to call for government action, in both the United Kingdom as elsewhere. Controlling for other characteristics, including education and income,

respondents who report having received at least one public cash benefit in the past 12 months express greater demands for government support (Figure 4.7, Panel A), are more likely to want the government to spend more on social policies (Figure 4.7, Panel B), and are more likely to call for the government to increase taxes on the rich to support the poor (Figure 4.7, Panel C). Given that benefit recipients also report greater satisfaction with benefits and stronger perceived fairness in benefit receipt (Chapter 3), one explanation is that recent recipients may be more likely to believe that increases in government spending will be put to good use.

Calls for support are greater among people exposed to economic insecurity

Over and above objective socio-economic status, people who have recently experienced financial shocks – and those who are worried that they soon might – tend to express a greater need for support. Evidence from both Europe and the United States suggests that personal experience of economic strain or an economic shock, as well as worries about personal economic shocks, can strengthen preferences for spending and redistribution (Blekesaune, 2013[32]; Margalit, 2013[33]; Rehm, Hacker and Schlesinger, 2012[27]; Alesina and Giuliano, 2011[30]). As noted in Chapter 2, worries about economic security were widespread when Risks That Matter went into the field in October 2022, not least in the United Kingdom, where as many as half of respondents reported that their finances had worsened over the past year (see Box 2.2). Results from Risks That Matter show that respondents who believe that their households finances have deteriorated in the past year also express stronger calls for government support (Figure 4.7, Panel A), for increased spending on social policies (Figure 4.7, Panel B), and for increased taxes on the rich (Figure 4.7, Panel C), even after controlling for income and other characteristics. In the United Kingdom, a deterioration in household finances is associated with a 19-point increase in net preferences for increasing taxes on the rich – one of the largest effects among the 27 covered countries, and well above the OECD RTM average (8 points) (Online Annex Table A4.20.2, Model 5). Respondents who believe that their jobs are insecure also often express stronger calls for government support (Figure 4.7, Panel A) and for increased spending on social policies (Figure 4.7, Panel B) than respondents in (self-reported) secure jobs, although notably not in the United Kingdom.

Those who perceive injustice in benefit receipt are less likely to call for more redistribution – but still want better support from government

Faith and confidence in government and the social protection system also shape calls for support, spending, and redistribution (OECD, 2021[29]). Focusing on measures relating to the tax and public healthcare systems, Svallfors (2013[34]) finds that perceptions of the "quality" of government can influence attitudes to taxes and spending, with those believing that the government is fair and efficient also preferring higher taxes and higher spending. Going one step further, Rothstein, Samanni and Teorel (2012[35]) find that public confidence in the fairness and efficiency of government is central to size and scope of social spending.

Results from Risks That Matter point in a mostly similar direction. In the United Kingdom, as across the OECD RTM sample as a whole, respondents who perceive injustice in the public benefit system (those who agree that "many people receive public benefits without deserving them") are less likely to call for redistribution (Figure 4.7, Panel C) and are generally less likely to say that they'd pay more in taxes for improved benefits and services (e.g. Online Annex Tables A4.19a.1-A4.19k.1, Model 6). Not surprisingly, people are less likely to ask for higher taxes and spending if they do not think the funds will be used fairly. At the same time, however, these respondents still often want support from government. Indeed, all else equal, respondents who not agree that they receive their fair share of benefits, who believe others receive benefits they do not deserve, and who do not feel listened-to by government all express stronger (not weaker) calls for more social and economic support from government (Figure 4.7, Panel A), albeit with associations in the United Kingdom falling just short of statistical significance at the 5% level.

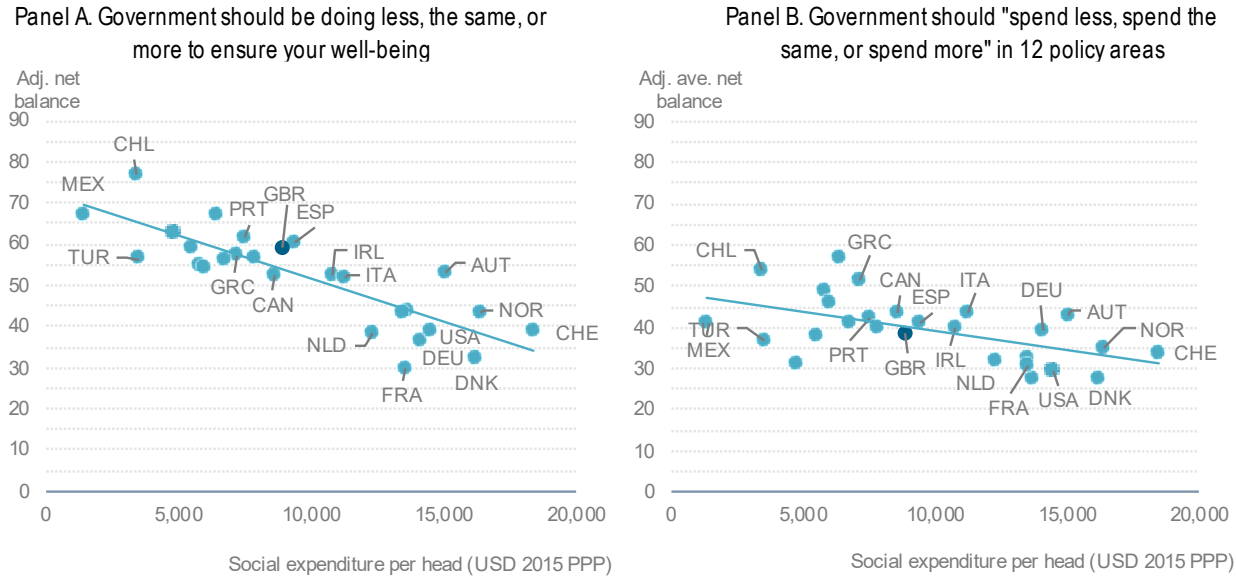
Current policy, levels of inequality, and the wider economic environment may all shape calls for support and redistribution

Calls for additional government support are stronger in countries where existing support is limited...

Links between current policy structures and preferences for future policy are known to be complex (Box 4.2) (Busemeyer, Abrassart and Nezi, 2021[15]; van Oorschot et al., 2022[36]) but evidence from Risks That Matter suggests that at the most basic level, people often want more support from government when they live in countries with comparatively slim social protection systems. Leaving aside the different potential feedback mechanisms, and even after controlling for population composition and GDP per capita, country comparison suggests that respondents in countries that spend less on social issues tend to call more strongly for additional support from government (Figure 4.9, Panel A; r = -0.84; Online Annex Table A4.17.1, Model 11) as well as, to a lesser extent, for additional spending on social policies (Figure 4.9, Panel B, r = -0.56; Online Annex Table A4.18s.1, Model 11). Calls for both support and spending also tend to be stronger in countries where benefits are less tightly targeted towards the poor (Online Annex Table A4.17.1- A4.18s.1, Models 17 and 18).

Figure 4.9. Calls for government support fall as social spending increases

Social expenditure (public and mandatory private) per head (USD 2015 PPP), (adjusted) net balance of responses to the question "Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?", and (adjusted) average net balance of responses when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas



Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.17.1-A4.18s.1, Model 11). Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. Social expenditure (public and mandatory private) per head is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on total social expenditure per head refer to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

For the United Kingdom, current spending is likely one factor feeding into policy preferences. Box 4.2 discusses how demand for spending and redistribution has grown in the United Kingdom as a response to declining social spending and increased conditionality over the past decade or so (Cooper and Burchardt, 2022[16]; Curtice, 2021[17]; Curtice and Scholes, 2023[18]). More generally, even in the absence of recent cuts, respondents in a country with a mid-sized, tightly targeted system like the UK's (Chapter 1) might be expected to express a relatively strong preference for expanded support.

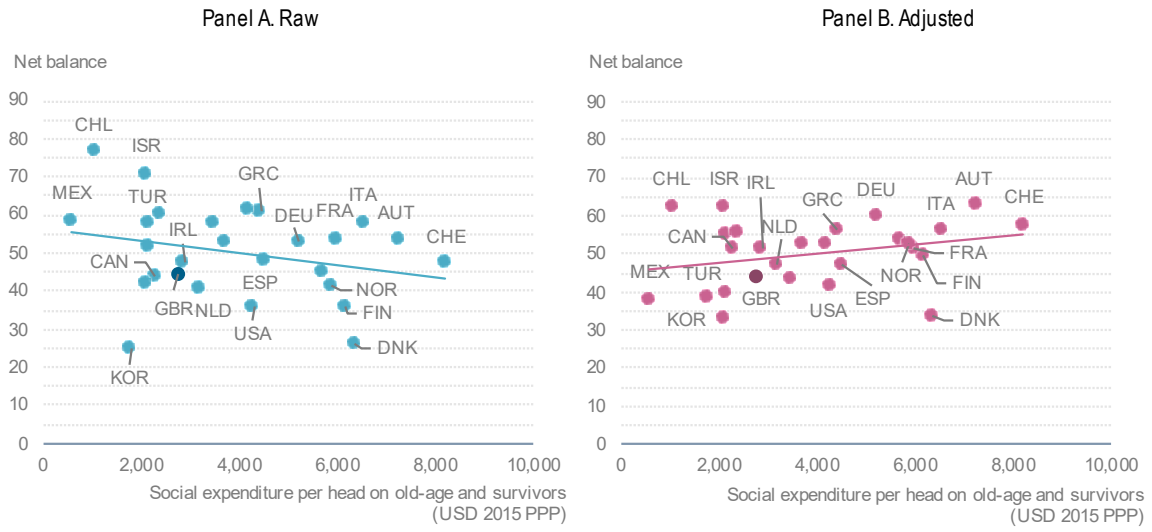
… but low spending in a given policy area is not always matched by strong demands for more spending

Links between current spending and preferences for future spending in specific areas are mixed. In some (but not all) areas, respondents are more likely to call for expansion when they live in a country that spends relatively little in that area. For example, respondents are more likely to say they'd like increased spending on housing when they live in countries that spend comparatively little on housing supports (Online Annex Table A4.18f.1, Model 20), increased spending on employment supports when they live in countries that spend comparatively little on active labour market policies (Online Annex Table A4.18c.1, Model 20), and increased spending on unemployment when they live in countries that spend comparatively little on unemployment supports – although notably not in the United Kingdom (Box 4.3). However, this is not the case everywhere, and in several policy areas (e.g. disability supports, health services, and pensions), calls for expansion seem largely uncorrelated with current spending (Online Annex Table A4.18h.1, Model 20; Online Annex Table A4.18g.1, Model 20; Online Annex Table A4.18i.1, Model 20). On pensions, for example, calls for more spending are often not much stronger in countries that spend relatively little (e.g. Mexico, Türkiye) than in some countries that spend comparatively large amounts (e.g. Austria, France, Italy) (Figure 4.10, Panel A; r = -0.27), especially after controlling for population composition and GDP per capita (Figure 4.10, Panel B; r = 0.27).

In the United Kingdom, there is little to suggest that respondents prioritise areas in which the country spends comparatively little. Indeed, when put in comparative perspective, respondents provide a certain degree of implicit support for the current distribution of spending across policy areas. Take pensions for example: relative to other OECD countries, the United Kingdom spends comparatively little on public pensions (Chapter 1) and yet support for increased spending, while substantial, remains lower than in many other countries (see Figure 4.3 and Figure 4.4). This possibly reflects the comparatively widespread view that pensioners' standards of living are not the responsibility of government alone (Hadler, Eder and Mayer, 2019[37]), as well as the relatively moderate role played by the public pension system and the UK's strong reliance on private pensions (OECD, 2023[38]). In a similar vein, the United Kingdom stands out among OECD countries as spending little on unemployment support (Chapter 1) but increased spending on unemployment continues to come bottom of the UK priority list (Figure 4.3 and Figure 4.4; see Box 4.3). Health care remains top of the list despite it already being the largest item in UK public social expenditure (see Chapter 1).

Figure 4.10. Calls for spending on pensions are often not much stronger in countries that spend relatively little than in countries that spend relatively large amounts

Social expenditure (public and mandatory private) per head on old-age and survivors (USD 2015 PPP) and net balance of responses to the question "Thinking about the taxes you and your family might have to pay and the benefits you and your family might receive, would you like to see the government spend less, spend the same, or spend more in each of the following areas? Old-age pensions", before and after adjusting for population composition and GDP per capita



Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.18i.1, Model 20). Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). Social expenditure is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on social expenditure refer to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

People want more support and more redistribution when they live in countries where concern about inequality is more widespread

Away from policy, a range of additional economic and political factors are thought to play at least some role in shaping preferences for social protection (van Oorschot et al., 2022[36]; Mengel and Weidenholzer, 2023[39]).

Economic inequality, and its link with the demand for redistribution, is one of the most widely studied factors (van Oorschot et al., 2022[36]). Early work on the topic argued that calls for redistribution should rise with inequality, largely because the average voter will have more to gain from redistribution when they live in a less equal society (Meltzer and Richard, 1981[40]; Jæger, 2013[41]; Schmidt-Catran, 2016[42]). This so-called "Meltzer-Richard" model has received only mixed empirical support, in part because several high-inequality societies (including the United Kingdom) continue to vote for governments that redistribute comparatively little (Moene and Wallerstein, 2001[43]; Kenworthy and McCall, 2007[44]; Iversen and Soskice, 2009[45]; Mengel and Weidenholzer, 2023[39]). More recent work, including by the OECD (2021[29]), has built on Meltzer and Richard by suggesting that it is not inequality itself that matters for policy preferences, but rather the public's perceptions of (and preferences for) inequality: changes in objective inequality are

associated with changes in demand for redistribution, but only as long as changes in peoples' image of and concern about inequality move in the same direction (OECD, 2021[29]; Gimpelson and Treisman, 2018[46]).

Results from Risks That Matter 2022 support the argument that preferences for redistribution may be linked to public perceptions of and concern about inequality. Calls for spending and redistribution are no more or less frequent in countries with higher levels of income inequality (Online Annex Tables A4.17.1-A4.20.1, Model 9) but are more common in countries where concerns about inequality are stronger (Figure 4.12; Online Annex Tables A4.17.1-A4.20.1, Model 19): people in countries (like Chile and Portugal) where large numbers believe differences in income are "too high" tend to express stronger support for increased spending on social policies (Figure 4.12, Panel A; r = 0.52) and increased taxes on the rich (Figure 4.12, Panel B; r = 0.54). In the United Kingdom, income inequality is comparatively high (OECD, 2024[47]) but concern about inequality (as measured by the share that believes differences in income are "too high") is only moderate (OECD, 2023[48]). Calls for redistribution are stronger than might be expected for a country with its level of concern (Figure 4.12, Panel B).

Box 4.3. Why do Brits not want more spending on unemployment benefits?

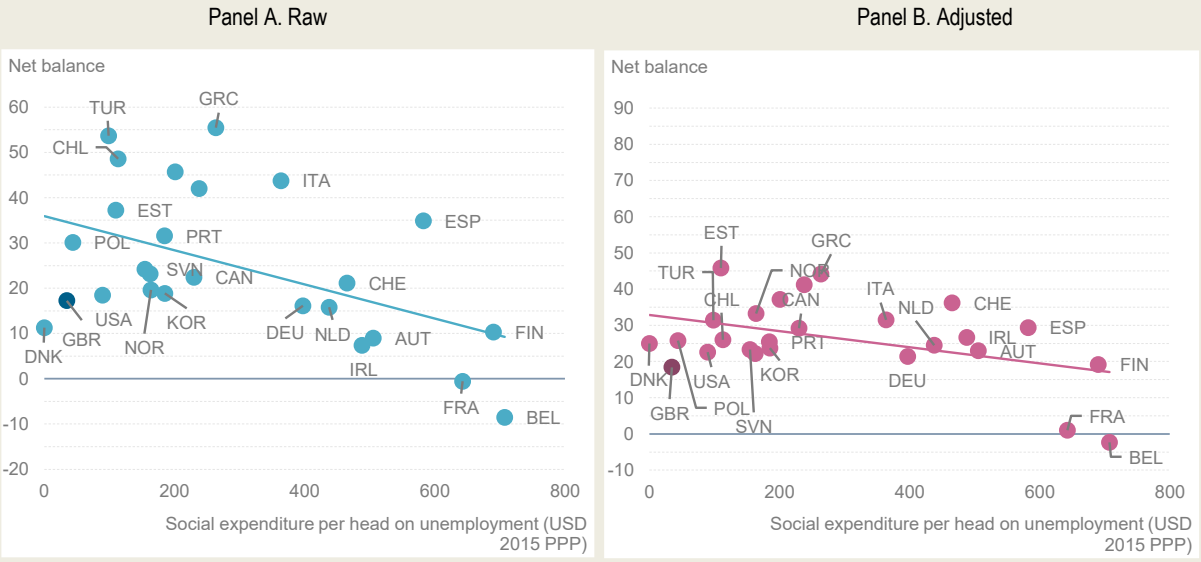
It is not because of confidence or satisfaction that unemployment benefit sits bottom of the UK's policy priority list. As discussed in Chapter 3 of this report, unemployment benefits are comparatively limited in the United Kingdom, and many Brits lack confidence in the government's ability to provide adequate income support if they were to lose their job. Many (although not all) countries that spend relatively little on unemployment benefits (e.g. Chile, Türkiye) have comparatively large numbers of respondents calling for increased spending (Figure 4.11). Only a minority do so in the United Kingdom.

One possible reason relates to the perceived deservingness of unemployment benefit claimants in the United Kingdom. Attitudes towards deservingness vary between countries and across different types of recipients, with the unemployed often ranking towards the bottom (van Oorschot, 2006[49]). Building out from van Oorschot's influential CARIN (Control, Attitude, Reciprocity, Identity and Need) deservingness model, several studies have found that solidarity with the unemployed is frequently weaker than with other groups, such as the elderly or people with disabilities (van Oorschot, 2006[49]; Roosma, van Oorschot and Gelissen, 2014[50]). This is particularly the case in the United Kingdom, where at least until recently comparatively many people have considered misuse of unemployment benefits to be wide-spread, unemployed people's standards of living to be comparatively high, and the government to have comparatively little responsibility for ensuring the unemployed have access to a "reasonable" income (Applica sprl et al., 2020[5]; van Oorschot et al., 2022[36]).

There are signs that attitudes to unemployment benefit recipients are softening in the United Kingdom (see also Box 4.2). Baumberg Geiger et al. (2023[20]) show that the share of the population who agree that "most people on the dole [unemployment benefit] are fiddling [cheating]" has almost halved since the mid 2000s, while the share that agree that "most unemployed could find a job if they wanted one" has fallen too. Support for increases to unemployment benefit has almost doubled over the same period. Nonetheless, in relative terms support for expanded unemployment benefits remains low, both in comparison to other countries and in comparison to other policy areas inside the United Kingdom.

Figure 4.11. Countries that spend little on unemployment benefits often have large numbers calling for increased spending – but not in the United Kingdom

Social expenditure per head on unemployment (USD 2015 PPP) and net balance of responses to the question "Thinking about the taxes you and your family might have to pay and the benefits you and your family might receive, would you like to see the government spend less, spend the same, or spend more in each of the following areas? Unemployment supports", before and after adjusting for population composition and GDP per capita

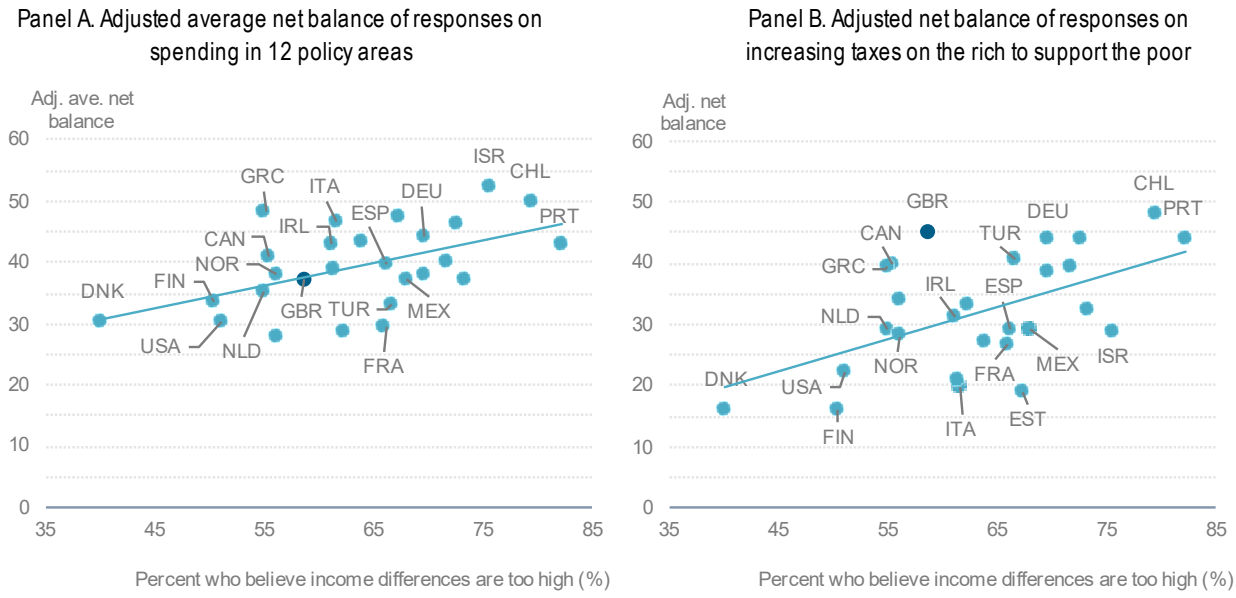


Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.18d.1, Model 20). Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). Social expenditure is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". Data on social expenditure refer to 2019. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only.

Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and OECD Social Expenditure Database, https://www.oecd.org/en/data/datasets/social-expenditure-database-socx.html.

Figure 4.12. Calls for spending and redistribution are higher in countries where concerns about inequality are stronger

Percent who believe that differences in income are too high or far too high, (adjusted) average net balance of responses when asked whether the government should "spend less, spend the same, or spend more" in 12 policy areas, and (adjusted) net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?"

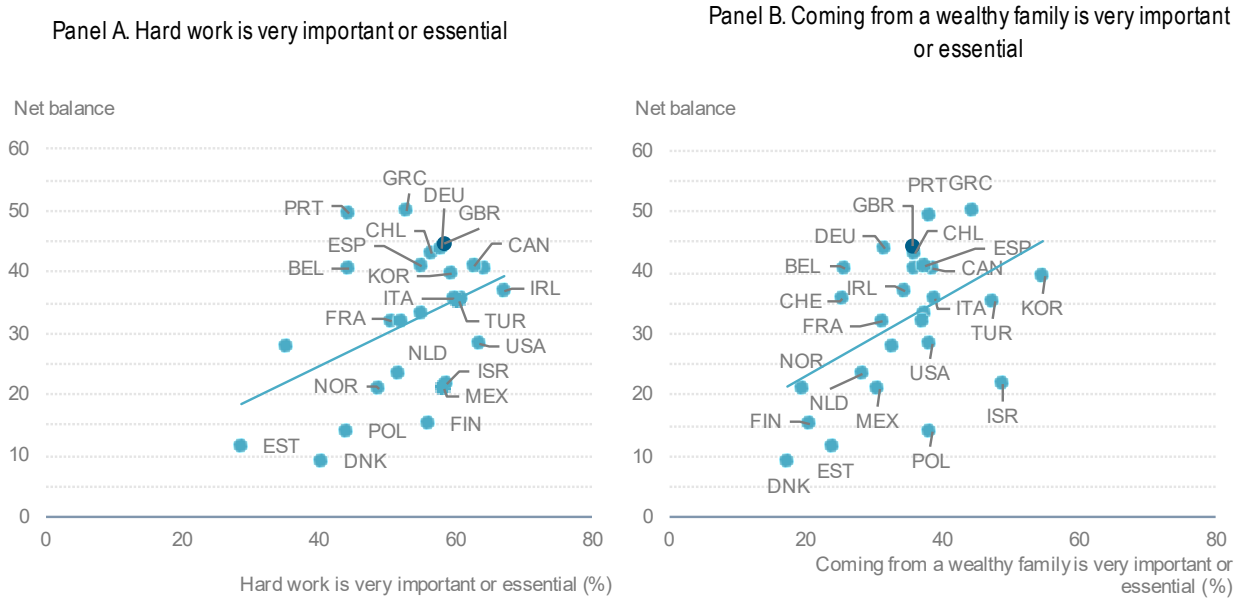


Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.18.1 and A4.20.1, Model 19). Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt). Concern about inequality is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. Panel A: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Panel B: Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Definitely no" (-100), "No" (-50), "Neutral" (0), "Yes" (50) and "Definitely yes" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on data and methods.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and (OECD, 2023[51]), "Working hand in hand? Exploring people's views of the role of different actors in fighting inequality", https://doi.org/10.1787/dbd54315-en.

A related factor is social mobility and beliefs about the determinants of (or barriers to) social and economic success. By and large, research finds that support for redistribution tends to be weaker when people believe more strongly in meritocracy, and stronger when people believe that success in life comes from factors beyond individual control (Fong, 2001[24]; Alesina, Stantcheva and Teso, 2018[52]; OECD, 2021[29]). In this instance, results from Risks That Matter are only partly consistent with the literature. Using the perceived importance of hard work as a proxy for beliefs in meritocracy (Mijs, 2021[53]; Mijs et al., 2022[54]; OECD, 2021[29]), results suggest that demand for redistribution tends to be stronger (not weaker) in countries where people more often believe in meritocracy (Figure 4.13, Panel A; r = 0.42; Online Annex Table A4.20.1, Model 20). At the same time, and more in line with expectations, demand for redistribution also tends to be stronger in countries where people more often recognise structural inequalities (Figure 4.13, Panel B; r = 0.49; Online Annex Table A4.20.1, Model 21), as measured by the share that consider coming from a wealthy family as important for getting ahead in life (Mijs, 2021[53]; Mijs et al., 2022[54]; OECD, 2021[29]). Shaping both associations are a group of Nordic and Baltic countries (Denmark, Estonia, Finland, Latvia, Lithuania, and Norway) where beliefs in the importance of hard work, beliefs in the importance of a wealthy family, and demands for further redistribution are all comparatively low.

Figure 4.13. Demand for redistribution is higher (not lower) in countries where greater numbers believe hard work is central to getting ahead in life

Percentage who believe hard work is very important or essential for getting ahead in life, percentage who believe that coming from a wealthy family is very important or essential for getting ahead in life, and net balance of responses to the question "Should the government tax the rich more than they currently do in order to support the poor?"



Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.20.1, Models 20 and 21). Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Definitely no" (-100), "No" (-50), "Neutral" (0), "Yes" (50) and "Definitely yes" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Both panels use adjusted estimates accounting for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus GDP per capita. Percent believing hard work (coming from a wealthy family) is very important or essential is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.

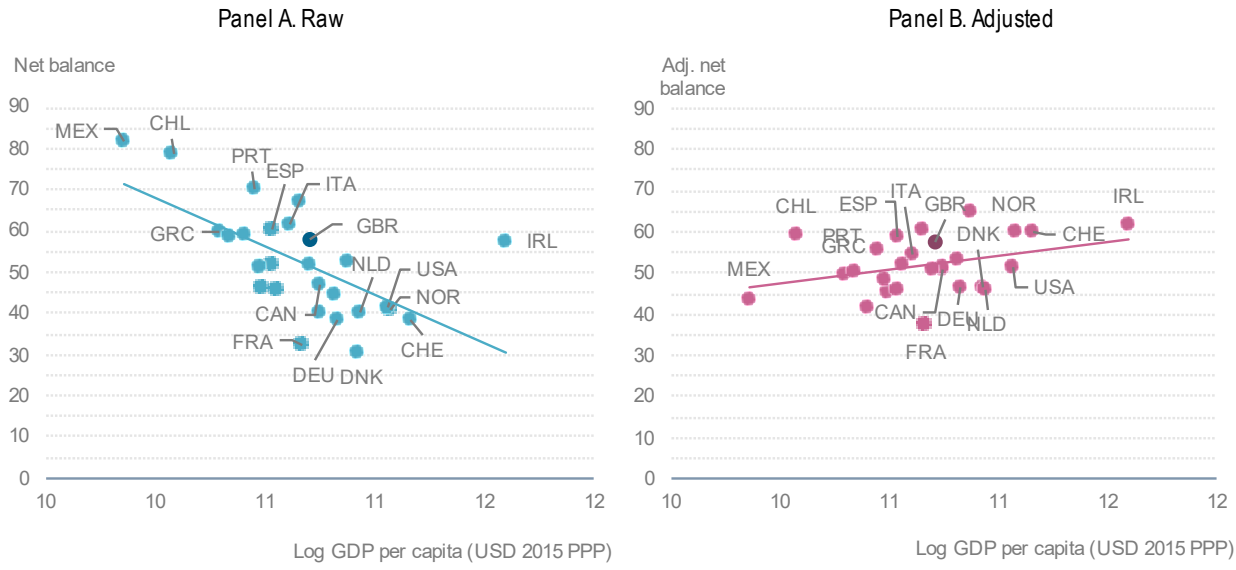
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html, and (OECD, 2023[48]), "Hard work, privilege or luck? Exploring people's views of what matters most to get ahead in life", https://doi.org/10.1787/e1903ab2-en.

Links with economic development are not clear, but economic (in)security may shape calls for support, spending and redistribution

In line with its role in shaping perceived risk (Chapter 2) and satisfaction with social protection (Chapter 3), economic development may also influence policy preferences (van Oorschot et al., 2022[36]). Looking across countries, respondents in less wealthy economies often issue the strongest calls for greater government support, and those in the wealthiest some of the weakest (Figure 4.14, Panel A; r = -0.63; Online Annex Table A4.17.1, Model 4), especially if Ireland is excluded as an outlier (Online Annex Table A4.17.1, Model 7; r = -0.79). However, this association may be driven by the fact that the OECD's wealthier economies often already have more expansive social protection systems: after controlling for public social expenditure, any correlation between GDP per capita and calls for government support disappears and if anything, reverses (Figure 4.14, Panel B; r = 0.36; Online Annex Table A4.17.1, Model 11).

Figure 4.14. Respondents in wealthy economies are less likely to call for more support, but this may be because their governments run more expansive social protection systems

Log GDP per capita (USD 2015 PPP) and net balance of responses to the question "Do you think the government should be doing less, about the same, or more to ensure your economic and social security and well-being?", before and after adjusting for population composition and public social expenditure per head



Note: Estimates based on results from multilevel mixed effect linear models (Online Annex Tables A4.17.1, Models 4 and 11). Net balance is calculated as the average of the responses "Much less" (-100), "Less" (-50), "About the same as now" (0), "More" (50) and "Much more" (100), and can range from -100 to 100. Adjusted estimates account for between-country differences in demographic- (sex, age, and parenthood) and basic socio-economic characteristics (educational attainment, employment status, and self-reported benefit receipt), plus public social expenditure per head. Log GDP per capita is controlled for but not included in the adjusted estimates. All estimates are post-hoc corrected for the share of respondents answering "Can't choose". For readability, data labels used for selected countries only. See Box 4.1 for question wording and Annex A for more detail on scale construction.
Source: OECD Secretariat estimates based on the OECD Risks That Matter Survey 2022, https://www.oecd.org/en/about/programmes/oecd-risks-that-matter-rtm-survey.html and OECD National Accounts, www.oecd.org/sdd/na/.

Independent of economic development, economic security and the experience of economic shocks can also shape attitudes (Margalit, 2019[55]) (Alesina and Giuliano, 2011[30]). As already noted in this chapter, individuals who have recently experienced financial shocks tend to be more supportive of government intervention and redistribution (Blekesaune, 2013[32]; Margalit, 2013[33]; Rehm, Hacker and Schlesinger, 2012[27]; Alesina and Giuliano, 2011[30]). The same applies at the country level, at least for redistribution: calls for increased taxes on the rich tend to be stronger in countries where larger numbers of respondents report a deterioration in their household finances in the past year (Online Annex Table A4.20.1, Model 5). Perceived insecurity may be important for the United Kingdom in particular, given the comparatively high share of UK respondents reporting deteriorating household finances over the previous year (Chapter 1).

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Attitudes Towards Social Risks and Social Protection in the United Kingdom

Insights from the OECD Risks that Matter Survey

Social spending has declined in the United Kingdom over the last decade or so, reflecting efforts to limit public spending in the wake of the financial crisis. Using data from the 2022 OECD Risks That Matter (RTM) Survey, a multi-country survey covering 27 OECD countries, this report examines perceptions of social risks and attitudes towards social protection in the United Kingdom. Results point to a country that feels relatively vulnerable to social risks, especially in comparison to several of its peers in the G7 and other wealthy OECD economies. Looking forward, there is strong support in the United Kingdom for an expansion of social protection. Results are consistent with evidence from UK sources that suggest attitudes in the United Kingdom have been shifting in favour of increased taxation, spending and redistribution.

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